A Change of Luck

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by fleurjaune (fleur_jaune)

Summary

Shadow Moth is thrown to be confronted by a woman in Chat Noir's place. It shouldn't really make a difference in his quest but he finds himself strangely drawn to her.

Meanwhile Nathalie Sancoeur is having a well deserved breakdown.

Chapter 1: Gabriel I

A flash of black catches the corner of his eye and Shadow Moth swiftly follows after. Perhaps leaving the lair today, leaving Nathalie safely at home while he ventures out to better control his sentimonster might yet pay dividends.

Yet the slight figure in the alley below him, well for a start isn't quite so slight. Taller than Chat Noir by a least a head and though her figure is neat it's undeniably feminine, with that black leather showcasing the curve of her behind despite her slim legs, and an even slimmer waist.

The hair is still just as wild as usual, if not wilder, but it's a dark mass hanging just below her chin just on the threshold between wavy and curly.

He's always preferred a sleeker look himself yet he can't deny that despite what he's fighting for a flurry of excitement stirs in his belly. This might be a chance for a little bit of fun. The little bit of amusement he needs in this long slog in pursuit of the Miraculous.

It changes things, having an adult opponent.

Careful that his descent is silent he creeps behind in pursuit of her, as she frantically seems to be looking for someone else. Ladybug he supposes. It's odd that she's not gone to fight his champions by herself but perhaps *this* Black Cat is a little more reticent than her predecessor.

Finally he's close enough that he's able to catch her with an arm around her waist, pulling her back against him. The warmth of her body can be felt despite the layers of clothes between them. Though hers admittedly do little to obscure the *shape* of her body.

Her hand immediately closes over his arm, and with a sharp press that doesn't quite tear through his sleeve shows her claws. "Let go of me."

He grabs her other arm to stop anything else she might do and inclines his head to speak directly into one of the green rimmed black cat ears extending up from her mask, "but my dear, we've only started to get acquainted."

From her startle he's right that they're not just for decoration.

Unfortunately enough he can't reach her ring without releasing one of his hands and chancing her fleeing, the way that every stiff muscle pressed up against him betrays that she wants to.

"Shadow Moth," she swallows, "I didn't think friendship was something you were particularly interested in."

He pulls her a little closer. "A man can get lonely."

Despite a little hitch in her breath that he treasures there's acid in her sneer as she says, "What, without Mayura?"

He allows himself a theatrical sigh, and ignores the very real emotion below it. Terrifying as seeing Nathalie put herself in harm's way was he can't deny that she'd felt even more like a bulwark of support preventing him from giving up once she'd made this her fight too by donning that Miraculous.

"I do seem to have a vacancy for a partner," he nuzzles in behind her ear and is rewarded with a shiver against him, "interested in filling it?"

She inhales sharply and then suddenly his foot distracts him a burst of agony as she drives her heel into it, and the shock apparently loosens his hold enough she manages to jab her elbow back between his ribs.

Swearing he releases her, apparently just in time as her heel swings up between his legs.

"And I thought we were getting on so *well,"* he complains, "but you're a vicious little thing aren't you? What a pity. "

That part he does actually mean. There's a certain emptiness inside at knowing that Emilie and Nathalie are depending on him to save them while this woman prances around with half of what he needs and *won't give it to him.*

It's enough to extinguish any embarrassment he might have felt about his behaviour towards her. He *has* to fight her. This is no worse and seems to throw her off, and there's a definite *glee* inside him at getting under her skin. Like it's some sort of payment for the obstacle she represents to him.

She turns back to him, hissing, "I've no interest in a man who finds woman interchangeable."

"Hmm," the temptation to antagonise her is irresistible, "but you and my dear Mayura have such a vital difference. Only one of you has the ring I need."

She steps back, "I promised Chat Noir to keep it from you."

"Where is he anyway? Not that I'm not feline," he grins, "quite delighted with the swap, but why would you promise him that. Aren't you a little old to be a fan?"

"That's none of your business," her hands curl, preparing to claw at him again, "and if I were you I'd run away."

Playing along with her little game, he holds out his hands, "And why's that?"

With a smirk she stalks towards him as their little game of predator and prey suddenly flips, "Because as you so *clearly* started I'm an adult, so," she reaches out towards his chest, "I'm not limited with the number of times I can use cataclysm."

Catching her wrist he stops her hand, "much as I'd enjoy your hands on me in other circumstances I'm sure you'll understand if I stop you right there."

They both stare at each other weighing up their opponent. Shadow Moth is larger and empowered by both the Butterfly and the Peacock, but both of those expect their wielder to

fight from a distance, unlike the natural destructiveness of the Cat.

He has a few tricks up his sleeve. It's not like Gabriel had no martial training before donning a Miraculous but something in the posture of the woman opposite him looks *trained* like Chat Noir never had.

A whack to the side of his head sends his ears ringing, and reminds him of the one definite advantage that…whatever her name is has over him.

She has a partner.

A partner with a yo-yo hard enough to leave a decent bruise at the side of his head that leaves him with a thudding pressure-pain at the side of his head that makes it hard to concentrate.

"Get his Miraculous," that infernal bug shouts. "It's two of us on one!"

But the Cat hesitates and he can't read what exactly is going on behind those inhuman green eyes, but there's *something.*

Then she calls up to Ladybug. "You need to stop the akuma. I'll handle him."

"But,"

A thunder cloud crosses the woman's face, as she commands the girl, "*Go.* He's laying waste to the city.*"*

Ladybug stumbles, clearly not used to her partner telling her what to do, and her eyes flick between them before her eyebrows meet in determination and she nods and runs off.

"I'm flattered you want to be alone with me," he smirks back at her.

She crosses her arms, apparently unimpressed, maintaining a neutral enough façade as she drones. "Maybe I'm just worried about you hitting on the teenager."

That does unsettle him a bit. Not least as her monotone doesn't quite work to hide the disquiet in her voice; like she believes he could do it. Shadow Moth is supposed to be the repository of all Gabriel's darkest deeds and thoughts, the textbook villain who shares none of Gabriel's qualms. But it's all for a *purpose.* All for Emilie, and intensified by the need to make Nathalie's endangering of herself for *his* wife and *his* cause worth it.

An accusation like that is a tarnish indeed on his shining purity of purpose.

"There are depths of villainy too deep even for me. Besides, how could I ignore someone as purrfect as you."

She massages her temples, but there's a flush to her cheeks. "Please don't do that. It's bad enough coming from Chat Noir."

"Someone has to provide the lack in his absence."

With a shake of her head she sighs, “you really are incorrigible.” Then looking up at the horizon she says, “Go home Shadow Moth.”

“I thought you were going to handle me?”

He casts his eye over once more compartmentalising both his appreciation and his assessment of her likely abilities. There’s a strange lack of fight in her. Which is even odder given how she does in fact seem to be genuinely angry.

“That seems dangerous for of us. Either of us could lose a Miraculous. I’m new to this after all, and you’re quite given to…failure.” Her voice is a knife wrapped in velvet.

The world seems to slow down for a minute, his heartbeat thuds dully in his chest, the damage Ladybug did to his head and the Cat to his foot pulsates in slow waves of hurt, and he’s suddenly desperate for Nathalie as the void of her absence feels almost physical.

She would know what to say in response. Would have some cutting remark ready to shut her down as she stood between them the way she had with reporters after Emilie’s, after they had to put Emilie in the casket.

Gabriel has always been inadequate in that regard. A funny enough thing when how usually he has no problem cutting anyone down to size. But all they have to do is mention Emilie, intimate her disappearance is his fault and he's drowning in guilt and can't find his way to the surface.

Because it is his fault really. He'd helped Emilie to find the Miraculous, encouraged her ideas about it, and then when she'd got sick he hadn’t stopped her. A better husband would have forced the issue, wouldn’t have let her drive herself almost to death but Gabriel had been unable to refuse her, to provoke that sad disappointment in Emilie’s eyes.

It’s a lesson he’s learnt from, and bears in mind everytime Adrien looks up with him with his oh-so-beseeching eyes.

And now he’s had all of that thrown back in his face by a woman who he’s been flirting with instead of fighting with.

He really is a terrible husband.

“That’s a low blow.” He mutters.

“I’m sorry,” she says and despite all odds he believes it, as she places her hand on his and seems to suck out his stress and self-recrimination with her gentle touch. It’s a feminine thing he thinks. Both Emilie and Nathalie have that talent. To make it all feel all right so long as they’re there with him.

But of course *she’s* not with him.

She’s fighting against him.

And how can she understand his cause with how he started it?

But still she looks at him like Nathalie does, and all he wants to do is to fall to her knees and cling to her thighs and beseech her intercession in his cause because some stupid part at the back of his brain wants to tell him she'd understand.

"Are you?"

"Go home." She squeezes his hand in reassurance, "and think about you *really* want to act like this with me."

Something rears up at him in irritation, that she'd take her heroic morals and pretend that the two of them are close enough to impose them on him. There is *nothing* Gabriel won't do for who he loves. Including seducing another woman. "You don't know me."

Her hair tumbles round in a shake of her head, "I don't think this is you. I think you're a better man than this. What are you doing this for?"

He stumbles back out of her hold as she strikes at the very thing he's been ignoring in this conversation. Emilie seems to hover in front of him. Just as golden as her portrait. But her eyes aren't narrowed in that tempest of fury she could muster. Instead they just look down at him sadly like the Virgin herself disappointed in humanity but still ever-ready to intercede on their behalf with her son.

"I can't tell you that," he continues to slowly back away from her.

"That's fair enough I suppose," she retreats backwards seeming similarly lost.

"Catwoman," he calls out after her, "I'll recall my amok. So you just have to deal with my akuma. Since you've been so nice to me and all."

Her eyes widen ever so slightly, that strange green "Thank you. and that's not my name. Though that does betray a few things on your part. You're hardly Batman are you?

"I have better luck with women," the devoted husband chuckles at the comparison to the eternal bachelor. "But what should I call you?"

She smiles and her teeth fairly glow in the dark with a Cheshire cat grin, "You'll have to discover that. I'm not sure I'm decided."

Chapter 2: Nathalie I

Nathalie falls to her knees as the transformation falls off. It had been dangerous to go back to the house transformed, but Adrien's been doing it as Chat Noir all this time with them none the wiser and she'd had no faith in her own ability to walk once she was just Nathalie again.

And indeed her head feels wrapped in cotton wool and her limbs feel bone-tired with a fatigue that's become all too familiar.

The bed is right there.

But she can't quite reach it as her limbs refuse to respond and instead leave her tumbling to the floor.

"Hey lady," Plagg's tone is laughing 'til he must see her, "*lady,* are you ok?"

No. In no way shape or form am I OK.

That's what she means to say. Instead what she manages is a gasp for air betraying the pain in her ribcage.

"Right you are *not* OK." The Kwami floats in front of her oddly hesitant. "Should I call the kid or?"

"No," she manages to gasp, "he can't know. Can't know that I'm,"

Plagg flies right up to her face in something that looks like a threat but doesn't quite make it over the barrier to being one. "Is that a command?"

"Yes it is," she says with a calm that she doesn't feel at all but is mustered from years of professionalism, "As much as you can't tell anyone but Adrien who I am, you can't tell him *how* I am either."

Concern makes his body seem to curve in on itself. "You're setting him up for a fall."

"Do you think I don't know that?" She tries to ineffectually push herself up and fails. It's fine. She'll just lie here for a bit. It's fine.

Strangely despite the total weakness In every cell in her body she seems to have lost the urge to cough. Maybe her lungs can't muster the strength to do that either.

Or maybe the Black Cat Miraculous is effecting her damaged self differently to the Peacock. She can't pretend that she thinks it a good idea to try using another Miraculous after one had already condemned her to weeks of bedrest. There's a reason that Gabriel chose to wield both the Butterfly and the Peacock himself rather than letting her try the Butterfly, never mind the newly fixed Peacock.

Then again she *should* have never used the Black Cat Miraculous at all. Should have ran to Gabriel with it the moment Adrien had pressed it into her hands in panic blabbling about Chat Noir not being able to go out with a broken leg and *please* Nathalie, Ladybug needs help and you can't tell father.

But Adrien had looked at her with such *trust* and she'd transformed and suddenly it was like she could breathe clearly since the first time she'd put the Peacock on, and she'd told herself that she'd just use it as a way to get Ladybug's trust, and then she could present Gabriel with both Miraculous.

And hopefully with the fulfilment of all his dreams in his hands he wouldn't think to question whatever story she came up with for how exactly she'd got hold of the Black Cat Miraculous in the first place and why she hadn't told him.

Then ideally in the world he'd create Adrien never would have been Chat Noir and the relationship between father and son could go on, whole and unbroken, and steadied by Emilie's deft hands.

Plagg broke her out of her thoughts. "Are you seriously just going to lie there because you don't want the kid to know you're ill?"

"He knows I'm ill," she corrects him. "Surely you don't want him to feel guilty and…"

"Urgh. Try and take the ring back himself. I get it."

"Besides help's on its way."

Gabriel's just lost a battle. He'll be here to complain soon enough. It's almost a routine at this point.

Plagg turns to look at the door. "What? You know something I don't?"

"Something like that," she half gasps and half laughs and then as she hears Gabriel on the stairs panic makes her voice harsh, "You have to stay hidden from Mr Agreste. That's an order."

"Bossy," Plagg frowns, "you people used to worship me you know. But I was going to do that anyway."

"And you can't tell Adrien anything of what we say here."

That provokes a grimace. "Gross. You better get me some good cheese if I'm going to have to sit through that mushy stuff. It's bad enough with the boy."

"Really not the problem." She mutters as she hears the door open.

"Nathalie I," Gabriel starts and then there's a pause as he must take in her apparent absence, "*Nathalie?"*

The footsteps echo against the hardwood floor as he abandons any attempt at his usual stoicism. Not that it usually lasts long in here anyway.

Then warm firm hands are round her shoulders, and Gabriel's staring down at her with naked concern shining from those eyes that betray everything he tries to hide inside.

"Oh my Nathalie what has happened to you?"

"Too weak." She manages back, while she tries to keep a blush off her face as her body becomes uncomfortably warm as his hands move down her to better pick her up, and the memory of Shadow Moth pressed up against her back, his larger size meaning he almost seemed to encircle her, suddenly flares back to her mind.

He frowns, unware of her traitorous thoughts, and how her insides squirm as he lifts her onto the bed.

"Where's your exoskeleton?"

"Thought I was OK without it. Apparently I was wrong," she attempts to smile.

It doesn't bring any levity to Gabriel's face, "Nathalie." His forehead drops against hers and she's pinned under his fierce stare as that passion and determination he uses to fuel himself in his fight to save Emilie is suddenly turned on her, "you have to wear it. You're the only person I can rely on. I *need* you. And that means I need you to look after yourself."

Feeling stupid, like his regard has melted her brain with its heat, she reminds him, "I know. I'll always be there for you Gabriel."

"Do it for yourself too," a sadly familiar furrow forms in his forehead, "what I've let happen to you is the only part of this I regret."

His hand brushes against her cheekbone, so very soft despite the roughness and callouses of his fingers, leaving tingles in its wake.

A heat coils inside her as she imagines the leather of Shadow Moth's gloves in its place. Of what he might have done had she not stopped him.

Taken the ring, she reminds herself, that's what all this is for.

Emilie is the woman he loves. She's the only one he'd want to hold like that. Nathalie as the Black Cat was just…just a ploy.

"It'll be worth it when you win." She reminds him.

Gabriel sighs and sits up. "Sometimes I wonder when that will be, and in the meantime everything else is spiralling out of its place. Your health. The business. *Adrien's* health. He's broken his leg playing rugby and I didn't even know he played rugby. How can I keep him safe when I don't know what he's doing or where he is?"

“You’re a busy man. You can’t be expected to watch Adrien’s location all the time. That’s my job. And it’s my fault that I never checked what sports Adrien was doing at school.”

Even if she’s fairly sure that there was no rugby involved at all, given that would have been more likely to result in a broken collarbone or nose rather than a leg, and more likely Adrien had probably had some misfortune as Chat Noir after the Ladybug cure had already done its job and couldn’t help him.

With a shake of his head Gabriel dismisses her apology. “You’re still not well. Though I will be demanding his school excuses him from anything similar in future. I’ve had to cancel two photoshoots. Though admittedly between you and Adrien I’m starting to think I should just give in and design a line of crutches and supports.”

“It would be a new market sir.”

“Hmm. Perhaps,” he sighs again, “but this trying and failing. It’s all getting so monotonous Nathalie. Though a new piece has entered the board.”

The world slows down as Nathalie’s mind frantically draws up a flowchart of the repercussions of faking that she has no idea what he’s talking about, or pretending she only knew of her alter ego’s appearance on the news.

“The new holder of the Black Cat Miraculous,” she says steadily, after what feels like an eternity even though it most have only been seconds. “I saw on the news. Though I didn’t manage to get much information.”

“Exactly,” Gabriel smirks, and belatedly she’s suddenly furious with him for his actions out there.

It was only a ploy to get close to her, she reminds herself but Gabriel’s supposed to love Emilie. To be faithful *to Emilie.* Nathalie has staked her own life on the idea that his wife is the only thing that can make Gabriel happy again. That Gabriel, unlike her own father, or any of the men she’s know is a man devoted enough to his wife to fight against death itself for her.

He’s not meant to be the sort of man that goes out and flirts with another woman. He’s not supposed to *enjoy* flirting with another woman the way that gleam in his eyes right now betrays that he does.

It’s a very different sort of heat that rises in her now as Gabriel announces, “and I think she likes me.”

“What.” The flatness in her voice is no performance. *This* is not a situation she ever thought she’d be in.

Though at least it shows that Gabriel is unlikely to figure out that was *her* when despite the Miraculous on his chest he’s never betrayed any sign of any awareness of her feelings. Which is all for the best. She’d be mortified obviously. It’s good he respects her well enough to

deliberately not prey on her love for him. After all it's not like he'd even return them. Not like he'd ever look her way. Not like he's attracted to her.

Unless apparently she doesn't look like herself.

Perhaps, and the thought makes her wish she had those claws again so she could vent some of her rage by ripping into the pillows, it's the green eyes.

"You wouldn't have seen it on the news but…she let me go." The a tinge of marvelling in his bafflement, "and anyway I can tell when a woman is attracted to me."

It takes Nathalie some effort not to roll her eyes, and she can't quite keep the dryness out of her voice when she says. "Can you?"

"Oh she was certainly affected when I had her in my arms." A plan is forming in Gabriel's head, she can see it, and her instincts are screaming at her that she needs to stop this now. That is going to be a worse mistake than that time he decided he wanted an ice rink for a catwalk. "I'm going to have to seduce her."

"*Sir?"*

She's embarrassed by how much of a shriek she makes.

Gabriel draws back a little, seeming equally shocked, but it must affect him at least a little from how he doesn't meet her eyes.

"I realise it sounds bad. It's not that I mean to cheat on Emilie. Hopefully it won't get that far."

Never mind hopefully. Nathalie won't let it. She's not going to become his mistress in a secret even from himself when she's so far successfully pushed any guilt she has at her feelings for him into working to get his wife back.

"It sounds like you're going to have to do *something*."

"All pretence. But don't you see, if I can throw her off enough to get the ring, or confuse her loyalty and bring her over to us, or get her to reveal her identity, then we'll have one of the Miraculous jewels we need."

Nathalie could stop this right now by giving him the ring he hasn't yet noticed on her finger.

Then Gabriel says, "I'll need your help of course."

The bottom of her stomach drops out. "You need my help to seduce…"

"Panthera," Gabriel delivers each syllable with a self-satisfied smack of his lips. "That's what they're calling her. A fitting name. But yes, I'll need your feminine perspective. It's been a long time since I courted Emilie,"

"Mme. Agreste said she made the first move."

“Details. And I approached her first, even if it was just as a model.”

“I don’t think this is a good idea sir.”

“What?”

“We’ve other plans. Other ideas. There’s no reason to debase yourself doing *this*.”

“I’m capitalising on a new opportunity. And I’d hardly think that.”

“By flirting with a pretty woman? What do you think Mme.Agreste would think of that? Surely you can’t think she’d condone it? Gabriel. Please. Think about this.”

But bringing up Emilie was a mistake. She can see that as his expression hardens and he stands up. Flint sparking in his eyes.

“People have *died* from my akumas Nathalie. Miraculous Ladybug brings them back but I’ve already made myself the blackest of men for Emilie’s sake. I’ll do anything to save her. And yes that includes going as far as I have to with Panthera.”

Once she’d been used to Gabriel’s beratement. Used to weathering his anger. Used to not speaking up or making any suggestions.

But that’s changed. Now she’s become accustomed to being able to calm him, to being the exception to his rages, to not quite being his partner, not quite being his co-parent and Adrien is still uneasy territory for her, but to having her contributions *valued.*

And why shouldn’t she?

Isn’t she his Mayura?

Isn’t she dying for him?

Isn’t she lying to him only because she wants to save him from himself?

Only for him to turn around and do *this.* To twist everything they’re done to something tawdry. To fill her mind with images of their limbs entwined as he tries to pull that ring off her finger.

She’s a cornered animal, and it’s half rage half self-defence, when she flings out, “you’re just justifying. You *want* an excuse to screw another woman. Forget about Panthera. You’re better than this.”

“How *dare* you,” Gabriel’s lip curls, “I think you’ve forgotten your place Mlle. Sancoeur.”

It’s a clear demotion from Nathalie and they both know it. And what’s worst is they also both know she’s just nudged him into fixing on this ridiculous plan.

Plagg reappears by her side the moment he disappears. “So. Paris’ foremost mockery of a father is Shadow Moth. He’s doing it to get his wife back. And my new holder is Mayura.

And also you're in love with him, and he's just decided to seduce you."

A damming summary indeed. Nathalie rolls over and screams into her pillow.

Then a moment later there's a slam of her door, and a glass put down on her side table with a thump of ill-grace.

"Here," Gabriel says gruffly, "I forgot to ensure you took your medication. Whatever your… problems with insubordination unnecessary martyrdom isn't a good look on anyone."

She'd guess it was Nooroo who reminded him. Even healed Duusu is still a little scatter-brained.

"Thank you sir," she mumbles as she gulps down the water and pills, "and I'm sorry. I didn't mean to diminish your loyalty to Emilie I just…."

There's a slight loosening of tension in his jaw. "Had a bit of a shock. I realise my plan is a little out there. And Panthera is a very attractive woman. But I promise this isn't just for my own selfish pleasure."

"I understand sir."

"Good. Your assistance will be
invaluable."

Once Gabriel leaves the room Plagg announces. "Lady. There is something very very wrong with you. Also you owe me the largest wheel of camembert possible for keeping mum about this."

Chapter 3: Plagg I

As a rule Plagg doesn't really go in for introspection. There's stuff he's done and stuff he hasn't done. There's stuff he can't do and stuff he can do. And short of combining with Tikki there's nothing he can do to change any of that.

He's not Fluff or Sass. Time runs linearly for him. And millennia is a long time for regrets and second guessing to build up over something he can't change, and couldn't have even chosen to have done otherwise in the moment because he's bound by the forces that tie him to his Miraculous.

So what's done is done. He hadn't stopped Adrien from thrusting his Miraculous into his caretaker's hands because once the boy took the ring off there was nothing he could do, and besides Ladybug needed aid right that second. He hadn't acted quickly enough to cataclysm his true holder's, because he refuses to think of Nathalie that way, father once he figured he was Hawk Moth because it's not like he *could* have in her hands. So it is what it is.

Not that Plagg particularly had any compunctions about the idea of destroying Gabriel Agreste before he'd known he was Hawk Moth. He's killed before and he'll kill again. It's what destruction *does*. Tears something apart for creation to re-assemble in a brand new way. The dance he and Tikki have done together since before they *were* Plagg and Tikki. Since before they had their Miraculous, when they soared through the vast abyss of space.

Still he's grown attached enough to this place to be wary of using his powers unfettered. He's had the time to become quite a connoisseur of cheeses and to have seen some of his favourites disappear with the passage of time, as they fall out of fashion, or as tradition of making it is lost with its people, or even as the grass eaten by the animal providing the milk has changed. He doesn't plan to accidentally lose Camembert by destroying Gabriel Agreste for not being there for his son.

Unless the man gives him stronger ammunition to hate him of course, but until the scales are flipped that heavily Plagg isn't going to chance that things will come up his way. Gabriel Agreste isn't worth losing the country around him. Or he isn't *yet* anyway.

Unfortunately no one else in the house shares Plagg's feelings. Neither on the fact that this world would be rather better off minus one Gabriel Agreste since both Adrien and Nathalie inexplicably seem to want the man in their lives, or the fact that it's not worth worrying about what's done.

"It's just," Adrien bites his lip, "do you think I did the wrong thing by giving the ring to Nathalie?"

Does Plagg think Adrien made a mistake giving the ring to Mayura?

Yes.

But also. With everything he's seen. Perhaps not. Perhaps Adrien has stumbled into a way out of this for all of them.

Besides he can't tell Adrien *that* part. Nathalie won't let him. So it's not something to feel guilty about.

"Eh, she seems to be coping," for a certain definition of that that seems to include a lot of screaming into her pillow. "And anyway I told you. I can't heal that leg of yours. I'm not Tikki."

"But," Adrien is pacing on his crutches now, "she's *ill.* Like half the time she uses that robot to walk. How can you transform *her?*"

"That's different," because it's *magic,* "I'm not healing anything with her," not that she doesn't need it, but all Plagg can do is collapse some of those corrupted magical channels in her body which will give it a chance to recover at least, "just giving her a bit of a boost, like I give you. Unless I missed something and you can jump off buildings normally?"

"I mean usually I *can* jump from pretty high," Adrien gestures at his rock wall as he collapses onto the bed, and Plagg stiffens to attention, waiting for the thrum in the vibrations of the universe that suggests he's done further damage to his fracture but thankfully the kid seems fine, "but yeah I guess that's true. Still. I don't like it."

"Hey, I miss you too kid," Plagg flies down, to nuzzle against Adrien's face, and then aware that's a bit too affectionate for his reputation adds, "Nathalie won't keep a cheese fridge in her room. She just tells me to go to yours."

"She probably wants her privacy." Adrien says.

"Maybe," Plagg agrees noncommittally, but yeah she probably *does* want to keep whatever her new secret plan is for solving this secret from him given she *knows* he won't agree with anything that includes making the Wish. Been there. Done that. Lived through the unforeseen consequences. Not planning to let anything like that happen to his Adrien.

And maybe even Nathalie, who despite being a villain, lacking backbone where it matters, and having the worst taste in men Plagg's seen in 8 centuries, even if he was sleeping in the Miracle Box for some of them, is kind of starting to grow on him.

Totally unrelated to her having introduced him to cheeses he'd not yet heard obviously.

Course with her it's equally likely that she wants the privacy to make mushy faces at Hawk Agreste, or Gabriel Moth or whatever he ought to call him now, without Plagg making gagging faces after.

He'd do it over his shoulder if he was bold enough but he's not stupid enough to let the man catch sight of him.

Nathalie might hold back out of, mostly embarrassment for the whole situation really, but also plus a little love for Adrien but the boy's father will not. That Plagg's sure of, and it's a

real pity because apart from Adrien deserving better it also takes the fun out of the whole thing.

Suddenly Adrien makes a face, "you *are* giving her privacy right Plagg?"

"Yeah, yeah," he brushes it off as he phases into Adrien's cheese store to grab some camembert.

His wielder is sitting up looking as serious as Plagg's ever seen him. Not *sad* in that way that Plagg hates, the way he does when he looks at that picture of his mother sometime, or when Tikki's chosen apparently forgets *his* is an actual person with his own problems and not just a joke machine she can rely on to back her up when she needs it. But *serious.* Set on something like its life and death that the woman who schedules every second of his life gets time alone for *hers*.

Adrien shoulders set back as he sits as straight as he can with the bottom of his leg in a cast, "I mean it Plagg. It's not like you can be in there when she's changing like you do with me, and never *ever* go into her bathroom like you did that one time I was showering."

Plagg rolls his eyes, "I thought you were over that."

How was *he* to know that humanity was going through one of it's "bathing is private thing" moments?

"I *am,"* Adrien's doesn't sound like he is but Plagg refrains from pointing this out, "but that's not the point. The point is you shouldn't be around when Nathalie's undressed."

"You don't care."

"That's *different.*"

"Why?"

"I'm a guy. And a model."

"OK so, you *do* know I'm not human right? Not really into your whole reproductive thing."

"Ew Plagg," he dodges the pillow thrown at his head.

"Anyway I don't know why you're bothering *me.* I'm here aren't I? It's your dad you should worry about. He's always dropping in there unannounced."

"Uh," Adrien blinks, and then contrary to Plagg's stored knowledge of human behaviour, which admittedly was less than it probably should have been for how long he'd been around, his boy grins, "he *does?*"

There's something more to that grin on his holder's face. Plagg is a Kwami not an actual cat, and *yet,* that sudden sharpening of the Adrien's eyes looks like it ought to belong on Chat Noir's instead, belongs to a being who's scented his prey and is ready to pounce in a way that Plagg instinctively knows.

“You gonna tell me why what’s a good thing?”

“Look, I know Father said there was nothing between him and Nathalie when I asked, but maybe I wasn’t wrong. Maybe he was just in denial. I mean, he’s not very good with emotions. It makes *sense.*”

Plagg has to swallow his amusement at the irony of *Shadow Moth,* exploiting of any Parisien’s strong feelings, being bad with emotions. Not that it wasn’t true but it was a much less enjoyable thing to swallow than a good brie.

“Again, *why* is that a good thing?”

“Because,” Adrien’s wildly gesturing, “if Father and Nathalie get together again then he’ll be happy again. And you don’t know what he was like when my mother was around but-“

“Did he let you out the house?”

“Well, not except for basketball and fencing but,”

“Did he let you go to school,”

“No I had tutors but,”

“And he made you model?”

“I volunteered for that, and,”

“Doesn’t sound like it was much better.”

“Well it was,” Adrien snaps, and then his face crumples, “Sorry. Plagg, please I didn’t mean to snap, I just. I’m sorry.”

“Hey,” Plagg floated right up to his face, “no problem. I’ve seen much worse kid. Everyone’s got to snap sometimes.”

Adrien swallows. “Right. Well he *was* better. I know I spent most of my time with Mom but my father didn’t shut himself away in the Atelier all the time like he does now. He used to always be there for dinner, and we’d rehearse stuff together on the piano to play for her, and he wasn’t, he was just *nicer* before.”

“That doesn’t sound like much.”

“It was for me.” He mumbles looking down at his cast, “and anyway, you know Nathalie helped convince him to let me go to school, and I think *she’d* let me go out more,”

“Schedule-Lady?”

“Plagg.”

“OK so maybe she looks sad sometimes when she says no to you, but she still does it.”

“Yeah, because she’s my father’s assistant. If she disobeys him than Father could fire her, but if she’s his *girlfriend,”*

“Huh. Then he’d have to listen to her,” Plagg considers, there’d be no more ‘know your place’, and it *was* true. She clearly did have some boundaries when it came to Adrien and his father since she hadn’t betrayed that the boy was Chat Noir yet. *Or* given him the ring.

“Exactly. And that would basically make her my stepmother. Or eventually anyway.”

“I don’t think it would be that eventual,” Plagg mutters. A man who looked at Panthera and took about a second to decide he was into her didn’t exactly seem like a man who moved slowly.

“What?” Adrien stares up at him.

Plagg shakes his hand. “Nothing, so?”

“Right. So that would mean Nathalie wouldn’t feel the need to hold with me, she’d be more like,”

“A mom,” Plagg finishes softly, “Adrien do you think…” he didn’t want to pop the boy’s bubble but he’d seen how Ladybug’s constant rejection was wearing down the boy. He didn’t want him to suffer the same here.

“I’m being a little optimistic?” The boy shakes his head, “I’m not deluded Plagg. I know Father and Nathalie are *Father and Nathalie.* I know them getting together isn’t going to magically turn them into my friends’ parents. I’m not sure ever of them know how to be anything other than reserved. But we could, all three of us, be happier than we are how. And…I know it’s stupid but,”

Plagg stays quiet giving Adrien the chance to expand.

“I know Nathalie cares. And I know dating my father wouldn’t magically cure her. But I guess her being ill makes me think of when my mom was. And….I’d not thought about it before but, Nathalie is technically my dad’s employee. Theoretically she could just leave for another job. There’s nothing keeping her here.”

“Wouldn’t sure be more likely to leave if she broke up with your dad?”

Plagg was no Nooroo or Duusu but he was pretty sure the woman was halfway to stomping out the door out of anger at Shadow Moth’s shenangigans as it was. Which he wouldn’t condemn, and would in fact *encourage,* preferably with destroying the house on the way out if it wasn’t for Adrien.

Adrien laughs hollowly, “oh trust me. I’m not worried about my father ever letting her go if he works out he likes her. He doesn’t exactly cope well with that sort of thing.”

Now *that* was an understatement. Though he guesses Adrien, thankfully unware of Shadow Moth, doesn’t know that.

And despite the fact that if magic didn't force him to keep schtum on the matter Plagg could end Shadow Moth's reign in seconds but telling Adrien who his father really was, by telling *Tikki* who Shadow Moth was Plagg *was* thankful his boy was unware.

It might have been better for the rest of the city, and for Tikki's chosen if Gabriel Agreste could be unmasked as Shadow Moth.

But Adrien, unfathomable as it seemed to Plagg, loved his father. And he wouldn't *want* him to be Shadow Moth, wouldn't want him to fall to whatever type of justice was currently in vogue. He didn't want to be off with the rest of his family, though if they were all like that Felix then Plagg couldn't blame him.

His boy wanted his family here back together.

And Plagg couldn't give him Emilie Agreste back even if he'd wanted to.

Maybe though, he *could* give him a new one, and the best thing was that it was basically the path of least resistance. Even if it did include working out a way to talk to Nooroo and Duusu when his *their* holder didn't let them go more than metres from him. And possibly Tikki too if he was to figure out a more permanent way to save Nathalie which was now a *much* more difficult thing to work out since both their holders weren't going to the same school.

"Heh," seems pretty fair as a way to no give anything away.

"I'm serious Plagg!" Adrien says, "All we need to do is make Father realise that he likes Nathalie!"

The easy answer to that seems to be to dress her in black leather, but alas Plagg's already done that and she's been oddly resistant to all of it despite the fact *her* mind must have had impact on the costume.

A grin slides up his face as the idea forms in his head, "sure you don't have an idea of what might stop someone from looking at the girl right by them because they're in love with someone else?"

Adrien's nose wrinkles, "why would I know *that?* You know I tried with Kagami but I still loved Ladybug even if I now I'm starting to think it would be better if I didn't."

"I don't know that. I just think you should cast your net elsewhere." Preferably to the version of Ladybug who was actually in love with him just to cure Plagg's headache.

"I've loyal to Ladybug even if she isn't to me," Adrien's held his hand to his chest with such passion that it almost pushes Plagg to the floor with the fact that *Adrien is in fact his father's son,* despite his previous theory of him and Félix being swapped at birth.

It's something that both does gives Plagg an insight to what he's dealing with with the adults and simultaneously makes things so much worse. Still. He does have the benefit that Adrien was too young to react to Lady Noire in quite the same way Shadow Moth reacts to Panthera.

"But you *definitely* want your father to get over your mother?"

Adrien's eyes well up like a little kitten desperate for a parent, "Mom's gone. I know that. There's nothing I'd like more than for her to waltz back in our door but it's been too long Plagg. People don't, don't come back after as long as she has. Beside I need Father to admit to Nathalie he likes her or maybe she'll give into *Shadow Moth.*"

The boy makes it sound like a curse word.

"You noticed his interest then?"

A crutch suddenly whips up like an order to fire, "Me and everyone else. I knew he was a supervillain. But I didn't know he was a pervert! And a cheater! Look at poor Mayura, he's just abandoned her."

"Eh, maybe she's gone."

Adrien lunges forward, "you think she's *dead?* Oh my god, Plagg what if I've sent Nathalie into the jaws of a serial killer? What about *Ladybug?* Now he hasn't got me as distraction what if he goes after her?"

Plagg didn't have much awareness of what happened when he transformed a hero but, "I'm pretty sure he's only interested in Panthera."

"That doesn't make it better," his boy splutters.

"Doesn't it?"

"OK maybe a bit. But still."

"Calm it kid. You and Nathalie get me that stilton you've promised and I'll make ensure your dad and Nathalie aren't flirting with anyone apart from each other."

"Errr, I'm not sure you should tell Nathalie about this?"

"Oh don't worry. I know exactly what I ought to tell Nathalie."

Chapter 4: Gabriel II

Chapter Summary

> If you'd like to see Gabriel being this ridiculous please see the fanart Despicablebird drew for this scene (and some later ones on the last slide) here

Fate has hardly been on Gabriel's side these last few years. Even before he started to fight one of its chosen. But this evening he seems to have been blessed with some unexpected luck. He doesn't know what made him decide to stroll back from the event instead of taking the car but it's put him *right* in the path of the two people he's been wondering how to find.

Strange for them to meet in dark empty park and he files away the information that the heroes either don't have any sort of headquarters or that Panthera isn't trusted enough to be brought in.

Despite the shadow they stand in and her dark outfit he can make out the annoyance in Panthera's posture.

"Can we get this over with?" She says, "I need to get home before it's noticed I'm gone."

The irritation in her voice reminds him of Nathalie's when he causes delays to her schedule. Not that she's had such chances to be annoyed recently with her confined to her bed. Guilt squirms in his stomach, but he forces it away.

If he can manage to get the Miraculous he needs then Nathalie will be whole and well as if she'd never *not* been.

"Chat Noir and I manage well enough."

Panthera's claws tap against her leg, "apparently. I assume you hide it from your parents too then?"

Ladybug's arms cross, "it's not that I want to. I can't risk them becoming targets for Shadow Moth."

"Or you don't trust them not to take your Miraculous from you?"

"I trust my parents," Ladybug says mulishly, but her distrust for Panthera can be easily felt. It's not strong enough for an akuma no, but it's an interesting crack that Shadow Moth might be able to exploit later.

"And yet you won't let them keep you safe." Unlike her younger counterpart interestingly *guilt* seems to be the main emotion for the Cat. He wonders exactly what the relationship

between her and Chat Noir is.

She'd referred to Ladybug's parents earlier in a way that certainly doesn't suggest that she *isn't* Chat Noir's mother but neither does she seem to particularly resemble the boy in personality or appearance. She's too old certainly to be just a friend, and the boy seems a little old for a nanny but he doubts the boy would just give away his Miraculous to someone he *didn't* trust.

Her guilt does suggest that it's possible she *took* it from him but in that case he's surprised she's yet to make any play for Ladybug's, unless she's still trying to gain the girls trust.

It's something they might have tried in other circumstances. Had the Peacock not been broken then perhaps Mayura could have been their Trojan house into the hero's inner circle.

But then if that's her play then it's odd to get Ladybug on the defensive like this.

The girl's hand goes to her yo-yo, apparently thinking similar thoughts to him, "were you lying about Chat Noir being injured? Did you *take* his Miraculous from him?"

"No. But if I had then he wouldn't *be* injured." The chagrin in her voice certainly sounds like a parent. Gabriel hadn't given much thought to *why* Panthera had taken Chat Noir's place but if *that's* why he almost feels sorry that he has to deceive her the way he does. It's what any parent should do for their child, but unfortunately he's fighting for his own family and that has to come ahead of any sympathy he might have for hers.

Ladybug shakes her head, "that's not your fault. It's Shadow Moth's."

The image of the laughing hero hurt somehow looks wrong somehow in his brain. It's not something that happens in this mind numbing routine of theirs. But he ignores the emptiness inside him. This is all for a reason and one day it won't have happened at all. All of Paris would be happier if the heroes would just let him win.

And anyway whatever happened to Chat Noir can't be down to him or Ladybug's powers would have fixed it.

Panthera echoes his thoughts, "If it was Shadow Moth's wouldn't your magic have fixed it?"

"OK so it wasn't *exactly* Shadow Moth's fault. But still Shadow Moth's the reason he has to be Chat Noir. *That's* not your fault."

"It doesn't make me feel much better," Panthera mutters, before shaking her head, "anyway why did you even want to meet up?"

Ladybug straightens. "So I thought we should discuss patrol."

"Patrol? Look you and Chat Noir might have the time to spare hanging out, but I *don't.* I have a job. And it's not like us being seen is going to discourage Shadow Moth when getting our Miraculous *is what he wants.*"

"But it makes the people of the city feel better, and that *does*discourage akumatisations

“Patrol if you want to Ladybug,” Panthera extends her staff. “I’m going home."

“*Hey,”* Ladybug yells after her. “You can’t just leave.”

But the woman does, much to Gabriel’s amusement. He really could like her under better circumstances.

Thankfully the young heroine seems too affronted to make chase, so he ducked behind a building and transformed and did so himself.

By sight alone he’d have lost her but the steady annoyance and concern the woman feels shines out like a beacon in the dark for him to follow. It’s novel trying to focus on just one person when their emotions aren’t the strongest calling out to him. Like trying to use untrained muscles.

It’s something that perhaps he should practice. A way to track Ladybug, or indeed Panthera more meaningfully. As it is he can barely keep track of her. But to do that he’d have to practice on *someone* and the idea of having to feel someone’s petty annoyances and enjoyments all day gives him a headache just thinking about it.

His own grief and guilt is quite enough to deal with.

Nathalie alone he might be able to stomach in his mind. He’s thought of it before. Sending out an akuma but *not* transforming her to connect them psychically rather than through easily hacked technology. Or even trying to go further, *the user sets the limits,* that’s what Nathalie’s told him. And it makes him wonder if he could do something more subtle. Akumatise Nathalie into *Nathalie* but well and healthy. Surely it should be easier than his usual transformations.

Only his butterflies and the damage the Peacock Miraculous has done to Nathalie don’t seem to mesh well together, or so his last attempt at Catalyst seems to suggest.

Besides doing to Nathalie what he’s doing to Panthera now, reading her emotions to take advantage of her, without the benefits of the above seems like a level that despite all else he’s done he’s hesitant to stoop to. She’d let him. He knows that. Nathalie offers him all she has, more even than *he* has offered to Emilie. Which is one of those thoughts he tries to forget because that’s easier than living with it, though a vice in his chest never quite lets go of it. Whatever secrets Nathalie has are hardly any danger to him so he won’t reward her loyalty by expecting her to give them up.

Or so he tells himself. Because the alternative is that it’s cowardice. That he doesn’t want to be forced to recognise the pain she’s in everyday because of him.

No. Panthera is the safer target.

The cool slide of her staff across his neck seems to belie that.

“Silent as a cat indeed.” He chuckles. There’s no true violence in her right now.

“Stop stalking me,” she announces, no *commands* with a force that reminds him of the declarations Emilie used to lay out making him almost want to obey.

Except *that* of course would defeat the purpose of the whole thing.

“Who says I’m following you on purr-pose?”

“Did you seriously?” She releases him and walks around to face him, “did you just do what I think you did?”

“Purrhaps.”

She makes an incomprehensible sound and her emotions are a bright confused jumble too that fairly burns against him.

“Why am I even, I thought it was a fluke before. You know *I’m* the one wearing the Cat Miraculous right now?”

“Trust me. I’m well aware.” It’s his turn to almost growl.

“Stop trying to make me see a resemblance between you and Chat Noir then.”

Her skin shines in the twilight mix of the moon and the streetlights, more touchable than any fabric he’s ever used, and he suddenly wonders whether if Chat Noir *is* her son, or even her step-son given their disparate appearances, then if the boy’s father is in the picture.

“Are you married?”

“What?!,” She shrieks, “what sort of question is *that?”*

Widened with shock her eyes glow in the dark, so inhuman in a way that perhaps would be offputting if he wasn’t used to Mayura’s gemstone gaze being such a source of hope. Instead it makes him wonder what colour her eyes are. Not green he thinks. Despite the striking contrast it is it doesn’t seem right in her face, so much sharper than Emilie or Adrien’s. Brown perhaps, or no blue seems to fit better. She’d be beautiful with blue eyes.

“And what’s *that?*” She gestures behind him.

“What’s what?” He glances back confused.

“Your coat.” She clarifies. “Why are you making it stick up with that?”

“Like,” he looks down and in that moment is extremely thankful for the mask hiding his blush as how the tail of his coat has flared up like, well like the tail of a peacock displaying himself in front of a possible mate. “I’m not doing this.”

“It’s *your* suit.” Her own tail belt jabs behind her as if to punctuate her point.

“It’s not deliberate!”

“Why is it-“ She pales and her eyes go downward, “this never happened to Mayura.”

“How would you know?” He tries to press the damn coat down. This *was not* going to impress Panthera.

Her lips press together. “I guess I don’t. But no one ever reported *this*.”

“Well despite the colour of her costume Mayura is a pea*hen.* I suppose it works differently.”

“Peahens display too. More for intimidation or out of excitement than for,” she flushes, “mating purposes. But thanks for clarifying that she was a woman. Just in case I hadn’t realised.”

“Don’t be sarcastic. Besides, it’s not like Mayura had anyone to react to. Chat Noir’s *father* wasn’t subbing in for his son back then.”

He can’t quite make out what her reaction to that means on the situation he’s fishing for. Panthera swallows and her voice is oddly strangled when she says, “there was you.”

For a moment he doesn’t take her meaning. It’s so natural to have Nathalie by his side he’s never considered her in such a way despite the various idiotic rumours over the years. And he’d never brought up the fact that Hawk Moth and Mayura had had rumours of their own. It had been a useful enough subterfuge in that those who thought Hawk Moth and Mayura were a couple would never link his wife’s disappearance to situation but there had been no reason to embarrass him and Nathalie both by discussing it.

“Me?”

Panthera’s gaze on him makes feel small, as if Emilie’s soul has inhabited her and is asking him what the *hell* exactly he’s doing.

He shivers a little in the suddenly chilly night. There never *was* anything between himself and Mayura, and so he can give Panthera the truth. *Must* give Panthera the truth if his plan is to succeed. But that very plan means there must be something between him and a woman not his wife, that he *is* being unfaithful after all just like the heroine thinks he is.

The other night he’d told Nathalie he wasn’t doing this for himself. That this was just for Emilie, and for *her.* And it is for them. This really could work. She’s already shown a surprising softness towards him, and he’d felt the coil of attraction in her belly as he’d held her. It’s just another avenue to exploit.

But she’s also a very attractive woman. One his own stupid coat has betrayed he’s attracted to as if his body wasn’t capable of that by itself. It’s a game that until now he’s been enjoying.

And wrong as it might be he can’t stop when he owes it to then to exploit any chance he can. He’ll just have to ensure it doesn’t go too far.

“You called her your partner.”

“In my *quest.* Not. Mayura and I. We were never romantic.”

“What were you then? Whe-“ her words are curtailed by a cough, “Where’s she now?”

Instinctively he reaches out to steady her, but unlike Nathalie she flinches back.

Her unconscious rebuff of what had been an honest gesture destroyed by their places on opposing sides makes all his lies and sins feel very heavy, in a way that with Nathalie as his only unjudging witness they usually don’t.

“She’s my best friend.” He swallows as if that can relieve the tightness in his throat, “and she should never have got involved like this like she did. *I* should never have involved her. She’s, she’s not well. That’s why Mayura won’t be making any more appearances.”

“Your-“ Panthera’s grasp on her staff suddenly tightens as she sways, and coughs again.

“You’re not well either,” he realises suddenly.

Her other hand goes to her which chest rises and falls in way that betrays the deeper breaths she’s taking. Someone trying to stifle a cough that isn’t quite coming he recognises.

“Hey,” this time she allows him to place a hand on her back and rub soothingly, “you need to get home. And tell Chat Noir to find someone else.”

The relaxation he’d been pressing into her vanishes. “What? Aren’t you?”

“Aren’t I *what?*”

“Nothing,” she says, laying her head against her staff. “Anyway how I can head home now with you following me?”

“The same way I can trust you not to follow *me.*”

“You rather have the advantage there on me,” that stubborn pout reappears on her lips, “I wish I could trust you.”

“We both know any reason worth becoming Shadow Moth isn’t something you can just give up an opportunity to get my Miraculous because you feel sorry for me.”

“It’s not.” He agrees, feeling like quite the cad and unsure who he’s betraying, “Although Mayura might object to me bringing you home to share her sick bed while I worked on getting Ladybug’s.”

“I think she’d work out what happened if I didn’t appear and *you* suddenly had my Miraculous without you needing to hold me captive so I couldn’t communicate with her.”

“Perhaps,” she does have a point and he’s not quite sure why the idea even came to him except that while he’s the villain he’s not trying to be the *bad guy* with her. He’d look after her after defeating her. “but you let me go once, turnaround is far play.”

She turns her head to look him in the eye. “Alright. It’s not like I have much alternative I guess. You leave to the right. I’ll leave to the left.”

Chapter 5: Nathalie II

Plagg clearly isn't as sympathetic to Nathalie's plight as Duusu would have been had Nathalie still had the Peacock Kwami by her side. Though he *was* rather more with it than her poor former kwami had been, and therefore more sensitive to the possible fallout of the whole situation, even if he didn't care to well, care. Or he didn't like to admit he did anyway.

Unfortunately for him Nathalie's in a fairly similar position regards Adrien herself, if for slightly different reasons so that pretence of being unbothered doesn't really work on her. Besides which she's deeply familiar with the idea of transactional relationships and given that she, or technically Gabriel, is providing the kwami with housing and with rarer and more sublime cheeses than Adrien had been aware of with Gabriel's credit card, she feels that it entitles her to have Plagg as, at the very least, a listener.

"His flipping coat flew up! What the hell was that," she spits, "oh Nathalie I'm only doing this for Emilie," it's perhaps not the *most* accurate impression of Gabriel, certainly not even necessarily the best impression *she* could do of Gabriel but right now she's beyond infuriated with that man and in not mood to be generous, "*lies,* he's attracted to Panthera."

Plagg swallows the bite of cheese he'd just taken, "OK, so I just want to check that you do know you're Panthera?"

"Of course I," her throat convulses trapping her words inside it, and instead expelling air the series of ferocious coughs that still pain her ribcage with their force despite the fact that she ought to be *used* to this now seem to get trapped in her throat. Instinctively she's brings her hand to her mouth trying to get whatever's blocking it *out*.

"I'll take that a yes," Plagg continues munching.

Ignoring him she finally seems to shift whatever it is and it feels like her entire breathing system clears out, even as she tries not to gag on at the unexpected taste of salt and ash. Thankfully she manages to expel it from her mouth instead of trying to swallow it back down.

Focuses on regaining her breath she waits until she feels less likely to pass out before holding up her hand and trying to work out *what* exactly she's managed to spit out onto it.

The dark mess was a sticky tarry consistency, but less fluid than she expected blood to be for all that she knew the colour usually represented old blood that had had time to sit in the body outside the veins.

"Hey," Plagg suddenly appears over her shoulder, "looks like I'm doing something."

She lets the substance catch the light as she tilts her hand to inspect it and croaks out, "are you killing me? That doesn't seem like it would help Adrien? Or is it not deliberate?"

There's a pause and then he mutters, "really a good thing that you got me and not Tikki you know? You two wouldn't get on at all."

That's not even worth acknowledging with a comment though, "Don't suppose you want to tell me who did get Tikki?"

Plagg just raises his eyebrow.

"Thought not. So," she waves her hand, "this?"

"I'm not trying to kill you sheesh. That would upset the kid. And better you as my holder than that trashbag of a father of his who also happens to be Shadow Moth and is currently enslaving my friends."

"Didn't think you were the type to have friends. Save for Tikki. I know you have your" she makes quotation marks, "celestial bond."

"You humans are the one calling it that, though at least it's less tiring than what you humans get up to. I thought the kid was bad enough but,"

"Wait." Nathalie sits more upright, and then regrets it a moment later as her maybe-bloody hand makes contact with her duvet as she steadies herself, but that's not important because "*Adrien has romantic issues?"*

Adrien is a *child.* That wasn't supposed to be an issue for years. Not until they get Emilie back at least. Nathalie is sure she didn't even have crushes at that age, and she'd found her classmates' claims rather shallow and performative. Adrien can *not* be love with someone.

She refuses to entertain the possibility.

Because if he *does* then she's going to have to do something about it. She'd have to talk to him about…things, and it's not her place and goodness knows she doesn't have any good advice, so maybe she should get *Gabriel* to do it but it's such a strain to get him to make time for Adrien these days and the idea of having to talk about emotions to his son would probably send him fleeing in the opposite direction.

Besides what if he doesn't approve of whoever it is?

No, better to deal with it herself first and then work out a plan of action. Even if somehow Adrien handles it perfectly, and Gabriel approves, then there's *still* so many logistical issues to handle. How the brand will handle it from a PR perspective, how she and Guillarme will handle it from a security perspective, how to be sure whoever it is isn't just after Adrien's fame and money as a step up.

Which wouldn't necessarily be a problem if not for the fact that she has a sudden dread certainty that Adrien's going to take after his father in this department and then that would crush his little heart and she will tear any wannabe girlfriend to pieces before she lets that happen.

"Yeah you know he does." Plagg sounds infuriatingly unbothered.

“No.” She holds up her clean hand to gesture to him, “No I do not. I would be aware if I had an issue of that scale.”

“Uh, *Ladybug* ring any bells?”

“Oh my god.”

And she’d known Adrien was Chat Noir, but between everything, and especially that damned father of his she’d never even processed any of the implications past the fact that she and Gabriel had been fighting Adrien all this time, that the boy trusted her to fight his father, that Gabriel would eviscerate her for keeping this secret- both for failing to keep track and control of Adrien and for preventing Emilie’s revival, that they could have seriously injured, could have *killed* Adrien…

There had been a lot of things on her mind of rather higher priority than the fact of how Chat Noir acted with his partner.

“Mmm.” Plagg hums around his cheese, almost as if he enjoys her dismay.

Unfortunately even to their enemies it was violently clear that, “*Chat Noir is in love with Ladybug.*”

“Mmm.”

“*Adrien* is in love with *Ladybug.* In love. *With Ladybug.* Gabriel’s son loves Ladybug. The very obstacle in our way. Oh my god I have to defeat that girl and Adrien loves *her.*”

“Can’t agree on that last bit.”

“Look, yes, Gabriel is. I’m not sure he’s the man I thought he was,” that *lust* that she saw in *his* eyes in burned into her retinas, “and maybe he’s not the man I fe-.” She shuts her eyes. She’s not ready to say that out loud to even to someone as unable to tell Gabriel as Plagg, “that I chose to aid. But that doesn’t mean that I should just abandon Emilie to her death.”

“Eh, everyone dies.”

His blaséness is a shocking clang against the reverence she’s used to hearing Emilie spoken of with, and slips under her ribs forcing air out in a gasp, “She’s Adrien’s *mother.*”

“Yeah.”

“How can you,” she wants to punch, to *claw,* even to walk around to and pace off this energy but she’s too weak to do any of that, “you said you wouldn’t kill *me* because it would upset him but you’ll leave *his mother* to rot? Are you just too lazy to actually *do* anything for him”

“Look. Lady. She’s dead. You’re not. Very much not the same thing.”

“She’s not dead, she’s…sleeping.”

“Hmm. I like a nap as much as anyone but if you need the Wish to wake her it doesn’t sound like she’s sleeping.”

She shakes her head, “it’s complicated.”

Emilie was alive when she entered suspended animation yes, but it’s equally true that should they remove her she *will* die. Not in minutes necessarily, but probably within hours, Nathalie doubts she’d last a day.

They’d come very close to the line when it came to putting her into it, Gabriel had been frantic throughout the set-up, and in truth he’s never quite shucked that nervous energy despite the glacial front he puts up.

“I get it. You wanted to help. You thought you were clever. You thought it’d be a few attacks and wham, perfect world with her and whatever else you-“

“Gabriel won’t have fought Adrien.” It’s suddenly clear as anything to her. A solution to the whole sorry mess cresting over the horizon.

“What?”

“If I take Ladybug’s Miraculous and make the Wish then none of this will have ever happened. No one will remember Shadow Moth, or Mayura, or any of those akumas. Isn’t that better?”

“Nice idea, if it worked like that.”

“What do you mean?”

The kwami goes impossibly still, *stiller* than still somehow, as if his every atom has stopped in place. His eyes glow, not in the way cat eyes reflect, but actually casts a green tinge over the room, and the air starts to vibrate.

Then Plagg shakes his head and croaks, “camembert.”

Nathalie reaches for the drawer she’s turned into an impromptu cool box. She’ll have to order a mini-fridge and tell Gabriel it’s for make-up or something.

Plagg almost snaps her fingers off taking the camembert from her hand.

“What was *that?*”

His voice is oddly serious as he says, “why I shouldn’t try to remember the last time a Wish was made.”

“It *has* been done before then?”

Her research had certainly suggested it but she’s too good a historian to assume a story shown in something thousands of years old literally happened the way it’s written, especially

without other supporting sources. The Wish *could* be made. That she had to believe. But the story of it being made could have been a parable, or a prophecy, or-

A warning.

Plagg shakes his head, “I can’t, I can’t remember exactly what happened. Maybe Sass or Fluff could. Pity you can’t ask them. But what he wanted. It wasn’t what he got.”

“That doesn’t make sense. If you Wish for something it has to give it to you. There’s a price- I’m aware of that and I’m ready to pay it but,”

“You’re where he gets the self-sacrifice from then?”

She feels sick as without any conscious input her brain starts to replay a loop of how Adrien throws himself into danger for his lady.

“That’s not what we’re talking out.”

“Fine then. *Yes.* You can get the universe to give you your wish but it,” his mouth makes a few odd shapes before he seems to settle on, “flexes. Find the easiest way to do that and bounces into that shape. You want her to never have died? Have a universe were she never lived, or one where she turned left instead of right and married a different man, or one where she grew up to be totally different, would never chose to use the Miraculous and she’d look like your Emilie but you’d never recognise her. You can’t just make things like they were but for one small change.”

“That sounds more complicated than what I read of the price.”

“The price powers the Wish. It doesn’t form it. You could die for her but you don’t get to pick *how* she comes back.”

Nathalie doesn’t even try to not collapse back onto the bed. She wants to disbelieve it but she’s not sure that Plagg *can* lie to her like this. Omit information yes, failure to be offer helpful suggestions certainly, but outright lie about something he’s not compelled to?

When *she* wants the truth more than anything?

That’s not a bet she’ll take.

“So I’m even *more* screwed?” She groans, “I can’t even Wish my way out of this?”

“Cosmic destruction and recreation seems a bit much when there’s an easy solution,”

“What-“

A knock at the door breaks their conversation, and Nathalie deliberately looks to her drawers without moving her head making it clear to Plagg to make himself scare.

“Come in.” She calls.

Unsurprisingly enough it's Adrien. It's been easier training him to knock than his father, to the extent that Nathalie thinks there's an equal chance of her dying from her magical wounds and dying from a heart attack from Gabriel opening the door when she's talking to Plagg.

At least she wouldn't have to deal with this then.

Only she's not sure she could rest in peace with the idea of Gabriel knowing *she* was Panthera. Or with him having the Black Cat Miraculous with all that Plagg had told her.

"Hey," Adrien says, making opening the door look effortless despite his crutches, and smiling as Plagg mulishly reappears as if he begrudges Nathalie having told him to hide.

"Hi," she echoes back unsure. Adrien is much easier to handle when she was a *reason* to be interacting with him. Even if it's one she's made up herself. She's never been much of a child person, and avoiding the void of Emilie's absence makes it hard to find firm footing.

"I hope you too are getting on."

Plagg rolls his eyes but offers, "she buys good cheese. I'll give her that."

"We're managing." Nathalie says, "he's not that difficult."

Like a child Plagg sticks his tongue out of her as if to disagree.

"And you're doing ok as Panthera? With-" Adrien stops and goes pale in front of her eyes. "What's *that?*"

"What?" Nathalie belatedly remembers the unknown bodily fluids coating her hand and curses.

"Is that blood," Adrien comes closer and grabs her hand, sitting down beside her and for a moment the image of Gabriel doing the same after one of her times as Mayura overlays him, "Oh I know I shouldn't have let you take that ring. I knew you were ill. I should have just gone out myself I,"

"Hey." Nathalie interrupts. "None of that. *You,* Adrien Agreste, are not going out with that ring until your leg is fully healed."

Ideally he's not going to go out with that ring ever again but given her previous plan for that was smashed into smithereens a few seconds ago she's still got to work out exactly how to finagle that so there's no point on dwelling on it.

Adrien looks likely to argue back as shadows gather on his face, and then the tiniest hint of a smirk lifts the corner of his lips, "that didn't earn all my names?"

"Not unless you do something stupid and act on it."

His face falls again, "but it it's making you even more ill then…."

"Calm down," Plagg interrupts, "like I told her. I'm not killing her. I'm helping."

Nathalie looks away from Adrien towards Plagg. “You didn’t tell me you were *helping*.”

If one Miraculous alone can still her deterioration then perhaps it could do *more.* Maybe she doesn’t need both after all. Either way it, well, it suggests that she has more time which should be a relief.

Only she’s got so used to living with her ticking clock counting down she’s not quite sure what to make of the idea she might be alive after all of this.

“We got distracted.” The Kwami shrugs, and it’s not *not* the truth even if it undersells Nathalie’s whole reality being shattered.

Again.

As if Gabriel isn’t enough.

Adrien’s frowning, “but how can your powers help Nathalie? We destroy things. Which is pretty good in a fight but if she’s ill how does that help?”

“Thought I’d taught you better than that kid. Destruction’s just as important as creation.”

“I know but,” she can see his eyes move as he thinks, “are you destroying what’s making her ill then? Isn’t that dangerous?”

“A little,”

“a LITTLE?” Adrien shrieks, and this time it’s his mother than he sounds just like, “*Plagg.*”

“Adrien,” Nathalie places her clear hand on his shoulder to stop him then addressing Plagg, “so it’s sort of a hmm, magical chemotherapy?”

“Something like that.”

“Hmm.” Nathalie accepts. She’ll have to question it more but it doesn’t sound hopeful for Emilie and her weakened body.

“I’m still not sure I like it,” Adrien, sweet Adrien who has no idea of the state Nathalie was in before Plagg stating using his power, says.

“It’s fine Adrien,” Nathalie reaches for a tissue to at least not give him the mess to stare at on her, “what else did you come in to ask? You were saying something when you,” she hesitates, “noticed.”

“I wanted to know how you were doing as Panthera.”

“Fine.”

“Really?”

“Yes.”

“And wish,” Adrien sheepishly reaches behind his neck, “uh Shadow Moth? In the news footage he sort of seems to,”

“Shadow Moth’s an idiot that thinks I’ll be so flattered by him flirting that I’ll hand over my Miraculous. I can handle him.” She shuts *that* idea right down.

At least Adrien doesn’t know that’s his father out there.

“Right. Um. You’re sure?”

“I’ve handled worse working.”

“Uh. Does Father know that?”

“Why would your father know that?”

“So he could stop it?”

She just stares at him, “I’m paid to help your father not vice versa.”

“Yeah but, but I’m sure he’d *want* to stop it. And,” he gestures upwards in triumph, “doesn’t he have a responsibility to give you a safe working environment or something?”

“Adrien,” she sighs, “there’s a lot of stupid men out there. If it was anything more that I couldn’t handle I’d tell the appropriate people.”

Unfortunately she’s not sure that HR can help with the fact that her boss while moonlighting as a supervillain is unknowingly hitting on her sort-of-pretending-to-be a superhero officially because of his mission but unfortunately apparently because he’s attracted to her-but-only-as-Panthera.

Or with the fact that even though she wants to punch in him in his stupid captivating face it also makes something inside her go weak.

“Alright,” he bites his lip uncertainly, “so, what about Ladybug?”

“What about Ladybug?”

“Do you like working with her?”

“I’ve certainly worked with worse people,” unfortunately true much as she’d prefer to be working with one of the girl’s parents. Especially since Adrien wouldn’t be in love with them.

Adrien’s nose scrunches up, “you don’t like her?”

“I didn’t say that.”

The girl’s stubborn, convinced she knows best, and secretive. Unfortunately she’s also some sort of genius and committed to what she has to do. Which is rather unhelpful for Nathalie.

And what she represents is more damning than all the rest of it because frankly the rest isn't that much unlike Gabriel. So Nathalie *could* work with her if that was what she wanted to do for real instead of just pretending to while she bides her time.

"I thought everyone liked Ladybug." Adrien grimaces, "mostly."

Probably remembering Volpina or someone similar.

"She does her job. That's all that should matter."

Adrien pouts, "you're not being,"

"Being what?"

"It's just," he runs his hand through his hair, "apparently you can be, that is some people at school think you're scary?"

What. "Are you saying you're worried that *I* scare the heroine of Paris?"

Nathalie's got a good face on her for scaring off nosy and/or meddling teenagers but that girl faces akumas every week. She doubts Panthera anything frightening to Ladybug.

Adrien's eyes go horribly soft, "no, she's the bravest person I know. But it wouldn't hurt to be nice to her? Like you are to me?"

Nathalie spends half her time with Adrien telling him what he can't do.

He continues apparently having not noticed that, "I just. I hoped you'd get on. It would be nice."

"You like her don't you?"

He looks down at the ground, "I think everyone knows that."

"It's brave of you. To proclaim it like that."

"That's what you do when you're in love isn't it?" Adrien says, unware of how he's making her squirm, "Look at Father."

He's far too calm to know Shadow Moth is his father and "*what?*"

"His love for my mother is all over the house," Adrien says, "it's what you do."

"Right." And knowing it's just that should make her feel easy but instead there's a pit in her stomach. "You're sure you love Ladybug?"

"Yeah." Adrien laughs, "it'd be easier if I didn't. I've tried that, but even when I'm cross with her, down below it all I still love her."

Nathalie tries not to react, despite the alarm bells blaring in her head, "I've heard love is like that."

“So you’ll try to be nice to her.”

“I’ll try,” she allows totally defeated, but then manages to speak more firmly, “and you have a photoshoot in an hour you need to leave the house in five minutes for.”

“Thanks Nathalie!” and he’s out of the door in a whirlwind.

“I’ll break his heart if I betray that girl,” she mumbles.

“Yeah,” Plagg helpfully chimes in, “that’s why you have to seduce Shadow Moth.”

“*WHAT?”*

Chapter 6: Adrien I

Being useless is a trait that Adrien's unfortunately intimately familiar with. He was unable to lighten his frail mother's burden as she became more unwell, and then unable to keep her there with them. Unable to find a way through to the father after the shutters came down after her death to the extent that frankly he's given up.

And now he's unable to even help Ladybug. As if Chat Noir wasn't being relegated to the same level as one of the temporary heroes already now he's totally failing to turn up.

Instead Adrien sits here with his stupid broken leg, itching under the cast in a way he can't even manage to scratch, and Panthera, serious hardworking Panthera who somehow manages to turn up for every attack despite being supposed to be with his father all day, is Ladybug's new partner and maybe that's a better fit than the joker he used to be given how much he always seemed to say the wrong thing to Ladybug.

Except these days he can't say anything to Ladybug at all.

Unless he sends it through Nathalie, and. Well. Nathalie know how he feels about Ladybug obviously but it still feels awkward as anything to expect her to bear a message to her. Especially given that he knows that she doesn't approve of him being Chat Noir and, though he doesn't get it, she doesn't much seem to like Ladybug much either.

Which. He knows it's really really terrible but he almost sort of appreciates. He's not quite sure if it's just that it's nice to have someone else, that is he *loves* Ladybug but she does tick him off sometimes when she acts like he's failed some test he doesn't know he's taking, so it's sort of reassuring to know that there isn't something inherently wrong in him for being annoyed at someone so *good.* But if Nathalie who can't fault Ladybug for doing her job, which in Nathalie terms is one of the best compliments she can give, can dislike Ladybug maybe Adrien can too.

Beside a little voice that sounds like Plagg keeps whispering that if they don't get on, though once again Adrien isn't sure why- they even share a colour scheme, then maybe Ladybug is less likely to pick Nathalie over him.

It's possible that voice *is* Plagg.

Nathalie's pretty good at letting him roam free, which is kind of ironic really, except that he guesses she doesn't let him out of the house at all unless he's going with her.

Which is pretty rare these days given she's still not well whatever Plagg is, hopefully for the best, doing for her.

Adrien has tried to ask but Plagg *does* keep dodging the question which isn't the most reassuring thing in the world.

He trusts Plagg.

He *does*.

It's just. Plagg's *Plagg* and he's not really sure that Nathalie's his priority.

Which, it's not like Plagg could really do much, but Adrien kind of thinks she needs to be *someone's* that isn't Shadow Moth's.

The photo on his computer screen is grainy in the dark, and Adrien doesn't get what the hell Alya was doing at out at that time of night anyway, but it's very clearly Panthera and Shadow Moth.

And it's so unfair because Alya doesn't know Nathalie at all, and Adrien can't correct her because he can't admit that *he* does, but the implications in the paragraph are so very *very* unfair.

Alright Nathalie and Shadow Moth aren't exactly fighting in it, and maybe they're standing a little too close, and maybe Shadow Moth is kind of smiling but it's not like they're *kissing* or something.

And what Adrien *does* know, but can't correct Alya about, the same way he can't stop Shadow Moth from being a creep and sexually harassing Nathalie, is that Nathalie *can't* be betraying them because *she still has his ring.*

Sure if it's all an attempt to trick Ladybug then maybe she'd hold onto it but what Alya and whatever over conspiracy theorists casting aspersions on Nathalie don't understand is that Nathalie could never have planned to acquire his Miraculous the way she had.

It had been pure dumb the opposite of luck that Adrien had fallen of a rooftop just as his timer went off, and after Ladybug had done her magic, and messed up his lower leg. And then that he hadn't been able to sneak the ring back to Ladybug or at least to one of his classmates though he wasn't sure who he could have chosen.

Marinette would probably have been a good choice, though his face feels warm as he pictures her with that ring, and his stomach squirms at how actually she and Ladybug probably would have got on perfectly and they'd both have smiled at him and very kindly explained that they wouldn't need him back as Chat Noir after all since they worked so well together.

But that is very much the *not* the point. The point is that if Nathalie *was* working with Shadow Moth, which she *isn't* then, she could never have set it up to get his ring.

Plus it's not like she has any time to be having secret rendezvous with Shadow Moth when her entire life is basically spent keeping his father functional.

And also he was pretty sure that however unready his father might be for it, that nonetheless there certainly was *something* between them regardless of their denials.

Maybe Adrien should have felt worse about that. More defensive of his mother. But for all that he'd exchange this life in a moment for one with his mother in it he also knew that after how long it had been she wasn't coming back.

Someone new, had his father somehow been able to find his own outside the house might while shoving Adrien aside might have felt different but Nathalie wasn't that. She'd been there as long as Adrien could remember, and she, just like Adrien himself had been simultaneously thrust into the spotlight and pulled back into the insular environment of their home.

Adrien had lost his mother.

He wasn't willing to lose Nathalie too.

But right now it seemed like there was nothing he could do as *Shadow Moth tried to steal her.*

All that separating him from the scene in the garden was a window and a few metres and how his stupid rubbish leg was failing him.

He could make his way out there but anything could happen while Adrien stumbled his way out there, especially while he'd lose sight of them making his way done to the door. And then when he *did* get out there what could he do?

What was he supposed to do?

Much as trying to whack Shadow Moth with his crutches would have been *very* satisfying it didn't seem likely to be very successful. Were he Chat Noir right now then he'd burst out and hit the villain with his cataclysm.

The fact he *wasn't* Chat Noir was the problem.

Panthera fumbled the box of what looked like pastries in her hand only for *flipping Shadow Moth* to catch it and offer it back to her.

Then then same Nathalie who Adrien had thought was devoted to his family was frozen in place as the supervillain held his hand back towards her with the box in his hand.

Shadow Moth dares to look kind like he wasn't the worst type of man, like there was nothing else that Panthera could do in the circumstances but look star-struck by him as she hesitantly took it back.

And then Shadow Moth takes a step closer to her and Nathalie still doesn't move.

Adrien wants to scream.

Run.

Fight.

Do *Something.*

He's not asking her to cataclysm the supervillain. That seems too much to ask of her for when it's hardly like she eagerly volunteered for this job, and he can tell she doesn't like it however much she holds back from saying so.

That if it's going to happen to Chat Noir's job, and right now as the supervillain reaches out to cup her cheek he feels *much* less hesitant that normal.

If he'd been able to hear what they were saying before through the glass he certainly wouldn't be able to do know with how his blood thunders through his ears as his hands form fists.

Maybe he *should* shout or do something and break Nathalie out of what spell she's under, because he does *not* like how they look together.

They look, almost, like a couple.

Moreso even than his father and Nathalie do sometimes and they're always standing next to each other and exchanging loaded glances and whispers.

And. Look. Adrien doesn't believe in criticising other people's clothing choices. What you wear is as valid a method of expression as anything. But while originally he'd been touched by how Nathalie's costume had echoed his own, save for the missing bell and larger mask, it had still been a little odd seeing her in what wasn't her usual workwear.

The mask had made a certain sort of sense. Nathalie might have been less famous than him but she was hardly an open person, and she seemed terrified of his father finding out.

The latest change to her costume though.

It might not have been a problem if it wasn't for the fact that a certain supervillain certainly isn't ignoring that the zip of her costume now seems to be fixed in place pulled partially down so that now it exposed her neck, and gave the faintest hint of cleavage.

So much for Plagg's claims that he'd put a stop to.... Whatever this was between Panthera and Shadow Moth because while he couldn't accuse Nathalie of flirting back she wasn't stopping this either and Shadow Moth was definitely flirting.

The pervert was obviously pretending he was just looking down at Nathalie because of his stupid height but Adrien wasn't stupid. He could see what was actually going on here and he didn't like it.

Finally Nathalie takes a step back shaking her head.

Adrien frowns as Shadow Moth reaches out for her again but then the super villain pulls his hand back, and says something else, and doesn't stop her as Nathalie keeps stepping back away, thankfully at least having not completely lost her sense as she never turns her back on the villain for as far as Adrien can see her as she rounds the corner of the house.

Shadow Moth meanwhile just stands there with the dopiest smile on his face.

Adrien sort of feels like he should have a little camera drone or something to send out after the man and follow him home. Or wherever he lurks anyway. It's hard to imagine Shadow Moth having a home, having a *life* outside being Shadow Moth but then maybe people think the same about Chat Noir.

Maybe Mayura got fed up and left him and *that's* why he's using her Miraculous now, and why he's so obsessed with Panthera because he can't get over being dumped and wants to prove himself, or he just can't work out how to live without a woman by his side so he's fixated on her.

It would certainly explain why he's acting like this about someone he doesn't even know.

Unless he's just like that with woman generally.

Adrien really doesn't know why Nathalie doesn't just at least punch him.

He's sure Ladybug feels the same way.

But his attempts to make sense of any of this are shattered by the sound of the front door bell. Adrien rushes to it, or as much as he can in his current state, well aware that it's generally best *not* to let his father to be the one at the door.

When he gets there, and flips on the camera he's shocked to see Nathalie, *as Nathalie,* outside looking likely to faint.

"Wasn't planning to come in this way," she gasps, explaining why she didn't just use her keys, "take these and hide them from your father."

She holds out the macaron box.

Confusion rises in him as he stares at it, "What? Don't you,"

"*Now* Adrien," her tones broke no disagreement, "he can *not* see it."

Leaving her here feels wrong but it's not like there's any danger. There's no reason Shadow Moth should be in the house, and besides Nathalie's only Nathalie now. He'd have no reason to pay attention to her.

Unless he really is that indiscriminate when it comes to woman to hit on.

No. He's asked so much of Nathalie. It's only right that he does this for her.

"OK," he takes the box, even though it doesn't really make sense to him. It's true his father wouldn't approve of him stuffing himself with sweets and pastries but at the same time it's not like every single thing he eats is monitored that closely, elsewise he'd never get away with ordering all that cheese for Plagg.

Unless Nathalie's been hiding that from his father too.

The idea makes him rush a little more, and it's lucky that he manages it because he only just manages to get up the stairs when he hears the door of the Atelier knock against the wall as it opened and then his father's, "*Nathalie,* what are you doing down here without your exoskeleton?"

With a skill honed from years of spying on his parents grown-up parties while he'd been theoretically confined to his room he carefully ducks down behind the bannister, difficult to bend leg and all, and watches as his father carefully picks Nathalie up.

It's a kindness that Shadow Moth would never be able to muster no matter how hard he tries, and thankfully from how all that fight seems to drain out of Nathalie it looks like whatever spell the supervillain has her under the it hasn't yet broken the draw his father has on her.

But she *did* really want to keep this box secret from him, in a way that if Nathalie hadn't seemed panicked by Shadow Moth's appearance in the garden he would have thought that was because they'd come from *him*.

Wherever they came from his father's making his way up the stairs with Nathalie in his arms and Adrien needs to scram.

Once in the relative safety of his room Adrien gingerly opens the box. However all that's in there are macarons. His heartbeat slows down a little at the reassurance there's no obvious danger. He'd almost thought they might be something dangerous, or a secret message from Ladybug or something with how adamant Nathalie had been able hiding them.

…Although, now he looks at it they are in particular colours.

Red isn't unusual, and though it's less common neither is green that strange, but the black is. They're in the colours of Ladybug and Chat Noir.

And on the interior of the lid there's a not bad at all drawing of two hands fist pumping, and above it spelled out in alphabet stickers it says "Get Well Soon."

It's a message from Ladybug. His Lady hasn't forgotten him after all.

Not even Shadow Moth could dampen the fire that's ignited in him right now. He'd run round the room in celebration if he could.

No wonder Nathalie didn't want his father to inspect this, for all there's no reason he'd put together that this wasn't just a gift from a schoolfriend. There's no way for him to know Adrien has any link to Ladybug past being a fan.

Still a message from Ladybug reminds Adrien that he does still have responsibilities. Chat Noir can't fight out there, but Adrien Agreste can take the field here. Metaphorically. He has to make sure that Nathalie doesn't make herself ill being Panthera even if Plagg claims to be helping, that she works with Ladybug, *and* that she doesn't fall to Shadow Moth's foul seduction tactics.

As Chat Noir Adrien knows how to fight with very single weapon he grab on the battlefield. He's…he'll make his father fit his purpose *somehow.*

It's not like his father hadn't successfully wooed his mother, so despite his generally awful skills at gift giving he must be good in some way when it comes to romance.

The issue is making him realise that he *wants* to woo Nathalie.

Adrien's pretty sure that he does even if he feels guilty about it, and it's not like he doesn't understand why. This house is a shrine to his father's love for his mother. It must feel like betraying her even though he's not.

Adrien knows it's easier for him, because for him Nathalie's always been part of his family, it's not like he's trying to suddenly make her his mother. Whereas for his father….yeah he guesses it's different.

Not that Adrien wants to get shouted at either.

He needs to find a way to make his father realise that *he* needs to get out of denial and date Nathalie or they might lose her.

"Hmm," he considers, and carefully hides the macarons under his desk, "maybe the truth is the best course of action."

Heading to the door, he decides to wait until he can 'accidentally' intercept his father coming out of Nathalie's room. It might take a while. Those two can talk for ages.

"Father," Adrien calls, and despite how his father's face seems to shut down on hearing him he perseveres, "how's Nathalie?"

"Fine."

So that's not giving him much to work with but he tries again, "just working too hard again, hey?"

"Perhaps you should consider emulating some of that work ethic yourself. Shouldn't you be studying?"

Adrien puts on his best, mother-taught, innocence face, "Nathalie was going to go through my history with me but if she's not feeling well then…"

His father stops. He's caught him. "Can't you practice by yourself?"

"She says being quizzed is a more effective learning exercise."

That gains him a pinch on the bridge of his nose. "She's sleeping now. Why don't you do it later? I'm sure there's other things you can do for now."

“Is there anything I can help *you* with?” He decides to give a hint, “things must be busy in Nathalie’s absence.”

“I can manage without a teenager’s help.” His father turns away.

“Wait!” Adrien calls after him, “do you think Shadow Moth is hot?”

For once he seems to have really shocked his father. His jaw drops wide open, and his eyes are bulging out. “Do I *what?!”*

This hadn’t really been his plan, but he guesses he can work with it, “I mean some people must right? He’s uh,” OK Adrien has no idea what people see in Shadow Moth, “strong?” *think think think,* “and uh, tall?” strike at his jealously, *think,* “I mean he must even be taller than you, I didn’t think anyone was taller than you.”

“Adrien,” his father has gone so pale he looks sick, “what the hell are you talking about?”

He’s successfully thrown him enough that didn’t even sound *that* angry, time to aim for the goal “I mean I guess that must be what Nathalie sees in him.” He can’t see what else it could be.

“Wait, you think *Nathalie* is attracted to Shadow Moth, oh thank god,” his hand brushes over his forehead, “of course that makes so much more sense, why would.”

He comes to a sudden stop, straightens up, and turns that stare that usually heralds trouble down on Adrien.

“Wait. Why would you even, look. I’m sure that Nathalie has no interest in Shadow Moth whatsoever. You keep she’s very dedicated. If you’ve caught her following videos of the attacks I’m sure that’s just so she can try to find a way to get us safe.”

“That’s probably how it started.”

“How it *started?*”

“But she gets this look in her eye when she looks at pictures of him. All dreamy like the girls at school when they have crushes on people.”

Technically the look Nathalie gets when Shadow Moth gets close to her is probably more like a deer in the highlights but that doesn’t sound very romantic.

“Look son,” his father’s voice sounds rather strangled, “I think you’ve got the wrong else of the stick here. What you’re describing sounds very unlikely. Just go to your room and….practise piano or something”

Adrien’s not quite sure if that counts as a victory or a loss.

Chapter 7: Gabriel III

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

His gloved hand is startlingly dark against her fair skin, and as his thumb passes over the almost black corner of her lips it makes it clear how *red* in fact they are. Her mouth parts at the pressure, betraying a glimpse of her white teeth, making her lips even more striking.

No mask covers her face, despite the familiar catsuit under his other hand on her hip. As she shifts closer on his lap, his eyes are drawn up, past the curls hanging over her cheekbone, to the bold eyeliner around those aquamarine eyes that he can make sparkle with delight despite her usual face of stone.

The rose window of the lair casts strange patterns of light over both of them.

“I love you,” she says, her tongue brushing against his thumb, making him wish his hands were bare and that he wasn’t Shadow Moth, that he was, “Gabriel.”

And then it feels like his heart stops as a shrill ringing blasts through his ears and his eyesight goes dark. He grasps in confusion, one hand meeting empty air and the other fabric where she’d been a moment before.

Sunlight beats against his face, his eyelids not quite capable of keeping it out. When he tries to open his eyes he finds himself squinting.

His bed is comfortable, Emilie had insisted they only had the very best, but it’s nothing compared to the feeling of her against him.

Her.

Which her?

He groans. Panthera is one thing. He has, for the most part, made his peace with the fact that he wants her. And with the fact he should stop the game he’s playing and that despite all of that he’s not. He just needs to make sure it doesn’t go too far.

But Nathalie is quite another.

Panthera is Shadow Moth’s. Nathalie is Gabriel’s.

Panthera is a fantasy. Nathalie is real.

Panthera is an enemy he can manipulate with no compunctions. Nathalie is his steady rock to whom even thinking of doing that to would be an ill return to her loyalty indeed.

Panthera is unattainable. Nathalie is right by his side.

Panthera should he mismanage this and lose her he can manage. It would only be another setback in a string of them. Nathalie he daren't impose upon, she's irreplaceable.

Panthera has no idea why he's doing this. Nathalie knows exactly how much of a betrayal of Emilie anything would be.

Panthera is attracted to him. Nathalie is ... not.

This whole confusion, it's all Adrien's fault. Until his son had put into this head this idiotic idea of her having a thing for his alter ego he'd never considered the idea.

And much as it had been a relief after the brief horrifying moment where he'd thought that either his son was trying to confess to a crush on *him,* the very thought of which makes him imagine Emilie beating him bloody in her fury, or that somehow he thought Gabriel had a crush on *himself* which was only not distressing in comparison to the other, right now it's not a comforting thought at all.

Nathalie can't have a thing for his alter ego because she *knows* he's *him.* If she was going to be attracted to him then she'd be attracted to *him.* Clothes can be transformative but given what he's fighting for, what he *knows* he's fighting for, he can hardly see that a change of outfit and a little more height could send Nathalie's feelings off in such a wrong direction.

No.

If anything Adrien's just misunderstood Nathalie's admiration of Shadow Moth. It makes every sense that his most loyal, if only, supporter would watch his exploits hoping for the best, and look, Gabriel *knows* Nathalie's loyalty is strong, knows she's committed to what he's trying to do, knows she wants him to win because he *akumatised* her with it.

He's aware that Nathalie doesn't just help because it's her job, that despite her normal reticence he'd shocked her with his declaration that he would get Emilie back, and that that was perhaps when Nathalie began to admire him as a *person,* and not just as a designer.

Duty alone would not have let him create Catalyst.

The strength of feeling he'd found in her could easily be mistaken for something else. Especially by a boy without much experience and who was looking for it after-

Ah.

No.

That had been *Gabriel* and Nathalie whose behaviour his son had misinterpreted before; having seen that they had secrets and true, their relationship *had* shifted, and coming to completely the wrong conclusion.

As if Gabriel could let Emilie go so quickly. When Adrien falls in actual real love one day he'll understand and he'll laugh that he could have thought otherwise.

Still. He's being just as bad as Adrien at making the wrong conclusions here. His son believes there's something between himself and Nathalie. That much is correct. But Adrien's *doesn't* know that he's Shadow Moth. So it can't be the first that made him think the latter. To Adrien Nathalie is the only connection.

Although it does make that time look a little different. Gabriel had been so offended at Adrien thinking he'd just move on like that, as if all his time with Emilie had been meaningless, that he'd focused on the insult to himself.

He'd never considered that it might have been *Nathalie's* behaviour that had caused his son to question it, but since Nathalie is the common denominator here perhaps that's something that Gabriel should be considering.

Though he supposes it's just the same thing really. Adrien misreading Nathalie's support. It's not as if he's ever felt any jealously from her while he's talked about Panthera.

Anger yes, but not *envy,* though it's true that as a matter of course he tries not to read Nathalie's emotions, especially when she's less than happy with him, so it's not impossible that he might have missed something.

But he can't forget that memory of her *loyalty,* warm and all-enveloping as he'd reached into it. A woman who feels that for him, who's never been other than steadfast in support of his quest, who has endangered herself for *his sake* to the extent she's only just re-learning to walk….

It seems unfair to accuse someone like that of undermining his attempts the way that surely any misplaced feelings would.

The best thing would be to put it out of his head to concentrate on his mission.

Though, as the reminder on his phone bings, he does unfortunately have a life outside that as well and little as he cares sometimes about the brand the way he used to he does have a reputation to maintain if he's to keep his secret safe and that not being the sort of man to left his personal life trouble the success of his business.

Work it turns out was exactly what he needed to forget the whole thing for a few hours. It says there hovering at the back of his mind, how could it not with Nathalie's constant presence, but the constant calls and emails the two of them have to field do at least help make it difficult to devote much in the way of brainpower to Adrien's claims.

Still as he slumps over his screen he can't say it feels like much of a respite really.

He groans. "Have I done everything I need to do today Nathalie?"

"I believe so sir." Her answer is efficient and professional and Adrien has to be wrong.

Although it does now belatedly occur to him that just because Adrien's interpretation is wrong doesn't mean that it's not dangerous that his son is linking Shadow Moth and Nathalie in his mind.

After all from Nathalie it's only one very small step to him.

"Good," he acknowledges her while stalling on how to bring it up, "I do have to talk to you about something else though."

She looks away from her computer, "Sir?"

"My son decided to inform me of his belief that you have a celebrity crush on Shadow Moth."

Nathalie's mouth drops open before she immediately closes it.

"Yes, I was shocked as to how on earth he came to that conclusion too, though I must admit it was something of a relief to get clarification that *he* wasn't the one with the crush."

"Adrien," Nathalie seems lost for words, "*what?*"

"My son desperately needs to work on his communication skills apparently," archness allows him to hide his ongoing discomfort on the topic, and maybe a joke with help Nathalie feel a little better about it too, "perhaps you could sign him up for a seminar."

"I can look into that sir," she pauses, "did Adrien say *why* exactly he thought I…"

"Ah yes, he seems to have spotted you reviewing me in battle and rather got the wrong end of the stick. I can't see this will cause any issues for us, but it might be wise to disabuse us of him of the notion. We hardly want Adrien to get the idea to investigate Shadow Moth do we?"

Nathalie inclines her head and doesn't betray anything but agreement, "No we certainly don't want that. I'll talk to Adrien and get this sorted out."

Relieved to have the whole issue dealt with, especially with no response from Nathalie that couldn't be explained by the circumstances, "Good. Unless you felt an apology from him was warranted? If he'd said that to anyone else it could have caused issues for you," and therefore *them* but Gabriel isn't stupid enough not to realise that Nathalie is the one being accused of an attraction to the man the city hates.

He could easily disavow her or ignore the press.

She'd be the one with her reputation in tatters.

Nathalie seems unworried as she goes back to her work, "I'm fairly certain Adrien wouldn't have said anything about it to anyone other than you. But I'll sort it all out when I talk to him anyway."

“Thank you Nathalie. I don’t know what I’d do without you,” and then because it has been an utter nightmare of a day and he’s just given her another task, “did you want to eat together today?”

“Thank you sir, but I’ve just realised I’ve another errand to run.”

“Another? Is that wise? You’re still not healed you know. Couldn’t someone else from the company do it?”

“I don’t think someone else could go to the dentist for me, no. And I was lucky to get this late slot. Actually I should probably be headed off now if that’s OK sir?”

“Of course Nathalie,” he answers immediately but he feels a little like his balloon’s just burst as he watches her head out.

He’s got used to having Nathalie to decompress with since he’s lost Emilie.

Not that it’s the same thing at all. Nathalie has a way of making it all seem manageable, helping him to relax and accept what’s done is done for now because she or he will have a new plan another day.

Emilie had been more of…a distraction from whatever happened. She always had some new thing to share, or something she wanted to do, or indeed needed distracting from her own troubles, so there had been no time for to dwell on any of his.

Whatever Adrien might think his relationship with the two woman is very different.

Still now that his plans for tonight have changed he finds himself a little lost, when a sudden fit of anger burns through his Miraculous and suggests a new plan for this evening.

But even as he engages the entrance to the lair it fades away leaving him once again at a loss and moving up to the lair for no blasted reason at all.

Perhaps *he’d* make a good target for an akuma right now but he’d prefer to have Nathalie back here ready to play back if should the need be there, for all that he knows he can’t risk asking her to use a Miraculous again.

The Peacock might be fixed but despite the fact there’s been more colour in her cheeks lately and she’s been managing mostly to work Nathalie very much *isn’t.* She’ll seem as good as she’s ever been and then the next moment she’ll have collapsed again like the other day when he found her in the hall.

He really *really* needs to make this Wish. For Emilie. For Nathalie. For everyone.

The world he creates will be better than this he promises.

Gabriel will be a better man in that world.

But here he isn’t and even as he turns to leave he considers that there is *another* woman he could go bother right now.

Logic tells him it's unlikely. That there's no reason that Panthera would be out tonight, and even if she was this is a big city- there's no reason she'd be anywhere near him.

Besides it's dangerous to leave the lair too often. Each time he leaves and returns he might be spotted and the fact that neither Ladybug or Chat Noir have even been spotted returning to their own homes or wherever they come from isn't the reassurance it should be.

However if he was the sort of man that listened to the odds and gave up when they were against him then he wouldn't *be* himself. He'd be someone who would have given up years ago. Besides it's dark outside. It's unlikely he'll be spotted but he considers attempting to darken his cowl somewhat regardless.

Perhaps it was a premonition, or fate choosing to smile on him for the first time in forever, but he finds his prey sound enough sat on a rooftop staring up at the clouded sky, and it's odd not quite gloom reflecting the lights of the city.

Only there's many words that fit the Panthera he knows but none of them seem to fit the woman sat on the roof with her legs drawn up in front of her.

She seems small. Tired. Like Nathalie when she doesn't realise he's looking.

The excitement that had grown in him on spotting the green flash of her eyes ebbs and instead of flirting he just sits down by her. "Bad day?"

She doesn't move to look at him. "You could say that."

"Want to talk about it?"

"That's a very transparent attempt to find out who I am you know." Panthera says, but he can feel she's more tired than angry.

Not that he doesn't feel bad adding to her burden, that too will be anything he'll fix with the Wish. "I wasn't-"

"Look," she says, "I'm *really* not in the mood for this today. I mean I'm *never* in the mood for this but,"

"You are," he can't stop but himself smirking, "I can feel what you do you know. And even if I couldn't your costume change certainly suggests you do."

She buries her forehead in her knees, "of course you use your Miraculous to spy on my emotions. Why wouldn't you?"

"It's nothing personal. It's just,"

“What you do. I know.” She turns her head, so it’s still resting on her knees but looking at him, “do you really use it on everyone? Even…”

“Even what?”

She purses her lips. “Even people in your personal life? Even, and I don’t expect you to admit anything about who you are, but hypothetically speaking, your family?”

For some reason he feels caught in her gaze, “No. I don’t. Not people close to me.” He looks down at the ground, away from her eyes, “I tell myself it’s because I care but maybe it’s cowardice.”

“Cowardice?”

“Maybe I’m scared to know what they feel.” Scared to feel Adrien’s grief, Nathalie’s pain, that either or both might hate him for not having fixed this all earlier.

Her head is suddenly against his arm, “I think we all are. Scared of what others feel about us. I think they’d appreciate you not snooping though.”

“So I tell myself.”

“And on very different topic, trust me, the cleavage? Very much *not* my choice. You can thank my kwami for that.”

He looks down at the crown of her head, “but it’s your costume.”

“You’ll telling me you consciously pick every aspect of yours?”

“Well no, it’s like my akumas, it’s a-“

“Joint effort.” She finishes, “exactly. He apparently thinks I need to be more sexy.”

“That’s idiotic. You’re already that. And just showing more skin doesn’t necessarily have that effect anyway,” sometimes *not* showing can be more effective.

“Your eyes beg to differ. And anyway you wouldn’t think that if you knew what I really look like.”

“I doubt you look that different. Most Miraculous Holders don’t, It’s the magic that stops you recognising people. I doubt you’re secretly hideous.”

“I never said I was. Just not your type. Which is yet another reason you should stop all of this.”

“What other ones do you have?”

“I’ve already told you. It’s demeaning to both of us. *And* I have to somehow explain this to Chat Noir somehow.”

“Oh.” He doesn’t even her that. Thank god Adrien has no idea he’s Shadow Moth.

“Oh is right and-“ she stops. “Is that rain?”

He holds out a hand but it’s unnecessary as more droplets come, “Apparently.”

“Can I not just have one night of peace and quiet?”

Gabriel isn’t fond of the rain either but Panthera certainly feels more put out. A cat thing maybe. Or wait-

“Are you feeling better?”

She frowns, “what?”

“You weren’t well before. If you’re ill you shouldn’t be out in the rain.”

“I shouldn’t be out anyway. I just wanted to be alone.”

“I’m sorry.” But a solution to at least one of their problems begins to paint itself in his brain, “my dear Cat I have an idea.”

“Why does that worry me?”

He ignores her, and shuts his eyes, he’s never tried this before but it’s not so different to an akumatisation *really.* Almost a semi one of sorts.

“Nooroo, Duusu transform me.”

He hears her voice through the crackle of power running over him, “but you’re already…”

Once the purple light leaves his vision he opens his eyes, glad to see Hawk Moth’s suit back in place and a welcome new weight on his shoulders. Reaching up he finds the cape, he assumes of a Peacock’s tail, he was aiming for.

“Here,” he says, “you can shelter under this until it eases off.”

Her eyes widen but she lets him pull her close and wrap it round her.

He seems to have shocked her into silence though he’s unsure why. “Better?”

She swallows against him, “You know sometimes you make me wish you actually were in love with me.”

Chapter End Notes

and more art of from DespicableBirds here and here

Chapter 8: Nathalie III

Nathalie has decided she loves the Tsurugi car. She'd hated it when Gabriel bought it. Hated the confirmation that she was no longer an independent person who, in the very unlikely chance the whim took her, could just get in a car and drive away from all of this.

A taxi is manifestly not the same thing. Doesn't carry the same freedom. And doesn't give her the privacy she needs for this conversation.

For any of her conversations.

She likes Guillaume well enough, trusts him to do his job, but having him here for this-

No.

Plagg hovers in front of her, "I don't see why it's such an issue."

She opens the eyes she's been taking the chance to rest in the break from being around either Agreste for a few minutes of her day.

"Did you put him up to this?"

The kwami yawns, as if to show just *how* unbothered he is, "Why would I bother to do that?"

Nathalie wishes she could be equally unruffled, right now she can *feel* the pressure building up in her head for a migraine worthy of the record books.

"Because of your stupid plan."

Plagg shrugs, "*you're* the one calling it stupid."

"Gabriel is not going to give up and let Emilie go because he's fallen in love with me because Gabriel is not going to suddenly fall in love with me." She points out.

Plagg starts, "But,"

She doesn't let me continue, "And if he *thinks* himself in love with Panthera then he's definitely not going to be once he discovers she's me. Because he's going to be so betrayed by that discovery that I am going to be beyond fired and also homeless. And even if he could get over that without attempting to destroy the entire world on the way he's still not going to want me because he he's had plenty of chances to fall in love with me and he hasn't and he *won't.*"

"Has he though?"

She's never thought herself stupid whatever else she might be but she doesn't get his point, "What?"

“Look lady. He’s doing all of this for his wife right?”

Nathalie shifts a bit to better look at Plagg, and see if she could follow his somewhat convoluted and usually designed to get him either cheese, or just an easier life in general logic.

“Yes.” She confirms, “you know this.”

“So if all the time you’ve known him, he’s been married or trying to get her back then when was he going to fall for you? Like, look at the kid, he’s other options than Ladybug. Girls he *likes,* but he won’t let himself consider *because* that would be betraying Ladybug.”

That makes her squint, “wait, don’t you want Adrien to date Ladybug?”

Plagg turns away from her, “I don’t want him to get hurt. You’ve seen how they are.”

“I have,” she concedes but the idea buzzes in her brain anyway, there’s something important there, possibilities in Plagg thinking Adrien likes someone else *that Adrien knows* and pushing him that way.

Still she files it away for something to think about in the future, and sighs.

“Have you ever thought *I* don’t want to get hurt too?”

“Yeah, how messed up your body feels every time I have to transform you kind of suggests not.” The snark in his tone isn’t even hidden.

With every single bit of frost she’s even blasted impertinent journalists, or tardy suppliers, or people who just thought she was too unimportant to bother with, over the years she glares at Plagg, and wishes the Kwami would fly a little lower so she wasn’t looking up at him.

“I meant emotionally. Maybe,” and drat, her blasted voice isn’t staying level, she can’t control it and it doesn’t make sense. She’s shoved her feelings down inside herself for years. She talks to Gabriel without betraying how she feels about him every day.

It’s completely unfair and inexplicable that her emotional control is failing her now, just because she has an option for someone to talk to, when said person doesn’t care about her at all and just sees her as a way to improve Adrien.

Not that she’s censuring him for that. It’s just he’s hardly someone to pour her heart out to.

“It doesn’t matter,” she blinks her to get rid of any traitorous tears before they get too close to Adrien’s school.

Plagg tilts his head and then flies into the front seat, and apparently plays with the controls.

“What are you doing?”

He comes back triumphant, “giving us a longer route to Adrien’s school. Or possibly crashing us. Hopefully the former.”

“Oh my god.”

He looks up at down, “you don’t seem to be changing it though.”

“Like you said. I’m not scared of physical pain.”

There was an uncomfortable pause as air in the car seemed to get very scare before Plagg said, “you know. My holders aren’t supposed to destroy *themselves*.”

Those glowing green eyes Gabriel apparently finds so appealing on Panthera are hard for Nathalie to meet, as they seem to pierce past all her layers of protective pretence of non-caring and nonchalance and disinterestedness.

“Maybe I’ll be the first then,” she caves eventually, because Plagg isn’t who she *wants* to talk to, but she has no-one that she can truly talk to, no one who will understand without judging unfairly and running to the law, and at least Plagg isn’t able to betray most of this, the heart of this, due to the magic that binds him.

It’s probably better than drinking wine locked in her room and getting tipsy enough to wistfully imagine getting drunk enough to actually talk to some random stranger in bar about any of this.

“What are my options?” She asks him, “Really? The Wish that I’ve been fighting this whole time to get apparently won’t work the way I want it at all. Gabriel isn’t,”

Plagg’s mouth opened as if to say something.

She held up a hand to stop him. “You’re not entirely wrong about him and I. It’s true. *My* feelings have changed. I haven’t loved Gabriel all this time. Admired him certainly. He gave me the chance to be part of something. Made me feel valued. And I can’t pretend that it was after he lost Emilie the first time I looked at him, and realised that actually in a way he was attractive. But it wasn’t until the moment he told me what he was going to do, until all the barriers between us collapsed as he leaned on me not only for what *I* did for him but also for what Emilie used to do too, that I realised how far I’d go for him. And only later that I realised what that meant.”

Maybe she is stupid.

Or maybe she’s just shamefully inexperienced when it comes to relationships for someone her age. Then again with parents like hers she’s not sure where she’s supposed to have learnt to do this *healthily.*

“Yeah and?”

She could feel the wrinkles forming in her forehead, “*and?*”

Plagg’s face screws up. “So far you just sound even worse than our kid. I thought *he* took the crown for mushiness.”

“You’re not so bad really are you,” overcome by a rush of affection she reaches up to stroke his back like he was a real cat and smiles as he purrs.

For love of Adrien she could forgive a lot, “but you see Gabriel’s feelings changed too. I’m not going to claim they didn’t. He does care for me. A lot even. After Emilie, and then Adrien, I’m his next priority. But that’s not love. And Panthera proves that.”

“I don’t get it.”

“Gabriel might have done things that other people might think inappropriate,” her skin both crawled and tingled at the memory of him helping her out of her clothes after Mayura had left her too week to do to do it herself, “but the reason that he could was because it would never occur to him to think of me like that. Because maybe you’re right, maybe he’s not the man I fell in love with and he can move on. Maybe Panthera proves that. Because he just saw her and it was at the very least lust at first sight, and the worst of it is that I think it could grow to be more.”

Especially after the other night where he’d held her so close, and put that creative mind to work sheltering *her,* and they’d both admitted things they wouldn’t to anyone else, including for him *her*, “But that only proves that he’s not in love with Nathalie. So what am I supposed to do?”

“Well,”

“Give him the ring? And destroy what’s left of his relationship with his son, and either make the Wish and possibly destroy everything or let him continue on without Ladybug’s Miraculous but unable to give up because he has one of them?”

“Please don’t do that.”

“So should I betray him? Betray the man I might still love to prison and infamy, *still* destroy Adrien’s life as a result and probably end up behind bars myself?”

“Honestly Ladybug would probably be kind of,”

Nathalie almost wants to laugh. “Oh so I should just steal both Miraculous and give them to her should I? And yeah, maybe for Adrien’s sake,” because it turned out Ladybug did care for her missing partner after all and this was how Nathalie got talked into trafficking possibly identifiable pastries back into the house and almost destroying this very fragile safety they had, “she might accept that. But Gabriel wouldn’t. He’d know it was me and bam, I’m out of his house and a job again. But then maybe you wouldn’t care about that. But if you think things would work out better with him and Adrien there you’ve got another thing coming.”

“Trust me. I don’t think that.”

“No. You think I should be whatever I can to make him fall in love with Panthera, because you think it’s possible she could get him to give up on Emilie, only for it all to fall to pieces when he asks to meet the woman behind the mask which, in that scenario he definitely

would. Gabriel might compartmentalise but if he loves her he won't be happy with just rooftop trysts forever."

This time Plagg didn't even object.

"So *what* exactly am I supposed to do? The only way I can see this not leading to disaster is if I could somehow get Gabriel to decide to give up both his Miraculous jewels of his one decision, *not* just because he's in love with someone new. And if I knew how to do *that* don't you think I'd have done it before?"

It's embarrassing how she spits the words from her mouth, but she's needed this, needed to yell at someone about how impossible this all is for a long time.

"How would I know?"

Plagg's words puncture her growing fury.

"What?"

"Never seemed to me that you did much to stop him. Not with the kid. Not with Hawk Moth. Didn't Mayura save him when the heroes could have put a stop to all of this?"

Guilt prickles at the corners of her eyes, "you don't understand."

She had tried with Adrien. But she wasn't his mother, she had no right to impose the parenting decisions she would have made on him. She still tried sometimes because it might have been wrong, but it felt *right,* and sometimes Gabriel even asked her.

She had tried with Gabriel. But she wasn't his wife. She didn't have the ability to raise his mood the way Emilie had. To announce that this was what they were doing and make him do it. To waft around high society and make Gabriel's reserve seem mysterious rather than haughty, to make people believe there must be something about a man who could catch a woman like her.

Gabriel had caught Nathalie's heart by being something more than anyone could imagine but that wasn't a story anyone wanted to hear.

And maybe what she'd fallen for was only an illusion anyway, but she didn't know how to feel when she couldn't help but judge him for looking like he might be able to *give up,* the very thing she know wanted to do.

"No." Plagg says, "I don't. And people call *me* selfish."

Acid sat just behind her tongue threatening to come pouring out her mouth but Nathalie had been sick enough that now even though it still hurt she could see the difference between the symptoms of the anxiety she'd survive, and the damage from the Miraculous she might not.

So she shut her eyes again, and let her head hall back against the chair and tried, if not to swallow, not to heave anything up.

Letting herself consider it she thought it was possible Plagg had a point. For all it didn't seem fair that whether she was working to try to get Emilie back or preventing the very same the only options seemed to be to sacrifice *herself.*

"I think we're the same actually. We care about the people we love and that's it," she announces eventually.

"Kwami's don't,"

"Oh come off it. Maybe you don't love romantically. Maybe however you care is in a different way. But it comes round to the same place."

"So you've going to make him give up?"

"I'm going to try to do something. I'll work out the what later."

Opening her eyes she notices the Kwami has his hands held out and she sighs and reaches into her now-larger-than-she'd-usually-pick handbag to retrieve some brie from inside the little cool bag she now kept inside it.

Adrien might be happy to keep cheese in his pocket and drench himself in cologne to hide the smell, which is something she probably needs to do something about, but Nathalie has standards.

"Here," she holds it out, "payment for listening to my emotional breakdown."

Plagg grins. "See, this is why I almost like you."

"Hmm," she acknowledges as she checks out her make-up mirror to get her face, and see if she needs to tidy herself up before Adrien arrives.

"By the way," he announces, "we're basically here."

"Great," she sucks air. "At least Adrien is unlikely to care we're a little late."

As many great qualities as he has punctuality doesn't seem to be one of them. Though she guesses she shouldn't really censure him for *that* now that she knows the true reason why.

From his smile as he opens the car door it certainly looks like he's been glad enough to have a little extra time with his friends though.

"Hi Nathalie, hi Plagg," he smiles that great big sunshiney smile that he got from his mother that makes the guilt curdling in her stomach even worse.

She almost wants to ask him if he still misses his mother. If maybe he *would* want to save her.

But that's stupid. Because Adrien *does* miss his mother. Her photographs in his room, how desperate he'd been to see *Solitude* all make that clear.

Yet he's also moved on in a way his father hasn't. In a way that scares Gabriel, and only widens the chasm of misunderstanding between father and son.

Even if she could believe the Wish works the way she'd once thought it would she's not sure that Adrien would betray Ladybug for his mother's sake. He's too much an Agreste. Too much Gabriel's son to betray his lady.

Or too much the son of the Gabriel she'd thought she'd known. Not this one who gathers Panthera into his arms like she belongs there.

"Hey kid," Plagg saves her from the awkwardness her reverie could have created.

"Good afternoon Adrien," she hopes her voice comes out level and unemotional, "I thought we might talk while your father isn't around?"

His voice cracks a little, though she's not sure if it's puberty or embarrassment, "talk?"

Taking a deep breath in through her nostrils to settle herself she manages to say, "your father has informed me that apparently you think I have a crush on Shadow Moth."

Adrien's hand goes to the back of his neck, "he, uh, told you that?"

"I'm assuming you didn't mean him to."

He didn't meet her eyes, "are you angry with me?"

"I don't understand why you did it." She hates how much sympathy she has for Gabriel's inability to predict his son's actions right now, "Adrien you have to understand that it is *vital* that your father doesn't realise either of us have worn this ring. Connecting me with Shadow Moth in his mind is the last thing we want to do."

It's true enough as far as it goes.

Adrien seems to straighten up in the car seat, "do you though?"

"What?"

Finally he looks her straight in the eyes, "do you like Shadow Moth?"

Deflecting as best she can she turns that right back on him, "why would you think that?"

But Adrien isn't looking like he thinks he's the one who should be ashamed, "I saw you with him in the garden."

"He almost discovered me coming back to the house. I *had* to distract him whatever my own feelings."

He almost pouts like a toddler and not a teenager, "well what's *this* then?"

She takes his phone and stares in horror at the photo of her curled up under Shadow Moth's cloak the other night.

"Nathalie?"

"I won't give him the ring," she tells him, "you can trust me on that."

"That…" he teeth worry his lip, "kind of didn't sound like denial? This is actually real? I've been telling everyone it's photoshopped."

"Please continue doing that."

"But is it?"

Her nails did into the palm of the hand he can't see, "no."

"Why would you-"

"We both needed someone to talk to. If I play along with Shadow Moth's little fantasy then maybe I can take him down."

"And you think you can do that without falling for him?"

"I think it very unlikely my feelings for Shadow Moth will change," after all if her current anger and disillusionment with his father hasn't killed his affection for him then it seems very unlikely anything will.

"I'm just worried about you Nathalie," Adrien does look a little contrite. On the other hand both his parents are good at faking things even if Gabriel's nowhere near as seamless with it as Emilie was.

"Is that why your told your father?"

"Something like that."

But that doesn't sound like the answer at all, "Adrien why did you tell your father?"

For a moment all of Chat Noir's reckless bravery is on display as he says, "I thought if you knew he might lose you he might come out of denial."

She does almost wish the car *had* crashed earlier. It would have been easier to deal with than this. Nathalie's used to coming up short with the Agrestes. But *this* is a new angle that first Plagg and now Adrien are throwing at her.

"Your father isn't in denial," or at least not about his assistant. About why he's going after Panthera is a different matter, "I understand our relationship might look different now but," the only woman he'll ever love is your mother, she means to say but the words die in her throat and she weakly trails off, "it's not like that."

“You reacted better to the idea than Father did,” Adrien seems suddenly less confrontational, “I’ll give you that. But you don’t have to hide it. You’re already part of my family to me.”

She takes her tablet into her hands to distract herself, because she can’t look at her after that with all the secrets she’s keeping from him. “Thank you Adrien but I’m only your father’s assistant. And that’s all I’m ever going to be.” If she even manages to continue to be that.

“You don’t really believe that.”

It’s suddenly very easy to understand how Gabriel cracked a tablet like this. “I’m afraid I do. Now. Did you have anything you wanted to convey to Ladybug? She was asking after you.”

A glance out the side of her eyes shows that Adrien is still scowling but the mention of his Lady has at least distracted him.

Chapter 9: Ladybug I

Ladybug doesn't hesitate.

Panthera gracefully lands on the roof, showing exactly which Miraculous she has, saying "So what have you called me here for this,"

She doesn't get a chance to finish as Ladybug's yo-yo wraps round her and yanks her to the ground.

The woman hits the ground with a gasp as the air is knocked out of her and Ladybug tries not to feel too good about it. If Chat Noir's in danger then *that's* what she needs to focus on. Not just taking revenge for him tempting as it is.

But Panthera's *still* gasping for air, when usually an akuma or their minions would already be fighting back, and Ladybug's own hand spasms in the air looking for a Lucky Charm she doesn't have to tell her what to do.

It could be a trick.

Or…and this shows just how woefully unprepared as a Guardian she is, and really it would be nice if maybe Su-Han actually tried to teach her something instead of just kind of threateningly promising to watch her since she's now having to try to figure out during an actual situation if maybe a Miraculous *doesn't* cure its holder of asthma or things like that while they're wearing them.

She knows it doesn't exactly get rid of flu, so maybe it wouldn't solve that sort of thing either for all it makes little sense with the increased strength and agility it does grant. Though it *does* fit with why Panthera had claimed Chat Noir couldn't appear.

If that's even true.

Not that Panthera looks like she could tell her either way even if she wanted to right now.

It looks really bad.

Now Marinette feels horrible, and her anger is being drained away by panic. Alya should be around here somewhere watching, and she almost wonders if she should yell for her to get an ambulance or something.

Bending down by Panthera she held onto her yo-yo tightly but asked, "are you alright?"

She might deserve in when in between she laboured breaths the woman gasps out, "*seriously?*"

"OK look," Marinette decides, "I can't let you go. But if there's anything else I can do,"

Panthera gestures upwards.

“Oh you want to sit up? We can do that.”

She carefully lets a little more slack into the rope and helps Panthera rest her back against the wall.

The woman’s eyes flick over her and she rests there before she evidently makes some sort of decision and shuts her eyes as she starts to take deeper breaths, clearly trying to get her breathing under control.

It doesn't escape Marinette’s notice that she covers the hand with the ring on it with her other.

But Marinette can wait.

Information is almost as important here as the Miraculous.

“That was quite a greeting,” Panthera wheezes out eventually.

“What’s wrong with you?”

“Now that's a question with a long answer,” the woman mutters.

Marinette frowns in confusion because, “What?”

Panthera’s expression is somehow haughty despite the fact she's looking *up* at Marinette.

“Do you think I’m obliged to give you my private medical information after that?”

Marinette tried to mirror the expression right back at her but wasn’t sure it quite worked, it was throwing her off having someone as a theoretical ally who didn’t automatically accept her leadership the way the temporary holders did.

“Do I think I’m expected not to have questions about you canoodling with Shadow Moth?”

“Canoodling?” Panthera’s brow raised over her eye, “*really?*”

Letting her anger overtake her embarrassment despite the heat of her face Ladybug points out, “You looked pretty cosy.”

“Urgh. I am going to kill whoever took that photo.” Panthera groans.

“Um,” she didn’t *think* she actually meant it but she *did* wield destruction and she was maybe-dating a villain so it wasn’t certain that she didn’t need to say something but…

Panthera rescues Marinette from her uncertainty, “Metaphorically.”

Under the yo-yo string her arm moves as if that was going to be a gesture before her restraints caught it, and she glances down with a wince.

Ladybug does not fidget. She had a reason for what she did and she did it *for* that reason. Replacement partner or not she has a duty to this city and to the Kwamis.

With a sigh the woman sat against the wall says, “I don’t suppose you’re going to untie me until I satisfy you that I’m not betraying it you to Shadow Moth?”

Marinette startles. “How did you-“

Panthera cuts her off, “you tied me up and then confronted me about…”

Even as she trails off some little wicked part of Marinette can’t wait to see what words *she’d* choose to describe that picture. Canoodling had been a perfectly acceptable choice given they weren’t kissing or anything, and *wow* Marinette was glad of that because she never wanted to see Shadow Moth making out with anyone ever, but they’d basically almost been cuddling and just affectionate in a way that screamed out their interest in each other.

“Being too close to Shadow Moth,” the older woman finished.

“Alright,” Ladybug allows, “and *are* you going to try to convince me you’re not too close to Shadow Moth? Or should I just take your Miraculous now?”

Panthera didn’t seem to recognise the kindness of her bringing that idea up in a question instead of yanking the ring off her finger while she was tied up, and could make it difficult, but probably couldn’t manage to stop her, as she bares her teeth and almost *hisses* at her.

“*Chat Noir gave me this.”*

Her nails dug into her palms as she made fists instinctually at the name of the partner she didn’t know was safe, “*Did* he?”

“He did.”

“Chat Noir doesn’t have the right to pick a new wielder,” he wouldn’t without asking me, she means to add but she’s stopped as Panthera yells.

“Cataclysm.”

And then a boiling hot knife seems to stab into Marinette’s hand as her yo-yo disintegrates, as Panthera shakes off the disappearing strings.

“Tikki!”She screams in panic, because pain is something temporary, but she’s never had damage quite like this, from *another Miraculous,* before.

Panthera snorts air from her nostrils, “oh so you *do* care for other people then?”

Marinette’s still trying to regain her own breath, and work out that her hand’s still working, and *“*what?”

Her apparent enemy starts stalking over, her hand up ready to use her power again the way she can as an adult and, “do you even care about Chat Noir *at all?*”

Weapon are not she takes a fighting stance because one thing is clear to her no matter what, “of course I do! How dare you say that when you’ve probably stolen his ring and have him

tied up who knows where, and are you even feeding him and-“

“Wait,” Panthera holds her hand up, “you think I’ve stolen this ring from Chat Noir and I’ve tied him up somewhere?”

“If you took that ring from him by force and then let me go free then I know that Chat Noir would find a way to tell me so, yeah, I do kind of think that’s likely.”

Panthera arms went behind her hair as if pulling it into a ponytail, before releasing it, and her exasperation was clear when she said. “Look, Chat Noir *trusted* me with this ring, and I don’t want to fight you.”

“You just attacked me!”

“After you tied me up and then acted like you didn’t even trust Chat Noir, like he didn’t have the right to decide who should wield *his* Miraculous, like he has to get permission to do *anything,* that boy *loves* you and you treat him like garbage!”

“I never asked him to love me!” It comes out like a yell and she almost feels as startled as Panthera looks.

Swallowing, more quietly she adds, “and I don’t treat him like garbage. I just.”

That gains her a cocked head, “you just?”

“He gets on my nerves sometimes, and I have a lot to handle, and he puts himself in danger for me without me asking and I *hate* that, but then other times he doesn’t turn up at all and what am I *meant* to think? But that doesn’t mean I’m just going to abandon him.”

“Right, look.” Panthera holds her hands up to stop her, “Chat Noir’s busy. He’s…let’s just say his family life is complicated. He has a lot of eyes on him.”

“Including yours?”

“Yes. As a matter of fact. *Yes.* And you don’t know how awful I felt when I realised he *was* Chat Noir and I’d missed it.”

“Chat Noir isn’t a little kid. He *needs* some independence. You can’t micro-manage his life!” Adrien, “One of my friends has that and it *sucks,* it’s like he never gets to be a normal teenager,”

“Because being a superhero is normal teenage behaviour,” she spits with bared teeth, but then her face regains a more human position, “Look. It’s complicate and he has *a lot* on. I can guarantee you that if he’s not turning up it’s not because he’s not bothered. It’s just he *can’t.*”

Marinette *wants* to believe her, because much as it would all be *so much easier* if Chat Noir would drop this idea of them being together and they could just be friends she doesn’t want to believe that all his claims of love and loyalty are *false* but, “*I* always manage to turn up. I don’t get the choice not to.”

She'd *tried* with New York, and look what had happened there. It had turned out that there was exactly where she and Chat Noir needed to be, for all the people caught up in Mayura's attack might have disagreed, but part of her was beginning to wonder if Hawk Moth had somehow followed her there.

It was her Miraculous he wanted after all.

And Chat Noir's.

Panthera's face seemed to soften despite the hard mask covering its entire upper half, "No. You don't. So I guess it's pretty lucky the Miraculous were handed out the way they were even if red *is* much more my colour than green."

"What?"

"I don't know you. I have no idea who you are when you're not Ladybug but like I said I can almost certainly guarantee you that Chat Noir has more eyes on him than you have."

"What do you-" she stops herself, "Don't let me tell what that means."

Panthera's looking at her like she's mad. "OK?"

"I *can't* know Chat Noir's identity. That's important."

"O…K."

Chat Blanc seems to grin over Panthera's shoulder as her lack of conviction bites into Marinette. "It is!"

"Alright. I won't tell you anything more about Chat Noir then apart from,"

"From?"

"You didn't ask him to be in love with you. That's true. But he didn't ask to fall for you either. I'll talk to him about toning things down because you're right, it is too much and I don't know where he." A grimace passed over her face, "scratch that, but I'll talk to him. But. Be kind to him? Sometimes your heart can be inconvenient and even if he shuts up about it that doesn't mean he doesn't still feel it. You've made your feelings clear. That's enough."

"I don't understand how you can sound so much like you care about Chat Noir now, and be fraternising with Shadow Moth the next moment."

"You know how Shadow Moth acts around me."

"Chat Noir acts like that around me. And I don't go around cuddling with him, and he's the opposite of supervillain."

"Urgh." Panthera groans, "I really did not need confirmation that I'm not seeing things there."

Everything they've just spoken about floats in front of Marinette like some imagined pin board with different clues tied together with string, and a few phrases fairly glow.

"I don't know where he-" followed by a sudden realisation.

"Chat Noir acts like…." "How Shadow Moth acts,"

"I'm not seeing things there."

"Shadow Moth reminds you of Chat Noir," Ladybug slowly says.

Panthera's face doesn't change. It doesn't make any expression. But that very lack of a reaction *is* a reaction. It's a refusal to react not her not *having* one.

Then she cocks her head, and something rings false in her tone of voice though Ladybug can't quite work out what it is, "I suppose he does. You don't have to worry about me forgetting who gave me this ring when I'm with him."

"No, I mean…" but Panthera *knows* what she's means and she's being deliberately obtuse.

"I know what you mean. And you're not wrong but if you're worrying about trusting Chat Noir then I can tell you that they're *very* different people."

"I know that. Obviously. Chat Noir would *never* terrorise," but the words stick in her throat because it hasn't happened, but it *could* do, Chat Noir is capable of destroying the city when akumatised, and that *has* to the be akuma, that has to be Hawk Moth's fault just like it is with every other akuma victim, or *hers* even with however discovering each other's identities led to Chat Blanc, because she can't believe her laughing kind kitty has depths of anger like that, "he's nothing like Hawk Moth." She finishes more quietly.

"You didn't sound quite certain there."

She can't help the frown that forms. Panthera's no Lila or Chloé, but she seems to almost be as good at winding Marinette up, "Shouldn't you be defending him? He's your *son* isn't he?"

Apart from why else she'd know him if she hadn't just stolen the ring by chance, and who else Chat Noir would trust his Miraculous to, how she'd harangued Ladybug about keeping secrets and not being an adult had certainly suggested that.

"I thought you didn't want to know anything about either of our identities." Panthera says coolly, "As it happens I agree. Chat Noir is," she frowns a little and then seems to throw away whatever she was going to say, "he wouldn't do what Hawk Moth is doing. But that doesn't mean he's nothing like him. Unfortunately there's a shared sense of humour there."

There's a rueful twist to her lips but a softness around her eyes like when her dad talks about her maman sometimes that suggests a certain fondness, and more things start to slide together.

Embarrassing a question as it is, "You're not in a relationship are you?"

“I’m sorry. What sort of question is that? I’m not going to talk about that sort of thing to a *child*.”

She can’t help but be a little offended by that. People don’t talk down to Ladybug like that. Paris…isn’t unware that Ladybug and Chat Noir don’t look like adults, or she *hopes* not given her dad had thought she was dating Chat Noir but they don’t seem to think about or remember it much either.

Except for Panthera who for some reason seems to be an exception to this. She guesses it’s because she’s thinking of her as Chat Noir’s friend and she’s hardly going to forget *his* age.

“How young do you think I *am?*”

“Not an adult. I’d like to hope you’re just short and you’re just in lyceé but,”

Wait. Was Chat Noir in lyceé?

He didn’t seem mature enough to be older than her but everyone said boys matured more slowly, so *maybe,* if she squinted he could be….

Marinette shook her head frantically. She had to *not* think about Chat Noir.

“Are you alright?” Panthera asks, “or was that just really bad acting in an attempt to pretend you’re *not* at lycée? Ha. Maybe I’ll tell Chat Noir not to chase after older women and see if that gets him to leave you alone.”

“Chat Noir’s not at lyceé?”

“What do you think?”

“I can’t tell when you’re lying and when you’re telling the truth. Which brings me back to how can I trust you? Especially if you’re projecting Chat Noir’s father onto Shadow Moth?”

Panthera’s jaw dropped. Then she made a couple of sounds that weren’t quite words before shaking her head and straightening up and saying, “how on *earth* did you figure that?”

“Well.” Marinette shrugs because it how only came to her as she said it but it *did* make a lot of sense, “I’d guess if you’re letting him hold you like that then you’re single. And by the way? I’m pretty sure most of Paris is talking about that picture.”

“Oh my god,” Panthera covers her face with her hand, “maybe I *should* give Shadow Moth my ring and let him create a new world where none of this has happened.”

Marinette threw her hands in the air, *“seriously?*”

“I wasn’t talking literally. So continue.”

“Right. *And* you’re clearly attracted to Shadow Moth even if that makes no sense whatsoever.”

“It will when you’re older.”

Ew. Ew. *Ew.* “I really think it won’t.”

Panthera gave her a sardonic look. “Or maybe not.”

“*Definitely* not. But anyway you do because he’s tall or whatever,” she *really* in retrospect wished her mother hadn’t decided to let her know that was a thing after seeing a fashion profile of Gabriel Agreste and giving her wink saying it looked like Adrien would sprout up sometime soon and she was a lucky girl, “And he reminds you of Chat Noir soo,”

“So?”

“It makes sense Chat Noir would take after his father, so you’re projecting the man you,” oh *no,* what if he’d died and she was being really insensitive, or what, given that apparently Shadow Moth was like him he was a total dick and she was better off without him, and what non-committal word could she even use and, “…lost?”

That high sqeaky end note was supposed to be only a Marinette thing not a Ladybug one.

Still she forged ahead, “on to Shadow Moth.”

Panthera blinks, “you seriously need media training. Do you have media training?”

“Uh Paris likes me.”

“So long as you keep winning. And actually you have a small but virulent set of haters online.”

There was some information she had never *ever* needed to know. Everything was bad enough already. She was just going to forget that. She *was.*

“Why would you tell me that?”

Panthera held up a hand, “OK yeah that was on me. But seriously I think you do need *some* training, or a PR team, actually have you looked into official branding? There’s a big monetisation possibility here, maybe some cross-marketing with hmm, do you have a celebrity crush?”

“*WHAT?”* She shrieks, “how is, what does that have to do with anything?”

“I supposed we could always just ask Adrien,” Panthera seems to muse, “the voice of Chat Noir and Chat Noir together. That could melt a thousand fangirls hearts.”

“Adrien *Agreste?*”

For some reason it was hard to imagine Chat Noir and Adrien together. She’s sure they’d get on. Adrien would mellow Chat Noir, and Chat Noir would help Adrien loosen up. They could, they’d get on she’s sure, they could become close if she introduced them.

It just seemed a little overwhelming to deal with her feelings for Adrien with Chat Noir there having feelings for her. Her brain feels like it wants to shut down rather than imagine it.

The older woman looks amused. “Do you know another famous Adrien who voi-, oh my god. You like Adrien.”

“Who wouldn’t like Adrien? He’s *perfect.* He’s kind, and he’s not a snob at all and-“

“Alright,” Panthera holds up a hand to stop her, “I don’t need to hear a litany of his amazingness. I’ll take it from you. But to get us back to the point where you don’t break Chat Noir’s heart by showing you don’t trust him at all, and simultaneously discover his identity. I’m not going to just give this Miraculous to Shadow Moth because I’m attracted to him. I can promise you that. Besides if I was going to do that I’d have done it already.”

“When you were cuddling with him.”

“I was *sheltering from the rain.*”

“Why were you even there with him?”

Panthera took a deep breath, “I do get lonely sometimes, you wouldn’t understand but,”

“Oh,” Marinette could laugh, “trust me I understand.”

That gained her a look up and down and then an apologetic, “yes I suppose you do. And…no I’m getting ahead of myself but sometimes it’s easier to talk to an enemy than fight. Especially if you need someone to talk to. And if the only decisive weapon you have is well,” she raises her hand, “a little much unless you want to debate manslaughter versus murder with the law.”

“Tikki,” she feels like the worst person in the world as she remembers that, “you might have hurt her, I,”

Panthera’s hand closes on her wrist, “She’s fine.”

“You can’t,”

“You’re still transformed aren’t you? That’s her power. If you get a countdown when she needs to eat I’m pretty sure you’d have one if she was hurt.”

“I guess that makes sense. Though I’m not sure if I can trust a Shadow Moth sympathiser.”

“Ladybug,” Panthera stares somewhere past her, “what if Shadow Moth’s goals aren’t so bad? What if he doesn’t want to take over the world or something? What if he wants a good thing?”

Oh no. Whatever she claimed Panthera clearly was falling for whatever he was selling. “What sort of good thing could possibly still be good after all he’s done? Do you know the pressure he’s put on this city? My friends live in fear of having their darkest secrets exposed to the world because some horrible man wants to exploit them for power.”

Her voice is awkwardly stiff as Panthera says, “He panics. When I seem unwell. I don’t think it’s a new thing.”

“You think he’s lost someone?” She wasn’t sure how she felt about that, “not a wife or girlfriend with how he treats you, but….a child? A sibling?”

“I do.”

Her defences almost melted but she had to stay strong, “like you have. That’s what you recognise in him.”

Panthera just inhales.

“Did….Chat Noir lost someone too, didn’t he?”

Her eyes are suspiciously wet but her voice is steady as she admits, “yes. That’s why. Look I will stop the flirting. He needs to learn that sometimes loving someone doesn’t mean they’ll ever love you and you have to make your peace with that. But. Be gentle with Chat Noir. Don’t…don’t let him feel unwanted. He…he has reasons to feel more rejected than most kids your age.”

“I…I’m glad I sent him those macarons.” That episode with Alya played in a different light. He’d been afraid he’d not see her again, and she’d brushed it off because he was her friend and of course she wanted to see him but maybe he had a Chat Blanc of his own.

“He appreciated them.”

“Good.”

Neither of them quite seemed to know what to say.

“I’m not sure I trust your judgement,” Ladybug admits, “and *trust* me I’m going to have eyes on you so don’t go sneaking off with Shadow Moth and traumatise us. But. I,” she wasn’t sure why she was saying it but the right path blazed ahead as bright as with any Lucky Charm, “am not going to take your Miraculous right now. You’d better justify that choice.”

“I’ll do my best.” Panthera says, “if you trust in nothing else trust that I want to do the best thing for Chat Noir.”

“Hey, maybe you could convince Shadow Moth to give up,” she tries to smile.

“That really would make everything very simple wouldn’t it? Though I can’t see him agreeing to go to jail.”

“I’d like to see him make things right,” Marinette admits, “but that doesn’t have to be jail.” In some ways it felt like jail wasn’t enough for his victims, like instead Hawk Moth needed to make *amends* for he’d done to each of them. "Honestly I just want all of this to be over.”

“That’s…a very mature viewpoint. Thank you. There’s more to you than I gave you credit for Ladybug.”

“Thanks and-“ was it a weird thing to say? Maybe? *But* it felt like the *right* thing, “maybe you could let Chat Noir have his Miraculous back sometimes so we could message?”

“I could probably do that.”

“And you know. Maybe you should try messaging Shadow Moth. If you wanted to talk in a way that didn’t mean he could grab your Miraculous.”

“Hmm. That’s not a bad idea actually.”

Chapter 10: Gabriel IV

It's probably not a good thing that he's got in the habit of checking the Ladyblog first thing in the morning.

Firstly it's a distraction. It means Ladybug and Chat Noir are the first thing on his mind, and that sets the tone for his thoughts and his moods for the rest of the day making it difficult to concentrate on work.

Even *Audrey's* started to call his designs lacking and that's embarrassing from someone who used to rate him a favourite, never mind the rest of the ties that bind them.

And then to make it even worse there's never *enough* information on the heroes to satisfy him. Just enough to tantalise him with the fact that others are seeing details he missed and yet it's still not what he needs to *find* the heroes out.

Panthera replacing Chat Noir has only made it worse. Now he wakes up tired and lonely and *aching* for a woman in his arms, only to fumble with his phone and let habit lead him to pages upon pages of Panthera, fierce and glorious in battle.

He's pretty sure she'd cataclysm him in an instance if she knew.

Never mind the slick guilt on his stomach everytime the blogger decides to speculate about Mayura and her disappearance and Shadow Moth's apparent choice to move on.

It's not reality.

Their *ideas* of the truth what's happened between Hawk Moth and Mayura, and his new pursuit of Panthera, are nothing like the actual truth of what he owes Emilie and *why* he's going after Panthera.

But the guilt remains.

Guilt for betraying Emilie, for *enjoying* himself on this quest he's set himself.

Guilt for lying to Panthera, who has none of Ladybug's brazen ideals of heroism and is just a tired parent trying to do the best for *her* family like he is for his.

Guilt that stops him admitting the above to Nathalie. Because for some reason the idea of her knowing how he feels about either of those issues makes him feel so much worse.

Guilt for pulling her into this. Guilt for getting her injured. Guilt for letting the world think of Mayura as someone to cast off. Guilt for putting her in a situation where *Adrien* would think her attracted to Shadow Moth.

Because *of course* she's attendant to every fight he has with the heroes. Of course she's devoted to his cause. Because it's the only way to save *her* too.

So guilt is his constant companion.

And his strongest cheerleader.

Winning is the only way to fix everything.

So Gabriel goes on. Goes on sending out akumas. Goes on making plans. Goes on checking the Ladyblog first in the morning.

Today it might even be a good thing he does so.

Even if the phone slips from his grasp and he has to retrieve it from the floor hoping against hope that it hasn't smashed.

Thankfully Tsurugi technology is better than that.

Unfortunately he *did* just read what he thought he read. The only virtue of the situation being that at least he was alone when he did so, because he doesn't want to know what sort of face he just made, and because at least *now* he knows before….

He shakes his head to try to get his brain to work.

No one is going to call *Gabriel Agreste* for a press release on whether *Shadow Moth* is Chat Noir's estranged father.

The so-called article, *conspiracy theory,* goes on to explain its idea. Shadow Moth's clear attempts to win over Panthera, *her* apparent inability to not respond both with annoyance and distraction, apparent similarities between "father" and "son."

They're utterly ridiculous linkages of course. Just because he and Chat Noir might both use puns sometimes means nothing, especially when he'd been semi-aping the hero to get under Panthera's skin. And he's doubtful about any claimed similarity in their fighing techniques given they have different weapons and anyone who can't tell that is an imbecile.

As for the pictures of Chat Noir and Ladybug plastered in comparison of him and Panthera, well that means *nothing.* It's obviously that any two couples flirting might look similar.

Besides Gabriel knows that his son isn't Chat Noir.

That's an important fact he can't forget.

For all the superficial physical similarities between his son and the hero, if their differing personalities weren't enough, there's the fact that Gabriel has considered the idea before and discarded it because he's seen the two of them together.

And there's further proof in the form of Panthera herself.

It's true, and in other circumstances he would worry about it since it's possible what he'd seen before was faked, that Adrien injured himself around when Chat Noir disappeared but Panthera doesn't fit the pattern at all.

Emilie sleeps below them. She isn't out there taking her son's place. And there's no one else that Adrien could theoretically ask. Apart from that teacher of his he doesn't think he knows any adult woman he could possibly entrust such a secret to, except for well, *Nathalie.*

Nathalie who entrusted with that ring would have brought it to him immediately. She might, because he's not *blind* to her affection for his son and upon occasion disapproval of how he raises him, have lied about how she'd acquired it to him and how she'd lost it to Adrien in an attempt to shield them both and do what they'd both asked of her.

But she'd certainly have given to him.

She's not Panthera.

And Adrien isn't Chat Noir.

Unlike the rest of the world Gabriel knows the truth there.

The question though is *why* someone would think that. It can't be the non-existent resemblance between him and Chat Noir that the author keeps trying to show with lines on both their faces. More fool them given that no one anyone has ever said his real son resembles him.

Their conclusion is wrong but *how* they're come to their conclusion might give him some type of clue to Panthera and her life behind the mask. Perhaps there *is* an estrangement between her son and Chat Noir's father and she's accidentally admitted as much.

Perhaps he does somehow remind her of the man.

Both options are theoretically helpful to him and yet only the former fills him with any happiness. Gabriel will never abandon his family and he hates the implication, even by a meaningless resemblance that he would.

Groaning he forces himself out of bed. How exactly he's going to face Nathalie with all this nonsense he doesn't know. Obviously she *knows* it's nonsense but he can't help but feel like she's going to look at him with judgemental eyes that make it oh-so-clear that he's brought it on himself.

Not that it actually matters.

It doesn't *change* anything.

He just doesn't like it.

"You've seen it." Nathalie says, the moment he enters her room. Apparently he's not the only one checking the Ladyblog first thing in the morning.

He allows himself one pinch to the bridge of his nose. “Yes.”

“It doesn’t change anything.” She points out, “you know you’re not divorced from Panthera.”

He moves his hand away from his face, “divorced?”

“I thought that was the gist of the article yes.”

“Well I’m certainly not that.”

“No. You’re not.” She pushes her hair, which he know notices isn’t quite in up to its usual neat standards back away from her face, “this might be a good thing.”

“A good thing?”

“If the heroes think this is the truth then it makes *you* less of a candidate. And I suppose they might go less hard on Chat Noir’s father.”

“The heroes?” It takes him a moment to take the connection, “right. Rena Rouge.” Which rather begs the question of, “do you think *Ladybug* thinks this?”

“That’s the question I’ve been asking myself, but apart from maybe it giving you a better chance should Panthera intercede with you to Ladybug I can’t see it does us any harm or good that she does.”

“Apart from the embarrassment.”

“If you cared about the public embarrassment you wouldn’t have done any of this.”

It takes a moment for Nathalie’s words to sink in, a tendril of her hair has escaped back to her face, and there’s the slightest wave to it, and now he’s busy wondering how she’d look with other hairstyles, with it down, with something a little bit more wild like Panthera and, “hmm, wait, are you trying to insult me?”

“Are you taking that as an insult?”

“I suppose I can’t pretend I’m not a risk-taker,” he chuckles.

A knock at Nathalie’s door throws them both off.

“Adrien,” she mouths at him, and ah, that does make a certain sort of sense. His son, despite his new predilection for rebellion is a good boy. He’d want to make Nathalie’s life easier by coming to her room in the morning to get his schedule rather than coming to hers.

That’s something he’s not really thought about *enough* with Adrien. That his son might be more like himself than he’d realised. More motivated by the people he cares for than by rules.

It must be the stupid article making him think about resemblances but maybe this *is* something to consider when disciplining Adrien. He must ask Nathalie.

“Come in son,” he calls.

Adrien looks shifty and awkward as he enters the door, “uh I was just coming to,”

“Ask Nathalie for your schedule I’m sure. I’m afraid I had some urgent business to discuss with her.”

“Uh, that’s fine. She can. Um. Email it to me.”

Adrien’s nerves almost shine off him. It reminds Gabriel of once when Emilie had tried to prepare a surprise with Adrien with for his birthday and their five year old son had reverted to hiding behind Emilie’s legs at every moment he saw him in his attempt to keep the secret.

The memory makes his heart twist in his chest.

Had that article got it right then Gabriel would have been fighting his own son all this time. Would have injured his son countless times. Jeered at him.

Killed him, perhaps if not for Ladybug.

It’s true that for Emilie he might do much, might do *anything,* and if Adrien *did* dare to stand between him and those Miraculous knowing that it was his mother’s life he was ending by doing so then….then maybe he’d have to tell himself none of this would have happened in the new world he’d created.

Now looking at Adrien he’s filled with a sudden immense gratitude that could almost make him burst that his son *is* Adrien and not Chat Noir. That the worst he has to deal with are a few silly ideas about wasting his life, and not the boy deciding to be a hero. That *their* fights are never physical because that’s not a line he ever wants to cross.

Bruises long-healed decades ago suddenly feel sore on his legs.

Without Emilie’s prompting he’d forgotten just how lucky he is with Adrien. Just how thankful he should be with his son. That they’re been able to raise him into a child it’s not so difficult to be a better father to than his own was to him.

“If you’re sure,” he says to Adrien.

“Yeah. It’s fine.” Adrien gives a slight, not-disrespectful but conveying it’s not a big deal shrug, before turning to leave the room.

“Adrien,” he stops him, “you’re a good son. Most of the time. I’m glad you’re mine.”

Adrien is polite and obedient and the furthest thing possible from the wisecracking hero, and he’s not even sure that’s why he feels those words with such certainty in this moment. But he does.

His son’s wides widen, but then he grins, “I’m glad you’re my father too. So glad.”

There's more force to that last sentence than might be expected. He can't be going too badly with raising Adrien in Emilie's absence. Probably Nathalie's influence. Maybe he should listen to her more.

He smiles down at her once Adrien's left, "well if Adrien gets round to reading that article at least it might stop him worrying about you having a crush on Shadow Moth. A man hung up on another woman and fighting his own son is hardly a romantic idol is he?"

"No. I doubt Adrien would think that. Though I'd guess he's already read the article."

"You think?"

"All teenagers are obsessed with the superheroes. That's *why* we let him voice Chat Noir."

"True," concern hits him, "do you think we need to distance him from the hero? If he's being linked to Shadow Moth now?"

"I'll monitor it."

"Good," he looks at her, so ready with her tablet, and determined just like Panthera and wonders, "Do you think Panthera *did* say something to Ladybug?"

"What do you mean?"

"Well we know that their idea about Chat Noir and Shadow Moth is complete nonsense, but is there a grain of truth at the middle of it all? Is there an estranged father?"

Panthera's always been cagey on that question with him. But there's a glaring flag in the very fact that in all the reasons she's told him to leave her alone they've never included that she's in a relationship.

He wonders whether she might actually appreciate it if he sent an akuma after such a man. He'd deserve it. Gabriel's never been able to fathom how people can justify leaving their families.

"I'd say it's likely the girl's got the idea from something real but I don't think you should go out making assumptions. Maybe it would be for the best if you acted as if she *is* still married."

"I don't think she is," Gabriel says, "there's a…"

"A what?"

"A yearning in Panthera," but words feel weak for the emotion he feels from her, "for….she wants have a happy family, to be loved I think."

"I can't deny that sounds familiar, uhm, as a single woman," she glances down, and it hits him that despite Adrien's ideas he's never really considered that Nathalie might actually want something like that for herself, she's always seemed so content to devote herself to his cause

despite the effect it must have on any sort of social life even before she put on that Miraculous.

Nathalie continues with a sigh “And you don’t feel bad for taking advantage of that?”

“Of course I do. But I am a villain after all.”

Nathalie’s face creases as her brows draw down, and she leans towards him, and sincerity shines in her eyes, “that’s not the truth of you Gabriel. I know that.”

“I swore that I’d see this through. Nothing else matters in comparison to that.”

“Of course,” Nathalie murmurs quietly.

He can’t help but take her hand, “this will come to end Nathalie. I promise you that, I’ll make the wish and you’ll be well again and you’ll be free to go wherever you want to go, though I can’t deny I’ll miss you if you decide to abandon my to the clutches of an inferior assistant.”

“Let’s focus on winning first. And you should go get dressed for work. So should I really.”

Still the article and how Panthera must feel about if, and if there *is* some failure of a man out there lingers in his mind.

And maybe it makes him a little bit more satisfied than usual to find an akuma that night close enough to the house that it’s easy for him to slip out and find the superheroine after the battle.

“*You,”* Panthera hisses. “Could you not just hold off for once?”

“And there was I thinking maybe we could go for a nice stroll in moonlight?”

“So we could get photographed again? I don’t think so, or you definitely won’t be seeing me again.” She raises an eyebrow, “or did you really think Ladybug was going to trust me hanging out with you?”

“I didn’t think you were beholden to a little girl.”

She scowls, he’s hit a weak spot there, “that’s not the point. I’m not interested Shadow Moth, leave me alone.”

Or so her words say but as he reaches out with his power the mix of emotions inside her is much more less of a definite brush off. She’s irritated at him, lots for an akuma to work with there certainly, but below that there’s a part of her that wants to give in. Wants that choice to be taken from her so no one could blame her.

Alas for Panthera that might in fact turn out to be one of those boundaries he'd claimed not to have to Nathalie.

Still he has to wonder about *why* she feels she can't. If it is just her responsibilities as a heroine and that he's a villain, or if there *is* another man after all.

"Why?" He chances, "does someone already hold your heart? Chat Noir's father perhaps?"

Her hair seems to fluff up somehow. A Cat indeed apparently. She bares her teeth shining in the dark, "That's irrelevant."

Oh.

His little kitty cat is good. She's no Nathalie with her impenetrable walls that have taken years of careful erosion for him to learn as much as her as he has and still stand strong, but she is good at guarding anything more personal than the anger any heroine should have for the villain of the piece.

Though he supposes he's never tried quite this trick on Nathalie; who knows how *she* might react?

Still he's managed to hit something real there when he hadn't really expected to and now it feels like he's in completely different terrain.

Shoving aside his disquiet he grins, "so defensive. Tell me are the press right? Things aren't so rosy amongst your darling superfamily?"

Her shields slip back down, and his question. "The press would have it you're his father."

"Touché," he says, then "do you love him?"

He's surprised by how honestly the words come out. That wasn't just about getting her Miraculous. He *wants* to know.

She raises her eyebrows, "Chat Noir's father? Yes."

And yet, his miraculous roils on his chest with turmoil, all isn't right in paradise. "Tell me about him?"

She crosses her arms, and inclines her head, "What? Are you actually serious?"

"There's no akuma anymore." he points out, "your little friend sorted that out."

She shudders, "please don't call her that."

Her considers Panthera again, and the fact that she's never quite admitted to Chat Noir *being* her son. Just apparently the son of the man she's in love with.

Then he considers what she'd look like with human eyes, with the blue he keeps going back to when he tries to imagine her out of costume.

"Little sister?" He offers instead.

Both eyebrows raise this time. "Seriously?"

Perhaps not. Though she could still be acting despite there being no emanation from her heart suggesting fear at being caught out.

Still he shrugs. "Half-sister. It doesn't seem impossible. Perhaps it's not Chat Noir who recruited you after all."

She looks away. "I'm hardly going to answer that."

"You're a strange one to work out," he muses taking another step closer to her and offering her a hand, "want to go make your beau jealous with me?"

She makes a noise somewhere between an expulsion of air and a laugh, "I don't think that's going to work out the way you hope. No, he's had his chance to notice me and he…" a tilt of her head, "hasn't. I'm certainly not deluded enough to think a walk with *you* is going to change anything there."

Personally Gabriel has always found jealously quite an effective motivator. It would have taken him twice the time to marry Emilie if he hadn't thought Colt was interested in her rather than Amélie at first.

And it's that same acid hatred in his gut that makes him ask, "Well he sounds like an idiot then. What makes him so special? Chat Noir's father?"

Panthera just looks away from him. Dangerous really when he could still attack. It this is trust then he feels uncomfortable with it.

"He doesn't know his son *is* Chat Noir." She says staring into space instead of answering his question. "And I don't know if I should tell him."

With all that stupid article in his head, and the guilt he has for deceiving her, here he *doesn't* deceive her. Parent to possible parent, quasi-parent, whatever she is to Chat Noir he says, "I'd want you to tell me. In his position"

"You're Shadow Moth. Of course *you'd* want to know. You want his Miraculous." But there's less venom in her voice than just exhaustion. Like Nathalie. If his guilt wasn't bad enough.

"Well. Yes." But her assumption prickles at some soft spot in him, "it would be convenient but I still wouldn't want that to be the case. To think I'd been that blind. That I'd fought him, that," his voice cracks.

Everything he'd pushed away earlier, the scenarios he'd imagined, suddenly flood back in full force. A bruise blossoming across Adrien's cheekbone from *his* cane, a cut destroying the perfect symmetry of his son's face.

She reaches up and cradles the side of his mask, her fingers landing so softly on the same place he'd imagined wounding his son on, "why do it then? You don't know he isn't. And

even if he is then, he's always been someone's son. This, this isn't all of you is it? You're a better man this this I'm sure of that. So why do you do it? Why do you hurt my boy?"

He swallows, and steps back out of her hold. "You can't expect me to admit that."

"And you wanted me to tell you about Chat Noir's father."

"That's hardly equal." He tries to argue, he hadn't mean to ask for any *identifying* details. He'd just wanted to know.

Panthera looks him right in the eyes. "It is to me. Good bye Shadow Moth."

Chapter 11: Nathalie IV

It's not that Nathalie doesn't appreciate what Plagg's doing for her. It's really not. And it's not that she's not willing to suffer through the side-effects. Not dying is pretty decent end result for a little bit of difficulty along the way, and as shown by her very situation she's dealt with worse for less.

Only it is *really really* unhelpful for her limbs to decide to stop responding to her when she's already trying to run back to the office to beat Gabriel and his non-insignificant advantage of a lift down to the place they're both meant to be from his entry to the house.

Maybe it's her own fault for not wearing the exoskeleton but it's a irritant when she doesn't really need it and besides she thinks then she'd just have been stuck in place anyway.

Though admittedly that might have been better than falling to the fall like she is now.

Time seems to slow down as the floor approaches, but thankfully her arms decide to obey the frantic signals coming from her brain, albeit sluggishly, like they're moving through oil not air, and she manages to break her fall.

Hitting the ground still hurts, and she's already taken a thump or two fighting the akuma even if Shadow Moth does seem to be trying to make them go easier on her.

Thankfully it doesn't set her off coughing.

Not thankfully even as she rolls onto her side in an attempt to get to a position she *can* get up from Gabriel appears from the floor.

"What on earth?" His brows draw together, "Nathalie?! Are you ok?"

"I tripped," she tries play to it off as nothing serious, to inject a little self-deprecation into her tone, as if she's annoyed but not worried.

In fact she's *very* worried. Her right leg still isn't responding and if it doesn't soon then Gabriel will notice. She has the cover of the damage from the Peacock Miraculous of course, but if she keeps having episodes immediately after Panthera's been out in action he could notice a pattern.

Neither of them had with Adrien, something she's still reproaching herself for, but unfortunately she spends a lot more time with Gabriel then either of them do with Adrien.

Really the question she'd like answered is how exactly his *school* never bothered to report all his absences to them. The confusion of an akuma action she guesses, or maybe more likely the administration wanting to protect the hero it's so proud of.

Or *heroes*.

The fact that the other heroes are all connected to Adrien, and that Ladybug seems to be around the same age is something Nathalie is very carefully not thinking about given that she's fairly certain at this stage that Plagg *isn't* lying and the Wish isn't the panacea she'd hoped for.

That's an issue for another time with how Gabriel's running over to her.

"You're bleeding."

"What?" She didn't hit the ground *that* hard, and when she checks her hands in confusion they're absolutely fine.

"Your nose."

There is a dampness above her lip now he says that and as she reaches out with her tongue curling it upwards she comes into contact with a familiar warm saltiness.

"Nathalie," he sounds appalled, and she thinks he really must have let Emilie handle the lion's share of Adrien as a child if something like that disturbs him so much, given that he's better than you've expect with her medical needs due to Emilie.

She just shrugs at him, "Do you have a tissue?"

Gabriel shakes his head, "Come on," and half-carries half-helps her down into the recessed seating around the catwalk and then down…

On to his lap.

Breathe Nathalie. She reminds herself. You can do this.

"Here," he pulls a handkerchief from his pocket but he doesn't actually give it to her, holding it to her nose himself and supporting her back with his other arm.

Since it leaves her arms free she takes advantage to pinch her nose and incline her hand in and attempt to halt the bleeding.

It takes more effort than she'd like but at least this attacks of non-response from her body are only ever temporary. Plagg thinks they'll probably go away. Probably.

"Oh my poor Nathalie," Gabriel repeats her name again.

Harshly she wonders if she does it to remind himself exactly *which* woman he has in his arms right now. Because between her, Emilie, and Panthera she thinks it must get confusing.

That's the uncomfortable thing, this thing she hates the most; that Gabriel, whatever other reasoning he might use for his actions, is clearly attracted to Panthera and yet he holds her the same way, with the same care, regardless of whether she's wearing the mask or not.

It makes her feel like he *could* want Nathalie too, especially with all the nonsense Plagg's put in her head, and Adrien's well-intentioned encouragement on top of that.

Makes her feel like maybe there is a way out where he chooses her and gives up as if Gabriel has ever been a forgiving man, and their platonic relationship isn't built on his trust in her.

"This should never have happened to you," he continues, and she's gladder than ever to know that he doesn't spy on her emotions *as Nathalie.*

She can feel his lips against the top of her head as he says, "one day I'll beat Ladybug," she notices how conspicuously absent Panthera's name is, "and then I'll fix all of this. This will never have happened to you, you're be healthy and,"

"Umph," she tries to express her disagreement despite her blocked nose.

"What?"

"You can't do this for me," for Gabriel and through him for Emilie she might be able to let this go but the idea that one day Adrien will be able to take his ring back, and then Gabriel will fight him for *Nathalie's* sake is utterly unacceptable to her, "this is for Emilie isn't it?"

She hates that she sounds so unsure when she says it but Shadow Moth comes on so strongly to Panthera, and then Gabriel holds her like this, and it's hard to remember that she'd believed in his devotion to his wife once.

That she'd loved him for that.

Because it feels like then she shouldn't love him anymore but she thinks that…maybe she still does because every uncertain beat of her heart in his presence says that and that's a harder thing to deal with.

"Yes," Gabriel's voice deepens, rough with grief, "you know that's why I started this, but surely, *Nathalie,* you can't believe I'd leave you alone and swan off in my own happy bubble. I'm going to make this right. When I'm done no one will have suffered? You understand that don't you?"

Gravity drags down on her, much more than it should do, out of nowhere and her head lolls forward as she mumbles, "what if the Wish isn't that simple?"

Gabriel's constant circles on her back with his hand stop, "What?"

"What if, what if we've underestimated the price? Or what if we can't control it that much?"

Slowly his hand starts to move more slowly against her again, she feels his swallow against the side of her scalp, "you're read something?"

"I've found new information," she doesn't lie, it doesn't matter *how* she's obtained it, the matter is she *has,* "we might not be the first to attempt the Wish."

“I’d doubt we are,” Gabriel scoffs, “I might strive to originality but I’m not so pigheaded as to think I’m the first man in the world ready to rewrite reality to regain someone I love.”

“Or woman,” Nathalie corrects automatically before she realises what she’s just implied.

“Or woman,” Gabriel agrees with an even tone, and not the slightest jolt against or under her suggesting he’s aware of what she’s just almost confessed.

He continues, “and you think they managed it? Or is it just a warning?”

“It’s hard to know.” True Plagg has reasons to obscure the truth from her, “texts from those times can be unreliable,” she’s looked into it herself since Plagg had said what he had but had the Pharoah’s second wife died for his first and that, that’s not so bad, if *that’s* why Gabriel’s interest in her alter-ego has been leading up to she could cope. She’d be out of all this, all of this shame and pain and at rest and everyone she cares about would be happy.

And yet she can’t throw it all aside because she won’t manage to get that, if it’s someone Gabriel truly, *actually,* loves then it’s *Adrien* and she can’t allow that at it.

“Nathalie?” Gabriel prompts her, and she’s been silent too long she’s pressed this all up.

So there’s only one thing she can say.

“They’re consistent.” True. Plagg doesn’t waver on what he tells her and she’s yet to find a single thing to contradict it. “You can change the world but you can’t control *how.* What if…”

But her voice fails her unable to even speak the words into mind.

“What if *what* exactly? *Nathalie*, what if?”

“What if it stops Adrien’s existence?” She blurts out, “if Emilie lives because she never got the Peacock and you divorced as a result, or if you two never married, or never *met?* I don’t know maybe you’d lucky and the two of you just never met *me* but,”

“No,” Gabriel interrupts her, “I don’t want to diminish your skills my dear, I doubt anyone else could have jumped professions like you have, but I was determined to get Emilie those gems. If it hadn’t been you then it would have been someone else.”

He’s not wrong. She’s *good.* She might have done it faster than anyone else. But she’s not big headed enough to think she’s the only person who could ever find those Miraculous.

Which unfortunately destroys the idea she’s been halfway playing with of maybe working out a way to steal the Rabbit instead. It’s just too complicated, too likely to fail.

“I wish you weren’t right there,” she responds eventually. And she *does,* and not even just for Adrien’s sake or for Gabriel’s sake or indeed Emilie’s sake but *for her own.*

In a world where she’d never met the Agrestes, where Tomoe Tsurugi had never recommended her to them, it feels like everything would have been so much simpler.

She's not stupid enough to think it would be *perfect* or necessarily normal, it probably still wouldn't be with her past, but the Agrestes *are* extraordinary and she doesn't think it's any exaggeration to say it never would have become as complicated as this.

"I…yes," Gabriel swallows, "do you really think *Adrien* could be at risk?"

"I think we can't trust that he wouldn't be."

His head makes an aborted movement back, like he was about to look at Emilie's portrait.

"I couldn't bring her back to that."

"She mightn't," she stops herself. She wants Gabriel to *not* do this. To think about what he's doing.

"Mightn't what?"

She fumbles through an attempt to explain without making it sounds like a desirable outcome, "If you recreated the world then I suppose you'd recreate every person in it, me, Emilie, everyone else, we be a different version of ourselves who wouldn't know better."

"A version of you that wasn't like this," Gabriel sounds suddenly almost *angry,* and she's not prepared for how his voice changes, "*why* would you tell me this Nathalie?"

"Sir?"

"What do you want me to *do*?"

"I- I wanted you to have all the information before you made a mistake."

"*Made a mistake?* If what you're saying is right then I've *already* made the mistake! I haven't been Hawk Moth for fun, bridges have been burnt, everything but bringing Emilie back has been allowed to slide, even *my own son* has fallen down my priority list, and *you,* look at what's happened to *you,* and now you tell me I can't fix any of this without the chance of making things worse?"

"We can still fix things. The Miraculous isn't everything. The company's still successful, you can make it moreso, build friendships back up and-"

"That was *Emilie's* role."

She flinches back from the sudden increase in volume.

"And it doesn't matter," he continues, "because maybe some of it can be salvaged, maybe I take control of Adrien's upbringing back even though I will never ever be able to be for him want his mother was but I will never be able to save *her,* never be able to save….you."

Acids burns at the back of her throat at her own stupidity at not hiding her symptoms better. And her selfish pride stopping her from just wearing the damned exoskeleton. That if she'd just accepted help earlier then he wouldn't be looking at her right now.

“You don’t have to save me.”

“Don’t I? you-“

She stops him. “Got cocky and did myself some damage.”

“Exactly.”

“I’m not getting worse,” she says firmly, “it might be harder for you to tell because it’s so minor a change, or not change. But I can tell how I’m feeling and short of me putting that Miraculous back on I am *not going to die.*”

This time his voice is quiet, the raging man replaced by a scared little boy, “Emilie said that too.”

“Emilie didn’t know what was happening to her until too late. And Emilie was-“ Nathalie’s had some uncharitable thoughts about the choices Madame Agreste had made over the years and her frivolity when it came to the Miraculous but now certainly not the time to air any of that. She should probably *never* air any of that to Gabriel.

“Stubborn,” Gabriel fills in for her, and yes that does sum up much of it, then he adds, “like you. I seem to be cursed in that way. You. Emilie. Adrien. Even his bloody bodyguard. None of you listen to me at all do you?”

“I do listen to you. But keeping you safe is more important to me than keeping your ego safe.”

“And yet you’re asking me not to do the same for you.”

“I’m not worth the danger of making that wish.”

He doesn’t respond at first, and then with a shuddering breath, the words seem to burst out of him. “Emilie would say she wasn’t either.”

She waits.

There’s nothing she can say that mightn’t unbalance Gabriel from the precarious tightrope leading to the solution she’s hoping for that he’s just stepped on to.

“She was quite happy for me to go after the two Miraculous you know,” he says, and there’s the ghost of a smile on his lips, “and I think she’d have liked the idea of the world being remade around her, *for* her. And she’d accept *my* sacrifice,”

Nathalie’s heart jumps into her throat, “*your?”*

There’s the slightest head of his head, “I considered it you know. I didn’t *want* it. I wanted her back *with me.* To enjoy the world I made for her. But if it took that, then, I thought it would be been romantic at least. Something worthy of a legend. She’d see that.”

“*Gabriel,”* now it’s her voice breaking.

He gives no sign of hearing her, “but Adrien. If I killed our son she’d never forgive me. Anything less than that and she could fix but if I snuffed him out of existence then she’d murder me herself if she knew. And even if she didn’t….*I’d* know. She wouldn’t be my Emilie if she could be happy without Adrien.”

“No,” that much Nathalie doesn’t have to force herself to concede about Emilie. Adrien had been a dearly *wanted* child by his mother. “She wouldn’t be.”

“Because my Emilie’s his mother.” He huffs, “that’s the real reason Panthera won’t give in to me you know?”

Nathalie’s truly lost at whatever connection he’s made there.

“She’s not a hero. Not at her core. There’s none of Ladybug’s self-righteousness there, she might actually be capable of understanding *why* I fight.”

“I don’t think she’d be impressed with the flirting then.” She can’t help but point out.

“Probably not. But no, the issue is Chat Noir.”

“Chat Noir?”

“That I’m *his* enemy is why I’m hers. I suppose I’m lucky I’ve never done anything worse to the boy.”

You don’t know how right you are there.

Nathalie reaches for Gabriel’s free hand, even though he’s never let go of the bloodied handkerchief, “you don’t have to do anything more to him.”

His tone goes dull and empty, lost of the conviction inhabiting it moments earlier, “you want me to give up too.”

“I’m not his mother but I,” *love,* “care a lot for Adrien too.”

“And that’s the only thing you’re frightened of going wrong with the Wish?”

“Well,” it takes a courage she didn’t think she had, for all she’s told Shadow Moth she loves Gabriel even if he doesn’t know that’s what she meant, “I wouldn’t want it to take you either.”

One moment his hand simply allows hers on his, and then it’s holding hers back, “And?”

“And?”

“Aren’t you forgetting something?”

Her frown almost hurts as she tries to work that out, though the pain might be from the recent burst blood vessel in her nose, “I don’t know what you mean.”

“Surely you don’t want to risk it taking *you*?”

“Why would it take me? You just told me that you two would have managed to get the Miraculous anyway.”

Gabriel lets go of her hand, “you’re the one telling me it’s unpredictable.”

“I suppose. It’s just not something I’d considered. That we might never had met seems probable but,”

“Do you wish,” there’s the slightest hint of a wince at his word choice, “that we hadn’t? I suppose you must. You wouldn’t be like this otherwise. Perhaps you that yearning of yours wouldn’t be a yearning.”

It’s harsh of her that she’s surprised that he remembers that admittance of hers. She’d thought between Emilie and Panthera he’s had no mind to spare for *Nathalie* beyond her health. Certainly not for her romantic life, or lack thereof.

“Don’t put words in my mouth.” She retorts and cringes a little that her irritation at *herself* is finding a target in him, “or try and blame yourself for my choices.” There’s plenty of blame for him for his sudden idiocy as Shadow Moth.

“Am I supposed to be *happy* about what’s happened to you? That you still might die?”

“I’m not going to *die.*”

“You don’t know that,” he snaps, “you’ve given me two unacceptable options here. Either I do nothing and let the world stay as it *is* with you crippled and Emilie *gone,* or I make the Wish and risk it going wrong. And we don’t even know that’s definitely the case, if it came from anyone other than you then I’d think it was a lie to make me surrender.”

“Not making the Wish doesn’t mean things have to stay as they are.”

“Yes, yes, I know you’d have me devote myself to the rest of my life.”

“That’s not what I mean.”

His eyes sharpen, “what do you mean?”

“The Miraculous isn’t the only magic in the world. The Wish isn’t even the only magic other than the standard abilities of the Miraculous.”

“Nothing else is strong enough to save you both.”

“We used to think that about fixing the Peacock Miraculous, and look where we are now. And Ladybug’s powers only seem to be growing more and more. Maybe we have more options than we thought.”

“Maybe we do,” his voice is strained, “but how we’d *get* the information I don’t know.”

“We got the Butterfly and the Peacock didn’t we?”

“We did.”

“And anyway, maybe Ladybug won’t talk to you. But Panthera might.”

“I’m not sure Panthera is too pleased with me,”

Nathalie has to stifle a snort at that.

“But,” he continues, “if she thought that maybe this could bring an *end* to all of this. Then. Yes, I think that might make her talk.”

“It might even make Ladybug listen to her.”

“That I’m less sure of. But I suppose even pests must get tired. Having her time back might sway her. Hmm. Come on, let’s get you back to bed and you’re staying there all tomorrow.”

“No.”

“Yes. Because there’s no reason for you to get up to research these translations of yours and that’s your task for the foreseeable future. If I’m to change course it has to be because it’s the only option.”

Chapter 12: Nooroo I

The mood in the room is dark and oppressive.

So is the room itself, as Gabriel Agreste lies on his bed, with the lights off and the curtains shut.

The cavernous size of the bedroom doesn't even offer the illusion of freedom to Nooroo as he flutters around in the darkness unable to see to the walls surrounding them. The butterflies that his master uses to make his akumas are freer than him.

Duusu stays close to his side. Neither of them wanting to attract Gabriel's attention.

Their jailer seems unware of them. Lost in his own despair and angry. The two emotions fighting it out instead him.

To others he's just a man lying on a bed.

To Duusu and Nooroo he's a veritable storm. A hurricane of feeling. Holding the possibility to turn all that damage inside him outward and spread destruction over the city through the magic that binds them to him.

It's hard when you feel things like Nooroo does not to be affected by it. He hates the man. But he pities him too. He *wants* to make things better for him. That's what he does. Why he reaches out to those calling out to him to transform them into what they need to be.

What he's forced to do now is a pervasion of his powers but unlike how poor Dusuu's amoks are made and destroyed like nothing to none one's benefit, not even Gabriel's when it only gives the man enough hope to stay on this path of destruction even he doesn't really enjoy, his at akumas might not be *wanted* but he still manages to make them, with Ladybug's aid, something of what people *need.* They can at least be a cry for help.

In that way he can claw back some of this for himself. Usually. Some of those who call out to him, like the girl who's more ally of sorts than victim of his master with the empty void inside of her looking for recognition, he can't help.

Gabriel Agreste himself is much the same. He's beyond Nooroo's ability to do anything to help him climb out of the hole he's dug himself.

If he akumatised himself now it wouldn't be anything as controlled as the Collector has been. He doesn't think his master would even *know* what he wanted, *needed,* in this case until the akuma took over and made him forget all those nuances, and those he loved, that might usually stay his down.

Nooroo stills as if he could disappear and avoid being called on if he's not *seen* when he senses that Gabriel is about to talk. But there's no command to transform him.

Instead Gabriel draws in a deep breath through his nose. “Did you two know?”

Duusu curls inward with a huff, “like you’d have listened.”

It makes him flinch a little. He’d forgotten, but when Duusu’s good relationship with Nathalie had been down to the broken Miraculous, that his fellow kwami has always had a sharper side than he has. Duusu no longer condones villainy but. Well. Duusu doesn’t feel bad for *not* being about to help Gabriel be better unless maybe for Miss Nathalie’s sake.

The man sits up, annoyance clearly drawn across his face, despite how little they can see. Tension clear in every muscle of his body.

“So you did,” it’s not the usual snappish dismissal Nooroo’s used to. This is still carry warning in every syllable, but it’s more considered more thoughtful, almost silky in place of the usual harshness.

It’s the type of tone that though he cannot understand *why* Nooroo has seen provoke a certain squirm Miss Nathalie, has felt, as much as he’s aware of anything when he’s transforming his master, from Panthera.

Humans seem have a connection between danger and attraction that Nooroo still doesn’t understand despite his millennia with them.

“Strange when the Guardians kept so much from you. Understandable, if unhelpful, but then why would they let you know *this.* Perhaps Nathalie’s idea of it being a warning is right, just a story to-“

“No.” Duusu interrupts with a confidence that Nooroo *hopes* comes from the Gabriel probably no being able to make them out. “They didn’t tell us. You’re right, they wouldn’t have. It’s sooo unfair.”

Now there’s that irriatated snap. “So? How do you know?”

“We felt it.” Duusu explains, “we just know. This isn’t the world as it was.”

“So it has been done before.”

“Yes,” Nooroo says quietly, “not for a long time now but…yes.”

“What happened?”

Nooroo wishes that he could be more helpful, wishes he could have been more helpful back then but, “we don’t know. Maybe Sass does, or Fluff but if they do they’re not telling. We just…we can feel that this isn’t how things are supposed to be Master. And the absence that’s lost from the world.”

“If I discover that’s you’re not telling the truth neither of you will eat until you’d too weak to transform me.”

“We *are* telling the truth,” Duusu lunges forward and Nooroo has to grab Duusu to pull the other kwami back as he looks ready to fly at their master to attack.

“Miss Nathalie wouldn’t lie to you,” Nooroo reminds him, and then remembers that’s not quite true or she’d not have been Duusu’s wielder for so long but still, “not like this. She wouldn’t tell you this if she didn’t think you needed to know it.”

“No,” Gabriel shakes his head, “Nathalie has every reason to want me to continue. To want me to *win.* She of all people has no reason to tell me not to go after the only thing that could heal her.”

“She’s doing better.”

“With the help of a *machine,*” Gabriel spits.

“That *you* got for her.”

The man huffs, “Hardly. Tomoe’s always loved a challenge and she’s hardly without reason to feel guilty for Nathalie’s condition too.”

With someone else what to say would be obvious but he knows just how volatile his master is. Still, for his own sake, and the sake of the world and his fellow kwamis he has to try.

“Maybe you should talk to Miss Nathalie about it? About what to do? She said you shouldn’t risk it and-“

“No.” Gabriel cuts him off, “Nathalie won’t admit weakness. It’s that damned stubbornness of hers. She’ll sit there and say, “I’m fine sir. Just make the right choice for yourself. And for Adrien. That will help me feel better. And not mention that she’s dying. Just like Emilie.”

Beside him Duusu startles and then frowns, “Mrs Emilie….I, I knew her.”

“You killed her,” Emilie’s husband curtly corrects.

Nooroo blinks and wonders if he’s aware that this is the first time he’s admitted that the woman Shadow Moth is fighting to save *is* essentially dead. That if she was taken out of that casket, or even if it lost power for too long, she would be.

In the circumstances, with him considering stopping more *seriously,* than ever before it’s not as reassuring as it should be.

“When my Miraculous was broken?” Duusu asks, “but why would she use it? She wanted to, I remember that. It was important. It was *love.* But why? She was so sick but it was….”

Gabriel almost blinds then turning on the light switch at the bed. “It was, *what* exactly?”

“Different to Miss Nathalie.” Duusu says eventually sounding unsure but still not scared enough.

“Different in terms of their health? Or in why I did it.”

“I don’t know,” Duusu whines, suddenly on the verge of tears, “it was like a nightmare.”

Nooroo feels for his fellow Kwami but Duusu feels things very strongly. Any volatility wasn’t wholly due to the broken Miraculous.

“Useless,” Gabriel hisses. “Nooroo, go check on Nathalie.”

“Of course master,” Nooroo flies through the walls as fast as he’s able to because, he’s just been allowed to leave his master’s side, to go out of Gabriel’s sight and this is new new new, and it’s not freedom, not liberty. He has a task.

Nathalie has always been a weakness for his master. Save for Adrien she’s the only other person he’s seen a plan be halted for.

And now, unless the villain remembers to reinforce his old command, thanks for Gabriel’s concern for Nathalie Nooroo’s pretty sure he’s not bound by that anymore. That he can at least roam in search of Nathalie now.

His flight is so fast he doesn’t manage to come to the stop he should of in Nathalie’s room elegantly just inside it.

Instead he slows over her bed, coming to a stop in front of her face.

This would be fine where it *only* Nathalie in the room.

And had Adrien been here he’d not have been able to do it. The laws that bind the Kwamis to the Miraculous would have stopped him entering. Gabriel’s command to never let his son see him is still in place.

But he’d not said anything about avoiding other kwamis. Clearly thinking his order keeping him by his side sufficient.

And floating between Nathalie, and the bottle of wine and the plate of cheese on the trolley in front of her is, “*Plagg?*”

“Hey Nooroo,” the cat Kwami looks just as chagrined as he should do, right here in the house Nooroo’s been living with and looking far too *unshocked* at his own appearance, “long time no see.”

“You! Here, *how?*”

Nathalie fumbles for something in the draw at her side and then pulls out a thimble. “Would you like some wine?”

Nooroo glares at little at her, for knowing *this,* knowing Plagg, *his* friend, was here and not telling him, but still, “yes please.”

She pours a little wine out for him and hands it over, even as Plagg comes over and looks a little serious in that way in does once in a hundred years, “I’m working to get you out of this. I promise.”

“But,” then Nooroo looks at Nathalie again, her hair half fallen out of her bun and her glasses up on top of her head. That familiar pointed chin, and slope of her nose, the curve up of her cheekbone.

Features he’s seen across the atelier day after day.

Features he’s been seeing on Gabriel’s screen as the man attempts to make sense of the woman of so intrigues him.

“You’re Panthera,” he almost drops his wine.

It does suddenly explain an awful lot about heroine. *Why* she doesn’t hate Shadow Moth the way she should. How she indulges him. The way his master is drawn to him. The comfort the man feels in her presence.

It makes sense, and yet she’s also the last person he’d ever expected for the same reason she’d be the last person Gabriel would ever expect. He’d thought her loyalty was forged in iron and now it suddenly seems flexible. Not *nothing* or she’d have turned Shadow Moth in, or taken his Miraculous, but certainly not what he’d thought it was.

“You can’t tell Gabriel.” She says.

“You know I can’t,” he points out, “Kwamis can’t reveal holders.”

“I thought that was only your own.”

“Trust me,” Plagg laughs but there’s anger underneath, Plagg has always pushed at the boundaries holding them back despite his lackadaisical front, “I’d have told the boy who Ladybug was ages ago if I could, but Tikki would never let me.”

“I thought that was Chat Noir and Ladybug’s choice? In case we,” she went pale.

“Kwamis’ can’t be forced to tell,” Nooroo offers before Plagg can upset her more, because that won’t help at all with the current waves of repulsion he’s feeling from her. “But, it sounds like Plagg and Tikki chose not to too.”

“Superplum’s more worried about it than me but,” Plagg shrugs.

Nathalie takes a large swallow of wine. “Of course she is. A-“

It should have been obvious the moment he worked out Panthera was Nathalie.

“Adrien’s Chat Noir.” Nooroo finishes for her.

Nathalie shuts her eyes. “I’d deny it if I thought that would work right now.”

“It wouldn’t.” Nooroo agress, “he’s the only one you’d want to protect like that. And not knowing who Ladybug is protects him as well as her.”

Plagg mutters something inaudible.

His new (temporary? Nooroo isn't sure) holder shakes her head, "Adrien is Gabriel's son. He wouldn't-, he'd think he'd know how to demand answers from Adrien. Ladybug wouldn't have that protection."

Plagg's teeth are bared, "And if he didn't have any success in getting them?"

"He'd ground him forever. Take him out of school. Cut him off from contact with his friends. Not let him out of his room but he wouldn't, he wouldn't do more than that." Her voice is firm, broking no arguments.

Only Nooroo has them and he thinks they might need airing, so he takes a swallow of *his* wine and says, "he might akumatise him. He wants to sometimes."

"But he *doesn't.* He deliberately doesn't listen to Adrien's emotions. And I mean, he asked me."

"You haven't betrayed him,"

Nathalie shrugs, lifting a hand with a silver ring with three green gems on her finger.

"You hadn't then." He amends.

"No." Her eyebrows arc down, "I hadn't then."

The resignation and guilt in her voice are oddly familiar. Which makes him second-guess why she'd felt them *before* choosing to aid Plagg and Adrien against the man she loves and he'd thought, would follow down through every mistake he made.

Nooroo floats closer to her face, "you see him more clearly than I thought. Why do you love him then?"

"You know," she huffs, "of course you know, you're too close to me not to. Everyone seems to know my feelings that these days. Except for Gabriel, and even *he* does when he doesn't know it's me. But you know I'm not a good person either. And I saw the man he used to be, and the man he could be too."

Nooroo takes his time to turn those words over in his mind, then considers what he knows of the man forcing him to do the wrong thing over and over again and, "you're right. He's capable of being better. And It would be better for everyone if he did."

Plagg humphs, "well I hope so seeing as I'm staking my kid's future on that."

"Thanks." Nathalie says, but she doesn't seem bitter.

"Hey, you know I'm not in this for you lady even if it would be better for you too, which you *know* by the way."

That gets a snort, "Nooroo can tell you that it wouldn't."

"I don't understand."

“Plagg thinks that I can get Gabriel to fall in love enough with Panthera that he’ll give up, and then me, him and Adrien can just live as one happy family. Obviously that’s not going to work but,” she grabs a piece of the cheese from the plate before Plagg can object, “I’ve been speaking to Plagg and to Ladybug and well…you saw *my* attempt at getting him to stop.”

She then popped the cheese in her mouth as if by eating it violently enough she could cow Plagg or at least distract herself from the world.

“You’ve unsettled him,” Nooroo says. “But he is *thinking* about it. That’s a good thing I think.”

Her face softened a little, “how is he?”

“Not good.”

She frowned, “I’d go to him but…”

Nooroo wishes he could take that weight of her but he has to agree. “Usually that would help but now….”

“I don’t get it,” Plagg says, “isn’t this the perfect time to go to him? She goes and makes him feel better, and he realises that maybe he’s got an option more available to Panthera, and boom! Maybe he starts to have some realisations.”

Nooroo comes to sit above her prostheses, “he needs her, but seeing her will only make him feel guiltier and more determined to succeed. Nathalie’s appearance could very well make him chose *not* to give up.”

“Gabriel doesn’t see boundaries,” Nathalie mumbles, “if he thinks it’s necessary he’ll tell himself there’s a way around the cost of the Wish.”

“And you tell me he doesn’t care about you.” Plagg rolls his eyes.

Nooroo blinks at that. “Why would say that? He worries about you all the time.”

“When he remembers,” Nathalie corrects, and she’s not wrong but then she’s hardly the *only* important thing Gabriel can get too drawn into his ideas to remember. Adrien of course too, but his actual work for another, and even on some occasions *Emilie.* When he gets into *being* a villain rather than remembering *why* he’s being one. Never mind how Nooroo despairs of how his captor seems to not notice when he’s hungry or sleep deprived.

He’s not supposed to have to worry about someone who’s currently misusing his Miraculous.

“And I never said he doesn’t care about me,” Nathalie said, “just that he doesn’t love me, he won’t love Panthera when he works out she’s me, and he’ll never get over the betrayal. Let me work out how to convince Gabriel otherwise. Nooroo’s just told us my methods are working.”

Nooroo reached out to where his master lies in a turbulent agony, and that yearning for someone by his side. “I’d better go back before he comes looking for me. But it’s not as dark

a future for you as you think."

The flash of hope in her is small. Barely an ember under all her attempts to smother it down. But it's there. Ready to be coaxed to a flame.

"Don't you start."

"He'll be furious. But he wouldn't want to live without you either. And I wouldn't hold his attraction to Panthera against him either. How he acted with her made no sense to me until I realised she was you."

"What?" Nathalie tries to push herself out of bed to follow him, "Nooroo you get right back here now, *NOOROO,"*

Nooroo doesn't wait. His master is getting more and more angry and he really doesn't feel like him and Nathalie meeting in their current states of minds would go well. Not for them long term plans.

Behind him Plagg laughs, and then she screeches, "Plagg, *claws out,*" loudly enough he can only hope his master didn't hear it.

But reckless as she can be he doubts she'd come after him now. Not when she must know that would make it too easy for his master to take her Miraculous.

And there's her emotions seem stationary behind him, not strengthening in the way that heralds their owner coming closer, as he enters the master bedroom.

"She's well sir," he reports.

"Why did that take so long?"

"She was asking after you. And she fed me."

Gabriel presses at his temples, "she's not asleep then."

"No," Nooroo admits, "but she seems relaxed and surprisingly well," which he should have asked Plagg about it occurs to him know, "she doesn't seem in any danger tonight."

"She's not coughing?"

"She's," he yelps and forgets his words, as an energy not familiar for a long time runs through him.

His master looks down at his chest at the recurrent glow ebbing and rising there.

He puts a hand to his Miraculous as if to take it off, "what's happening?"

"Someone's trying to contact you through your Miraculous," and of course, as Mayura Nathalie would have known the feel of it to grab onto, but he doesn't know why she'd do this now.

Except that they're agreed that Gabriel needed someone with him. And Nathalie couldn't do it.

But they'd not said anything of the like about Panthera.

Clever.

"Can they find me through it?" His master asked.

"They can't." Nooroo reassures then.

The man shrugs with a smirk, "then, Nooroo, Dusuu, *double transformation.*"

Chapter 13: Gabriel V

Gabriel shuts the door behind him, and very carefully doesn't think about the concerned look in Nathalie's eyes as he'd announced he was having an early night.

It's becoming a habit.

Carefully not thinking about Nathalie.

Paris is repaired by that bug every time she manages to foil one of his plans. If Gabriel just… decided to stop then the city would continue on with its life perfectly unchanged.

Nathalie would not.

What he's allowed to happen to Nathalie is permanent. He doesn't even know if she'll have a *life* ruined by the Miraculous to live afterwards.

After all he has Emilie's situation to make it *quite* clear just how badly using a broken Miraculous can go and now it seems like maybe he *can't* fix the world anyway he can't understand how he could ever have thought it was OK to let Nathalie use that Miraculous too, even if she'd forced his hand on certain occasions.

He doesn't know how Nathalie can *not* blame him.

Besides his bed a photo of himself, Emilie and Adrien glints in the warm golden evening light. It seems to give life to his wife's eyes. Making them flash in anger the way they had when she'd argued with him.

"I'm sorry Emilie," he mumbles to the portrait in a way that he's not managed to do to the real woman in her casket.

He's been doing a lot of careful not thinking about his wife too.

It's been easier than not thinking about Nathalie.

Another thing he's been trying not to dwell on.

It's natural after all. Emilie's been gone for what feels like so long now while Nathalie is still here slipping away under his eyes. She'll have periods where she seems to be doing better, and he'll let himself hope. Let himself think that maybe it would be alright just to let himself stop. And then he'll find her on the floor again, or with blood streaming from her nose.

Lying down on the bed he takes the photo of his family in his hands.

"You'd blame me for stopping wouldn't you?" he asks the silent image of the woman who was supposed to be the love of his life for all of both their lives but now lies emotionless and cold deep below the ground, "but you'd blame me more if I killed our son to bring you back wouldn't you?"

He gasps a little as he says it. Such a clear statement of what he'd be doing. His hands might never *physically* touch his son. His eyes might never see the light disappear from those ones so like his mother's. His ears might never hear his child's final breath.

Gabriel would still have been the one to kill Adrien anyway.

Even if he didn't remember.

And even if he knew he wouldn't remember, knew he wouldn't carry that guilt, knew that Emilie would smile at him without any censure, knew that in truth he wouldn't be *murdering* his son as much as stopping him coming into existence in the first place he still couldn't do it.

Fatherhood has never come naturally to him. He's never had that instinctual connection to his son that Emilie had had. He's not *able* to be parent his wife was. There's nothing growing to fill the gap left by Emilie between him and his own flesh and blood the way a bond he's trying to ignore the development of *is* growing between Adrien and Nathalie.

When Emilie had looked so excited about the idea, luminous in a way there was nothing he could do but be sucked in like any moth to her flame, she'd convinced him it would be easy to be a father. That it would all fall into place once he had his son in his arms.

It wasn't. It didn't.

Gabriel has tried, even before Emilie left, to make up for the fact he doesn't understand the boy in the slightest. That he looks at this child so like Emilie but instead sees a stranger. That the impulse to hug him, or ruffle his hair like she used to never comes until Adrien is out of the room and he's suddenly aware that he's missed the moment.

Instead he's done everything he can to fulfil the *other* parts of fatherhood. The less touchy-feely bits.

Adrien is provided with anything he could need, and without him needing to ask and whine about it like a brat the way Audrey and André's daughter does. His room might seem excessive to others but not only did Gabriel not work himself to the bone to *not* give his family a better life than his parents had given him, but in truth it's a necessary provision for a child when it was so unsafe to let him outside when he was younger.

The boy has food prepared for him by a gourmet chef who ensures he gets all the nutrients he needs. Sometimes Gabriel hopes for Adrien's sake that this doesn't cause his son to end up taller than him. He doesn't wish the nightmare that is ov"er-short doorframes on anyone.

Adrien is getting every education, every bit of training to prepare him for adulthood. The money from his modelling is set aside as his. His grades are ensured to be top-notch. He'll go into the world with his fame already assured, and hobbies that will let him flow around the elites of the world naturally without it fitting like an awkwardly fitting way of clothes like it always did for Gabriel until he became rich enough to avoid all of that. No one will tell Adrien his future is nothing more than physical drudgery and anything more is girlish fantasies.

And Adrien will grow up with an understanding of rules. Of the necessity of not embarrassing himself, of obliging others even if he goes behind their back later. And most importantly he'll never have broken that weak *weak* rope behind which Gabriel can feel his *own* father's anger in himself, can feel the urge to punish his son properly the way *he* had once been. To treat Adrien the way he does Ladybug and Chat Noir.

That rope frays sometimes but strangely enough these days there's an emptiness behind it as he realises that *no* he's not his father, and *no* he has no desire at all to go further, never wants to cause Adrien's death.

He wants his son to live.

And he wants him to live in a way that's *happier,* yearns for it in an echo of how he hears the same from Panthera when she talks about how things could be for Chat Noir in a world without Hawk Moth.

He just has no idea how to achieve that.

No idea if he wants to give up on Emilie if he gives up on the Wish or to chase after other dreams of saving her.

No idea how to save Nathalie.

So he puts the photograph down on it's face, transforms, and calls the woman he does in fact know *exactly* what he'd have to do to please the way he's got used to doing these days.

Panthera sounds a little out of breath as she answers, "Shadow Moth?"

"Is this a bad time?"

"No," she breathing steadies out a bit, "sorry- Chat Noir just wanted to talk to me. I had to run to answer."

He chuckles at the image even as the something in his guts is unsettled. "It might be a little awkward if he caught you talking to me."

"*That's* an understatement." He wishes he could see the chagrined look on Panthera's face, "he'd probably do something stupid like try and steal the ring from me and go fight you."

"That's sort of admirable," he admits despite himself. He'd feel different in her shoes. Adrien would be grounded for life for a stunt like that, but he can't blame a child for wanting to defend his maybe-mother.

"It's stupid." Panthera retorts. "It's not like us talking is a danger to anything and anyway. Well. It doesn't matter."

"It's sweet that he cares that much about you." He concedes. He can give his enemy that much.

"Yeah," she sighs, "I guess it is."

“What was your anyway?”

He can imagine that little furrow between her eyes visible even under her mask, “What?”

“You said us talking like this isn’t a danger and anyway, but then you didn’t finish.”

“Oh.”

“You don’t have to say. I just thought. Well you’re always listening to my woes,” Gabriel thanks his lucky stars that Panthera had rang him that first night and reached out a metaphorical hand to pull him out of his despair. “It only seems fair that I should listen to yours.”

“I wish other people could see the version of you I do,” she says tiredly.

“Oh I’d hate to ruin my reputation besides….”

“I know. And I also know you haven’t sent out any akumas recently.”

“Sometimes I wish that you’d never confirmed what the kwamis had told me,” if she thinks it odd that he’d listen to *her* and the kwamis he’s spared no care for so far she hasn’t said, and he’s kept Nathalie, the fact that this idea has come from someone he trusts implicitly his own little secret.

“No you don’t.” There’s no hesitation in her response, and no uncertainty in it either. She could almost be Nathalie with her trust in him.

“No I don’t,” he agrees tiredly, the image of Adrien lying in Emilie’s casket haunting him again, “even if it would be easier.”

“A lot of things would be easier if everything wasn’t like this.”

“You’re right there.”

“So what did you call me about? I feel like we’ve got off topic.”

“Not at all. I just wanted to hear your voice my darling cat.” He’s got dangerously reliant on their little chats as a way to keep himself grounded.

There’s silence down the line, only the sound of her breathing in his ears almost as if she’s next to him in his bed telling him that Panthera is still there.

“Panthera?” He queries, “*is* there a problem with me calling now? If you dropped everything because you thought it was something more important than that you don’t have to stay. Goodness knows I know about having a busy schedule. I could message you you know,”

“No no,” she says in a hurry, “I’ve told you you can’t message. I let Chat Noir borrow the ring to contact Ladybug that way, and,”

“He can’t see messages from me yes,” his body feels restless on the bed. He’s used to *having* secrets. Not *being* one. And part of his pride is offended at the idea that a woman *wouldn’t* want it be known she’s dating him. He’s *the* Gabriel Agreste for god’s sake. It’s not like he’s been reminded by multiple women that he’s a catch whom they wouldn’t mind comforting on the few instances he’s left the house.

Not that he’s dating Panthera.

And to her he’s only Shadow Moth before and he’d assume there’s far less people out there lining up to date him.

“It’s not.” There’s an exhale of air, “I’m happy to be your conduit to Ladybug but…maybe this is dangerous. The rest of the talking. Us.”

“I don’t understand.”

“Maybe. On our first encounters, you enjoyed flirting with me. It amused you.”

He can’t follow her train of thought at all. “Yes?”

“But I’m not an option for you. Not really. Maybe this, this joking with me and confiding in me, is stopping you from finding something real with someone you actually know in your real life.”

“Why aren’t you an option?”

The temptation there has only got stronger since it had started to look like the Wish isn’t an option. Because if the Wish can’t be done then Emilie *is* dead, and there’s nothing wrong with him starting something with a pretty woman he respects and doesn’t really want to hurt at all who clearly feels something to him both physically and emotionally.

“I’m not Panthera. And I’m,”

“In love with Chat Noir’s father.” He finishes for her before he has to hear those words from her mouth again.

“Yes.”

“Was that your anyway?” He asks, “Don’t think I didn’t see you trying to weasel out of answering that question.”

“My anyway? I suppose in a way.” There’s a rustle and it strikes him suddenly that maybe Panthera is *also* in bed, and his checks heat up, “you see part of the reason Chat Noir objects to me and you as an idea,”

“Apart from the whole being a supervillain thing.”

“Oh hush. We both know you’re not the villain you pretend to be.”

“It can be fun though,”

“I know. And *that* would not help your case with Chat Noir. But you see he wants me to get together with his father.”

He feels like he’s bit into a lemon. “And you’re sure that won’t happen?”

“Certain. He’s in love with someone else. Or I thought he was. Now he seems to be falling for someone new, which I guess proves I never really had a chance.”

“He’s an idiot then but…” Gabriel hesitates, “if he’s noticing someone new that doesn’t mean he didn’t love whoever it was before. When you lose someone it feels like you’ll never feel anything positive again but then one day it starts to creep in.”

He feels a little lighter for having put his feelings into words. It’s not something he can admit to his *other* confidante. Nathalie disapproves of his actions with Panthera and he can’t blame her after everything he’d done to get Emilie back with her.

Her voice is almost painfully tender, “you’re sure there’s no one in your life?”

He shuts his eyes, “do you really think Ladybug would let me go free?”

Panthera humours his change in topic. “I don’t see how she could stop you if you just… stopped. It’s not like she knows who you are but if you wanted me to be a courier of those Miraculous then yes, I believe she would. I’d make her if I had to.”

“How on earth would you make her?”

Her warm laughter is a sound he’d like to hear for the rest of his life. Like maybe she could provide the warmth this house has been lacking for so long. That maybe he could hear Adrien’s too.

“That’s a secret.”

“What if I offered you a secret in return?”

“That’s a deal I might take.”

“Mayura.”

There’s a pause. “What about Mayura?”

“She’s dying and it’s my fault.”

She gasps. “My butterfly,”

“Don’t. It is. Her Miraculous was broken. And I think I’ve almost decided to not make the Wish. You know that. And she *wants* me to. But now every time I see her I think I’ve killed her. I, I struggle to look at her and I *know* that hurts her.”

He needs no Miraculous to tell him that. Nathalie, in her own way, has always valued being able to be there for him, to anticipate his needs before he knows she has them, and now he’s

taking that from her too the way he's taken everything else.

"You don't know she's dying."

"I do. I've seen it before."

"No I mean. I've, um," he wishes he could see her face, see the truth of her feelings in from of him, see her white teeth dig into her dark lips like Nathalie does when she's nervous. "spoken to Ladybug. I thought that might be it from what you've said before. What you wanted the Wish for."

Ridiculously he sits up as if he's going to go running to the two of them and sort this all out right now, "You can do *something?*"

"Not for. She can't just back from the dead. But for Mayura, she's not the first person in history to use a broken Miraculous."

Yes, Gabriel knows *that* all too well.

Panthera continues, "and I don't know about a cure but even Plagg's quite capable of stopping the damage. She doesn't have to die."

"She doesn't," he marvels even as he can't understand why he doesn't feel the triumph of he should at this.

"Shadow Moth?" Panthera must have got worried at his silence.

Everything in this world has a price. "And what would you ask for for this boon?"

"For this? Nothing."

"*Nothing?*" That can't be real. Panthera is enormously giving, is too kind, in exactly the same way Nathalie is without it making either of them soft or without an acerbic wit.

"It's more of a gift to *her* than to you really. I wouldn't want to be as heartless as to let the friend of someone I care for die if I can help it."

That brings a smirk back to his face. "You care for me?"

Not that he'd been totally unware of that but he doesn't feel her emotions with the same intensity when they're talking through their Miraculous as he does when she's right there, and besides with a woman like her he knows he's an achievement to get her to say it out loud.

"Ladybug's got a crush on Chat Noir." She says in a total non-sequitur.

"That was a very strange answer darling."

"A secret for a secret. You offered yours. Here's mine."

“She’s not though. Not that I haven’t considered driving a wedge between them as a way to divide them, and frankly she’s not as good with you as she is with him. No offense.”

“None taken.” She sounds amused.

“But she’s also made it pretty damn clear she’s not interested in a relationship with the boy despite his overtures.”

“Urgh, don’t remind me. I’m been cringing about his approach ever since I discovered who Chat Noir is.”

He tilts his head as if she could see him. “But you like it when *I* act like that.”

“I would not say that.”

“Come on, where does Chat Noir get his love of puns from if not you?”

“His father,” she says tightly.

“Oh.” Once again he feels awkward, like he’s overstepped.

“Quite.”

“But you do like your bait and switch. I’m feeling a little robbed. Ladybug isn’t interested in Chat Noir that way, even if I doubt she’d take it well where he to show interest in someone else.”

“Hmm, Ladybug isn’t interested in *Chat Noir,* but she does have a crush on him. It’d be kind of funny if I didn’t feel sorry for them both.”

Gabriel laughs as it hits him, “*I’m* not. That’s hilarious. You mean she’s admitted to you she likes whoever he is behind the mask? That does make explain how you were going to get her to go along with you. Clever.”

“I don’t feel good about it.”

“But he idolises her. It’s hardly as if you’d be forcing him to date someone against his will. I’d jump at the option in his situation. Hell, so would my son. He could certainly do worse.”

That DJ boy comes to mind. Any teenager ready to throw secret parties that endangers the house’s power supply and that keeping Emilie in stasis has an automatic black mark against them.

“Umph,” she makes the strangest noise, “but wouldn’t you feel bad? For using him?”

“In the circumstances I think he’d volunteer.” Adrien’s even been worried enough about Nathalie to *ask* him about it. And unfortunately his son is *also* a fan of Ladybug.

“Well that does make me feel a little better.” Her voice sounds odd though.

“About my a-, Mayura though,” he decides to put the question of Adrien dating well aside, “if I wanted you to help her how would I do that? How would she contact you?”

“Um.” He can feel her thinking, “I suppose you could give her the Peacock Miraculous.”

“I’m sorry?”

“I mean. It’s fixed isn’t it? So she and I could sort something out? I’m sorry but much as I *will* help you I don’t think Ladybug would be happy if I gave you my Miraculous.”

“Probably not.” He agrees but that old fear at the idea of letting Nathalie near his Miraculous raises it’s head, “But you’re sure this won’t hurt her more?”

“I’m sure.” He doesn’t *think* she’s lying. “Will you do it?”

“You’ll hear from her if I do.” He doesn’t quite commit. It feels like an easy answer. Too easy. If he’s given up then it doesn’t matter if he has both Miraculous or neither. It feels like a trick but he doesn’t think Panthera is tricking him.

And he doesn’t think he can do Nathalie out of any chance of a cure.

Panthera is either oblivious to or ignoring his doubts. “Hmm, Shadow Moth?”

“Yes?”

“Look at her.”

He tries to make sense of that and gives out. “What?”

“Mayura,” she clarifies, “I know you’ll think I have no reason to say but but…as a woman, you’re hurting her treating her like you’re preparing for her being gone. Now you know she’s not just. Show that?”

“You’re right. I should.”

The slightest hint of swallow can be hear. “And I know this is overstepping. And you don’t have to answer but, what is she to you? Mayura? You said it wasn’t romantic but the way you’re bringing her up now…”

“Are you saying I can’t not want my best friend not to die?”

“No. No I didn’t mean. I’m sorry.” She blurts back.

“She is my best friend you know.” He stops her.

“I see.”

“Anything more is your fault you know?”

He can’t fault Panthera for her incredulous. “*My* fault?”

“You remind me of her sometimes. The two of you are oddly similar. It gets confusing. So yes. Your fault.”

Partially Adrien’s fault too to give credit where it’s due but sometimes he can’t help but look at Panthera but see Nathalie and vice versa.

“You make things confusing for me too you know.” She tells me, “so I think we’re even there.”

“I shouldn’t say this but I think that in another world out there without any Miraculous then maybe we could have been happy together you know.” He admits to her the secrets he’s not yet admitted to himself.

“I shouldn’t say this either but I agree.” Her answer is tired. Wistful with might-have-beens.

Gabriel shakes his head as if that will clear it of never-will-be fantasies. “I will go to Mayura now. You’re right. I’ve been cruel to her. “

“She’ll appreciate it I know.”

“Any suggestions? You know.” He can’t help the slight dig, “As a woman.”

“I don’t think you need any help from me there.” He imagines her saying it with a smile on her face, “Goodnight my not-so-little butterfly.”

“Goodnight my darling cat.”

Chapter 14: Nathalie V

Everyone tells her she's doing the right thing. Plagg. Nooroo. Even Adrien and Ladybug would be delighted if Shadow Moth just disappeared. So why does she feel so selfish?

It shouldn't. She knows that. Even if she somehow pulls off convincing him to give up without letting the truth of everything slip that hardly means Gabriel is going to be ready to move on with anybody anytime soon whatever he might say to Panthera. Because she's not stupid, she knows the very impossibility of a relationship with Panthera is *why* he says that to the heroine.

And though that's no option, because despite the trust that's grown between their other identities even as the understanding they'd shared as Gabriel and Nathalie has diminished he's hardly as misled by lust as to consider sharing who's behind his mask with her, there's still no reason he'd pick Nathalie to move on with instead.

Unless that line about her and Panthera confusing him had meant something.

She fiddles with the Miraculous on her finger.

Perhaps Gabriel could plausibly chose her afterwards, because he'd think that *she* unlike the heroine *is* someone he could be honest with. Ironically enough. But it's one thing to play second fiddle to Emilie when if she's more than an assistant she's still only a friend.

It would be quite another to be with him knowing that he really wants the more interesting version of her, but if he was to discover that *was* her he'd never want to be with either of them.

Because that's the thing. Even if all the rest of it happened the way it does in the dreams she doesn't acknowledge when she's awake this will always be there between them. His secrets bound them. *Her* secrets will forever keep them apart.

What she has with him as Panthera is all she's ever going to have with him, and acknowledging that makes her hate that they only call each other these days; that she's too scared to throw caution to the wind and greedily take whatever he so freely offers her.

She swallows the lump in her throat and tries to tell herself this is a good thing, that this proves that however it might feel she's not in fact being selfish. That's she's doing this because it's the right thing to do, that it's *for* Adrien, and not because it has any benefit to her.

But as she gives up trying to work on her own laptop and watches the boy doing homework further down the table as Plagg curls over his shoulder she can't quite manage to smother her guilt.

"Adrien," she calls.

His head jerks up. Eager, but shy about it. "Yes?"

But now he's looking at her she feels stupid. What is she supposed to ask him? Is he ok with her taking away his only chance to see his mother again? Even though *he* is the very reason she can't trust herself or Gabriel to make the Wish?

"Did you need any help with your homework?" she tries to ask as if that was all she'd ever meant to say.

From how his eyes narrow she's clearly not carried it off.

"No. But. Do *you* need help with anything?"

Nathalie can feel her expression tightening. She hadn't realised her dilemma was so visible to Adrien and she can't see how he thinks he can help with it. "Like what?"

He looks up and her, and *god* she has to save this boy. "I know it's not easy being the Black Cat..."

She shrugs, she doubts the difficult parts of it for her have anything in common with the difficult parts for Adrien. After all, "there haven't been many Akuma attacks."

Gabriel spends most of his time transformed speaking to *her* these days. She guesses that could be seen as making her some sort of hero even if thinking of it in those terms does nothing but make her feel vaguely unclean.

"No," Adrien's face looks sour, "but you're sure you don't need help with Shadow Moth?"

She does her very best to mute her reaction to that. "I'm not sure that's something you can exactly help with."

From Adrien's scowl she's clearly not quite succeeded but then *his* expression is hardly giving unpolitical brand ambassador either. So there's that.

"That's what I'm worried about," he mutters but audibly enough that she can hear him so easily she wonders if she was meant to.

If she was. Meant to. That is. It would be quite an Emilie little flourish. Nathalie hadn't known her well, but she'd known her well enough to know she'd liked to do that sort of thing. Gabriel had used to hate it. He's more of a blunt communicator.

"Would it be so bad?" She asks, "if he listens to me? He's not a bad man Adrien."

"Not a bad man?! *Nathalie!* Have you seen what he's done? How he's hurt my friends?"

She stiffens, "I've fought him too. And Ladybug's power fixes everything."

"The physical stuff *yeah,* but it doesn't fix the rest of it."

"The rest of it?"

Adrien looks every image the orator Gabriel wants him to be, “can you imagine what it’s like being akumatised?”

She doesn’t have to. She knows what that’s like actually.

Shivers go down her spine at the memory of the sensation of Hawk Moth’s voice inside her mind, and his fingers against hers and how he’d *asked* for and she’d *given* the loyalty that thrums through her veins and in return he’d *reciprocated* with trust, esteem, and *power.*

How as he’d empowered her it had felt like the boundaries between Gabriel and Nathalie were *gone,* that they were one, tied together by a purity of purpose because they weren’t Gabriel and Nathalie, they were HawkMothandCatalyst and they had one goal. She existed to fulfil him, and he couldn’t do it without her.

How for once she’d not felt insufficient in the slightest, that she was able to be exactly what she was needed to be, that she was *wanted,* that she was *essential.*

Akumatisation had been an expression of love for Nathalie, because what is loyalty if not a type of love?

And when the man she was loyal to, the man she loved, had needed a different solution to Catalyst then she’d broken her own akuma, broken the bond between them, as easily as a change of hair colour.

She’s aware her experience is likely pretty unrepresentative.

Not that no one else has ever said *yes, give me the power I need to strike back,* or even that no one else has volunteered, has called out to Hawk Moth asking to make their pain someone else’s problem.

But Nathalie is the only one who was asked by Gabriel, not Hawk Moth, who know exactly what she was getting into, who suggested the entire idea of akumatising an ally in the first place.

So she knows what it’s like be akumatised.

But she doesn’t know how most people feel about being akumatised, and Adrien’s fierce scowl only supports that.

“He comes to people in their weakest moment and drags out their innermost emotions and makes them public, he takes away their chance to sort out things themselves and forces them to hurt their friends and people they love and do things they’d never do themselves.”

The room suddenly feels over-warm and if the brace she’s wearing, more to appease Gabriel these days than because she really needs it, didn’t hold her jacket in place she’d shrug it off.

Because she’s not Shadow Moth, but she was his partner, and while as Mayura she’d used her own emotions or Gabriel’s more than she’d reached out to anyone else’s heart and pulled out their hopes and fears to be the clay for her creations it’s not that she never has, even if she’d generally piggybacked on Gabriel’s akumatisations then.

“I thought the general opinion was that people weren’t to blame for akumatisations?” She suggests gently.

It’s easy to get to caught out in her betrayal of Gabriel, even if it’s for his own good, that she’s forgotten her betrayal of *Adrien* and the secrets she’s keeping from him even if it’s for his own good.

She doesn’t want to be Adrien’s enemy, has always disliked her role as a force keeping him from having a more normal life despite seeing the necessity of it. She doesn’t want him to hate her.

“They’re not,” he almost snaps, “*Shadow Moth* is. He’s a terrible person Nathalie, how can you look past that?”

“I’m an adult.”

“What does that mean?”

“It means maybe I’ve done things I’m not proud of too Adrien. I know people make mistakes, and…the world is a lot more complicated than it seems to someone your age.”

His face droops, is the only description she can give of it, “I’d say my life is pretty complicated.”

She sighs. “I didn’t mean to say it wasn’t.” Because even without him being Chat Noir she can’t pretend anything in his house is simple, “just that, maybe I’ve less room be judgemental.”

“What do you mean? You’re nothing like him.” Self-righteousness animates every line of his body and she would almost falter back in the face of it but the exoskeleton holds her in place.

“But I am,” *come on Nathalie,* she pushes herself, *take the jump.* “Shadow Moth isn’t just doing this for power’s sake you know?”

“You’re *that* close to him that he told you that?!”

“More or less.” She shrugs, that it was Gabriel and not Shadow Moth who told her isn’t the point. The point is, “yes, he’s doing the wrong thing. From what Ladybug and Plagg have told me about how these powers work I know *that* but…”

“You’ve talked to Ladybug about this? *She’s* ok with this?”

“Ladybug just wants all of this to be over as far as I can tell,” she forces herself to move closer to Adrien and puts a hand on his shoulder, “it’s a tough life for the both of you. You’re both too young for this.”

To her surprise Adrien looks away, “but the people Shadow Moth akumatises aren’t? Do you know how many Akuma victims I know? How many of my classmate he’s targeted? If you think it’s unfair Master Fu asked us to be heroes, isn’t it more unfair that Hawk Moth made my friend’s villains?”

She lets go of him on instinct but because it does hurt like a stab between her ribs not because Adrien is wrong but because this is *Adrien* talking to *her,* and it had all been fine when they were going to remake the whole world but now they're *not*.

Everything Hawk Moth and Mayura did will last. And she's not sure Adrien will forgive either of them.

But despite the salt burning at corners of her eyes Nathalie's dealt with other's hatred before; in her youth from strangers and then from her family, when Gabriel had snapped and blamed her for finding the Miraculous for them before his contrite apology, when people whisper loud enough to be heard about whether Emilie's disappearance was a promotion for her, and if maybe *maybe* Gabriel's jealous little mistress had had something to do with said disappearance.

Which she had, if not in the way they'd meant.

It feels worse now, looking Adrien in the eye as he expounds his hatred of his own father, of *her,* but it's not unprecedented and so she's able to stuff all those feelings down and gentle her voice like she does with his father when he's down but rarely does with Adrien from a fear of overstepping. Perhaps everyone thinking her Chat Noir's mother is having an impact.

"Teenagers are…volatile. It makes them easy targets. And." She has to concentrate a little not to heave, and forces her thoughts down a different route, "it think it's location based,"

"*Wait.* Shadow Moth lives around here?"

Damn. She really isn't in good control of herself. If only she hadn't let herself get so attached to both Adrien and Gabriel. "You know that," she stonewalls, "the same way you know that Ladybug is too. I mean what's the chances he attacks somewhere you're both able to get to fairly quickly?"

"Oh my god." Adrien's eyes are wide and he's staring somewhere into the middle distance, "*Ladybug* lives near me?! Do you think I know her? That I've met her as not-Ladybug? I mean, she's around my age right?"

Bingo. Mentioning his Lady was a stroke of brilliance to distract his attention.

"I mean I did threaten to tell you she was in lyceé but given her response to that I'm pretty sure she's in collége, so yeah she's around your age I'm pretty sure."

His whole mouth contorts, "she's not younger than me right? That's just, urgh, no she can't be right? She's so responsible and actually I can kind of see her being in lyceé and that would be alright right? Because everyone at the parties my parents took me to said I'm so good with adults and-"

"You're around the same age kid," Plagg drawls.

"Wha-?"

"Oh hey! I can say that." Their kwami sounds delighted.

“Probably because I was going to,” Nathalie decides to stop him because she’d forgotten once again that Plagg was here and he could have made this *so* uncomfortable had he wanted to.

Adrien looks between her and Plagg and then seems to settle back on his inquisition of her. “So she’s my age?”

“I’d guess,” it’s an honest enough answer. Nathalie doesn’t actually *know* but she’s pretty sure that superheroine is in that ballpark and much as she has very much hoped she could maybe push Adrien in a different direction with someone who *isn’t* Ladybug she can’t deny that getting Adrien together with Ladybug might be useful if Ladybug goes along with Shadow Moth now giving up.

“Then,” she winces as she sees Adrien’s fingernails grasp along his jeans the same way Emilie used to grip at the handles of her handbags, “I guess it would be. Good for her. If Hawkmoth gave up. Before we get to more important years at school”

Despite his words nothing from his countenance to his posture to how he won’t met her eyes is in the slightest bit positive.

And maybe Adrien, not her son by blood or by any legal tie, is a little bit hers after all because there’s an answering ache in her heart as it thuds.

Cautiously, ready at any moment for him to jump out like she’s a hunter laying a trap, she clasp his upper arm like she might, in of course a purely friendly way, for his father.

“It would be,” she imparts firmly, “should you struggle at school then we’d ensure you had the tutors to make that up but we don’t know that she has that freedom, and it’s quite likely she doesn’t.”

“Yeah, I know,“ He jerks up, “and what if the freedom she wanted was to date someone, do you think she has that?”

Nathalie steadfastly shoves all her own issues to the side, “no, I’d suppose that so long as she’d Ladybug she doesn’t have that, even if,” she skates dangerously close to the truth but compared to all the other truths Adrien might learn this is a *good* thing and much as she hates it she might have to rely upon it, “she actually quite likes Adrien Agreste, and maybe,” and she’s not at all sure but some gut instinct is yelling at her, “she might have even meet him it’s not like she’d feel free to do anything until,”

“Shadow Moth was defeated,” Adrien interrupts.

“Shadow Moth is no longer an issue,” she corrects.

“But,” and her boy looks so weak and uncertain it pains her because he was never supposed to look like that. Gabriel’s rules were strict but they were certain, were supposed to be easy to obey, that Adrien never had to wonder what was the right way of living that wouldn’t earn his admonishment, “isn’t that kind of weak? Like choosing the easy route? Isn’t it our duty to put him in prison?”

“Your duty,” it’s easy to scoff a little, perhaps less to moderate it, “I think I missed when you signed up to be an officer of the Republic.”

“I’m supposed to be Chat Noir,” and suddenly he’s sniffling.

“Hey,” and it’s surprisingly easy to fold Adrien inside her arms, to hold him safely against her chest like he’s the precious thing he is, “this isn’t your responsibility anymore right? I’m dealing with it, and if I could convince Ladybug to let me meet her parents they’d be dealing with it too. And anyway which crime they’d convict Shadow Moth for is a total mess. It’s ok to just let him go and take his Miraculous. To let Paris forget all of this.”

“But,” Adrien sniffles against her arm, “I wouldn’t be Chat Noir then would I? There wouldn’t be a need for him, and Ladybug might take my Miraculous back and-”

She recognises the spiral from Gabriel and interrupts, “Hmm, I think Plagg would disagree there.”

And for once her prayers are answered, “Sorry.” The Kwami humphs, “But you’re stuck with me kid. No broken foot,”

“Ankle,” Adrien corrects.

“Whatever,” Plagg seems ridiculously unbothered when she knows just how much he values Adrien, “is going to take me away from a holder *I* chose. Not Master Fu. *Me.* Do you know how many boys there were with your boyband cutesy hairstyle in Paris?”

“Uh, much as multiple focus groups have decided this is the best option for me what does my *hairstyle* have to do with you choosing me?”

“Um,” Plagg suddenly looks uncertain in a way that doesn’t fit with her usually laconic Kwami, “I think that was important? Because he…I don’t know he could have known. Ask, actually don’t you’re *my* kitten I’m not sharing you with whoever comes around but look, I guess you’ve wielded Sass before. He knows enough to point you to Fluff if the timeline changed.”

In a nervous tic she uses the arm Adrien isn’t currently clinging to to run a hand over her hair, pushing any loss strands back into her bun, pushing herself back into Nathalie Sancoeur, executive assistant, “Couldn’t that be a good thing? If the timeline changed?”

“It could be,” Plagg nods, “or it could be a catastrophe.”

“And what do you, oh manifestation of destruction, think it is?”

Plagg hold out an arm.

“Are you *seriously* asking me for cheese?”

Stubbornly he remains with an arm out, and Nathalie has to abandon Adrien, though she leaves him with a kiss on the crown of his head, to go in search of something.

“Have some Fourme d’Ambert and shut up,” she slams the cheese down on the table.

Adrien’s eyes move between them as quickly as if he’s watching a tennis match, “can you just decide that’s an option? Surely if things have changed that’s not a good thing?”

“Eh,” Plagg takes the most nonchalant bite of cheese possible.

“Yes, I think we can. It’s our world, we’re the ones living in it.” Nathalie decides firmly, “and as to the rest of it, are you really that worried about me ending up with Shadow Moth? Or are you just worried about your father choosing someone else as a possible new stepmother for you?”

“Someone *else?!”* Adrien yelps but then he flushes and shame colours his voice when he says, “I just want Father to be happy. To be like we used to be. But. I thought maybe that was going to be with you? And that wouldn’t be forgetting my maman and It wouldn’t be re-drawing all my life. You’ve been here since I can remember and if you and father could reform around that gap in all our lives my mother has left and be happy then maybe I could be happy,”

“Adrien,” she can’t do more than hold her arms out, she’s not his mother and she’s not meant to be his mother, and she knows that but she also knows that his mother can’t come back so maybe a little bit of comfort is ok and, “I’ll stay with you,” *forever* but that’s not a promise she can make because she’s *not* his mother, “as long as I can. I promise you that. And I will always love you.”

“Even if father found someone else?”

“Even then.”

His eyes are so devastatingly large, she thinks he’s deliberately exaggerating but that doesn’t mean it doesn’t work on her. “Even if she was like some horrible fairy tale evil stepmother? Would you rescue me?”

Nathalie blinks away the utterly wrong impossible image of Gabriel with another woman and focuses on what she knows is true. “Your father loves you more than that Adrien.”

“I think those fathers loved their children once too,” his eyes when she looks into them are tired and full of wisdom and she hate hate *hates* that she’s been part of putting that there. “And I’m not sure he remembers how to love me anymore. And it’s hardly like I can go off an run away with you and Shadow Moth.”

“Even in the extraordinarily unlikely event Shadow Moth was any to offer me a real option, a real life with him, I wouldn’t say yes.” Not least because she *couldn’t* because the truth would mean the end of anything between her and Shadow Moth, but that’s not the point, the point is, “you’re more important to me than any romantic relationship.”

“So you’d never chose him?”

She’s regretting this whole conversation, “Like I said, he’s not a real choice.”

“But,” Adrien presses, “you would if he was? You meant it when you said you and father really aren’t…”

Ignoring the desire to massage at her temples she instead of answering that she replies, “Shadow Moth wants to save someone. And I’m not him because I know about the consequences about making a Wish with your ring and Ladybug’s earrings, so I know that’s not an option but. His devotion means I can’t help but wonder if *I* should do more.”

“Do more?”

Her nails bite into the palms of her hands, she’ll be surprised if she’s *not* bleeding later. “if I manage to get Shadow Moth to surrender then you and Ladybug are going to have a lot of time on your hands, along with access to a lot of magical power.”

“Nathalie?”

“I just think, should I ask her if anything could be done for your mother?”

His voice cracks, in a sign how he’s aging in Emilie’s absence. “What?”

“Maybe terrorising the city is wrong, but if Ladybug could save her and I don’t ask her to isn’t that wrong too?”

Adrien just stares at her gaping, and thank goodness they’d built up to this.

“I…don’t think that’s how it works.” He says eventually.

“What?”

“It’s, it’s not your job to find Maman, and it’s not Ladybug’s either and. I’m not even sure she *could* do anything. She can open a portal to anywhere but she can’t do that if she doesn’t know where to, and we’re not supposed to meddle with time and…wouldn’t it be wrong?”

“Wrong? To help someone?”

“To expect her to help *us* just because Plagg chose me? I’m not the only person who’s lost someone. I’m not even the only person in my family who has, would you expect her to help Félix get his dad back?”

“That’s not the same.”

“Why? Just because we don’t know what’s happened to my mother? You’re right. It is different. I would be easier if I could know. But I do know she’s *gone.* She’s not coming back,” his voice increases in volume, “I cried myself to sleep for *nights* after we lost her, I spent every day alone waiting for her to walk in the door while my father hid himself in his atelier. AND I CAN’T KEEP LIVING LIKE THAT!”

“Adrien,” she stands but falters under Adrien’s fury, and the sudden sensation of having lost the ground beneath she as everything assumption she’s had about what Adrien needs and how to fix it all is turned upside down.

“No, I know she’s not coming back and I’ve accepted that because that’s the only way I can live and you and father, you two just refuse to even consider that and do you know how hard that makes things for me? Having to know that father’s not going to get better, having that little bit of hope instead me keep getting stoked for nothing because you’re supposed to be able to trust you parent’s with things like this? And now you’re dangling it in front of me again, possibly endangering my relationship with one of the only good things in my life, just because you want to go off with Shadow Moth and not feel guilty about it?”

“That’s not *why,*” she finds herself snapping back, and hates herself for it at Adrien’s wince. “I’m sorry, I didn’t mean to,”

“*I’m* sorry,” Adrien says, “that wasn’t fair of me, and its more father anyway. I know you just do what you have to. And I know you were just trying to help. But do me a favour?”

“If I can.”

“Try not get inspired by Shadow Moth. If you of you has to have an influence on the other then it *needs* to be you on him.“

She smiles the fakest weakest smile she’s ever mustered, because it’s a little too late for that.

“That’s what I’m trying.”

But despite all Adrien’s words, all his deeply felt feelings he’s entrusted her with, she still does think she needs to talk to Ladybug.

Especially with the glances Gabriel keeps casting on her when he thinks she’s not looking. Asking him to see her might have been a mistake.

Chapter 15: Duusu I

Nooroo has a secret and he's not sharing.

It's not *fair.*

Duusu too is stuck here as the prisoner of Gabriel Agreste, and without even the distinction of being first Kwami. And it's so boring.

The only excitement, the only *hope,* around had been the growing relationship between their so-called master and Miss Nathalie who makes sure that both he and they are looked after and fed and sleep, and are able to keep fighting.

Splintered memories, like looking through broken glass, suggest Miss Nathalie had been his holder before. Duusu thinks that would have been better. The woman might also be a villain but at least she's *nice.*

And her emotions were so much more comfortable to be around. Guilt is hardly one of Duusu's favourites but in the circumstances it's right that it should be felt and it's certainly better than Gabriel's righteous self-justification that tries to ignore it. At least until it pokes through when Miss Nathalie coughs and when something happens to make him realise, before he forgets again, the danger he's placing his son in.

He likes to try not be feel *most* of his emotions actually. Anger he lets himself feel and devastation when he loses but anything else he stifles in a way that almost makes it feel like Duusu's the one being smothered with a blanket cutting of any sense of the world.

Miss Nathalie *hides* her emotions from the people around her but she doesn't try not to feel them. Duusu feels her little bursts of irritation, and sparks of excitement, and nervous hope followed by troughs of disappointment, and then below it all her *love.*

Constant unyielding devoted love.

It's always been one of Duusu's favourite emotions to feel; it offers so maybe different possibilities, so many ways it could play out.

Duusu could create something beautiful from Miss Nathalie's love, it calls out almost asking the Kwami to do so, for some acknowledgement when Gabriel won't give it.

But it's dangerous to create anything without a wielder and moreso from an emotion like this. Even if Shadow Moth or Mayura were to the ones to make it that steadfast devotion could be forged into a sentimonster that even they might have cause to regret.

Love makes people do terrible things after all.

And Miss Nathalie's has done terrible things for her love.

But it makes her do good things too, like standing up to their master about his son, and doing things that he wouldn't approve of but which would make all of their lives better, and giving him hugs when he's down.

The last one doesn't sound like much but Gabriel Agreste is a volatile man who yearns *not* to feel and the worse his grief and self-hatred and anger gets the more likely he is to turn his anger out on the whole world.

Without Miss Nathalie what he forces Duusu and Nooroo to create would be worse. He wouldn't be satisfied with the highly-felt but often low stakes conflicts of teenagers. No, he'd look for the worst emotions around even if they were further again, and fainter, and not really helpful to his apparent cause. Because really he'd be fighting as much to make everyone feel the way he had after losing his wife as he would be to bring her back.

He must have loved the woman in the casket once. Otherwise he wouldn't feel the sadness that threatens to smoother Duusu whenever he stands in front of her, or the anger that almost burns.

Duusu doesn't really remember Emilie Agreste. Trying to only brings a fuzzy sense of warmth and determination.

Nooroo can't offer much either. Apparently *he* hadn't been called upon much before.

The, yes *romantic,* love that is hidden deep inside Gabriel Agreste's chest now isn't for his wife. It's a confused little thing, and Duusu can't help not pout at how he feels it surge after they've transformed him.

Nathalie was here *first,* and Duusu doesn't even know Panthera even if the lack of akuma attacks recently, and how for the first time in forever Mr Gabriel seems to be considering giving up suggest hers is a good influence.

Even if that last part was because of Miss Nathalie.

So illogical as it might be Duusu can't help but beam on feeling Mr Gabriel come to a decision and stand up.

His hand goes to his cravat, pressing against the Miraculous beneath, and then the Kwamis follow him down the corridor to Nathalie's room.

For some reason nervousness emanates from him but there's no sign of wavering, no worry he's making the wrong choice, and Duusu can't *wait* to see what he's going to do.

There's a flare of panic on opening the door, and Duusu doesn't get it until the empty bed comes into view but then it disappears as Gabriel spots Nathalie curled up in one of the chairs by the unused fireplace.

"There you are," he smiles.

Nathalie looks up, "oh, sir. Were you looking for me?"

From their expressions you'd never know how similar their emotions in this moment are.

Save for the bit of disappointment from the man at her form of address for him.

"We need to talk, my dear Nathalie."

Nathalie leans forward, uncurling her feet from beneath her to sit more professionally. "That sounds serious, should I be concerned?"

There's an upturn to the corner of her mouth like she's joking but beneath it she's clearly actually very much concerned already. That little leap her heart makes whenever she sees Mr Gabriel abruptly halting.

He sits down.

Exhales.

Leans forward and places his hand on Miss Nathalie's cheek, and Nooroo feels the affection/guilt/*want* there too from his abrupt turn of his head to meet Duusu's eyes.

"Shh," Nooroo whispers as if expecting Duusu to let out a happy shriek of excitement, like he's the only one who's learnt the best way to act around these two.

The man just stares at Miss Nathalie. Looking into her eyes, as if he could read something there that Duusu and Nooroo aren't already *giving* him the power to tell.

Her breathing speeds up, and the faintest flush starts to spread over her face.

She's terrified. She's exhilarated. And she's also very very confused.

"Are you alright?" He softly murmurs, concern leaking from him like water through a sieve.

Nathalie looks around as If someone can save her from this conversation. Like he'd listen to any of them.

"It's got very warm in here?"

"Has it?" His hand leaves her cheek to press the back against her forehead, "You don't think you're ill?"

"No more than usual,"

That makes him release her with a flinch of guilt, and combined with Nathalie's sudden harsh self-recrimination Duusu is overwhelmed enough to float closer to Nooroo for an anchor in how awful it all feels.

"You were never meant to get hurt," he shakes his head, "but it's not forever Nathalie. I *am* going to save you."

"I know that you,"

“No,” he interrupts and for once he *isn’t* guilty about her condition, “you don’t understand. I’ve found a way. Regardless of what we do rather than the Wish you’re going to be OK.”

Duusu’s felt hope from Miss Nathalie before but nothing like what thrums through her sharp, “Rather than Wish?”

“You were right. I can’t chance it. I don’t know that I can just abandon Emilie but,”

His words are cut off as Nathalie throws herself at him, her arms closing over his shoulders in an embrace.

Duusu isn’t so surprised. If it’s possible Miss Nathalie’s just fallen more in love with him. She seems t happier than…

Well happier than she’s ever been the entire time Duusu remembers knowing her, and honestly Duusu would be willing to bet that she’s happier than she even was while the Peacock Miraculous was broken as well.

Gabriel Agreste on the other hand is both completely unsurprised and wholly unprepared, though Duusu doesn’t really know why. He knew Nathalie thought this the best course, and it’s not as if the two of them aren’t always finding excuses to touch anyway.

His hand hovers awkwardly over her back, but, Duusu’s eyes narrow, he’s certainly not distressed by the situation.

“Thank you, thank you, thank you,” Miss Nathalie looks up from where her face is buried in his chest, “I knew you’d make the right decision Gabriel.”

Her face shines with a sincerity that needs no Miraculous to back It up. In fact with one her deep all-consuming relief could suggest the opposite of her words.

But as his hand settles heavily on her back despite having pinned almost under her face two Miraculous brooches which could tell him back Gabriel doesn’t seem to notice that contradiction at all. Even ignoring it as he often does anything he’s not ready to deal with quite yet, or which he deems unimportant, or distracted by his own guilt as he hides his head in her hair.

“I’m still not sure what I’m going to do,” he mutters into it.

“That’s alright,” despite the softness of her voice it’s also firm, “we’ll work that out. Together.”

“Hmm,” the sit in silences as that guilt seeps away to be replaced by a pride that almost make’s Duusu’s eyes roll.

Their jailer always has been good at letting Miss Nathalie’s approval scrub away the few remaining qualms he have.

And he’s utterly pleased with himself as he says, “you know, I haven’t even told you how I’m going to heal you yet.”

Suddenly it's *Nathalie* whose guilt Duusu can feel and it's followed a millisecond later by panic.

It's a very strange reaction to being told you're not longer going to be made ill by magic.

"You told me you were going to, and you said you'd given up the Wish so you must have found a way. The details aren't so important."

He expels half a laugh, "oh Nathalie. What would I do without your belief in me? Though maybe I'm a little disappointed not to see what you're next enthusiastic response would have been."

Miss Nathalie's embarrassment isn't as strong as her guilt but her voice wavers as she says, "what exactly were you hoping for?"

A swallow does nothing to stop the desire shooting through him, nor the surprise that follows, and then the oddest temptation to shock Nathalie and Duusu halfway expects Nooroo to starting pulling her out the room. He can get prudish about this sort of thing.

But then a sharp prick of pain seems to burst that little bubble and, "Sorry,"

He's clumsily tries to reach for his Miraculous under Miss Nathalie and rather annoyed Duusu realises that it must have pricked him.

Of all the times!

Why couldn't it be during an akuma attack or sometime like that!

And then the room disappears and everything goes blue.

Oh.

Renunciation.

But before Duusu can even start to think about the fact that *Shadow Moth has just given up the Peacock Miraculous* the familiar surroundings of Miss Nathalie's room comes back.

And Miss Nathalie, no longer pressed against Mr Gabriel, who know seems to be kneeling in front of her chair is smiling at her.

"Hello Duusu," she says, and her bright excitement is infectious, "I'm going to be your Mistress again. For a little bit anyway."

Her old master nods, backing up her statement.

"I thought we weren't going after Ladybug and Panthera again."

And *ooh* there's a fun response from Mr Gabriel at her name, as he must remember the superheroine was the last one he'd held the way he'd just been holding Miss Nathalie and that his response had been much the same then.

Well he deserves to feel bad about it so Duusu's quite satisfied by the discomfort and confusion he's currently trying to feel.

Miss Nathalie's smile only seems to grow wider, she's so *so* pleased. "Mayura's not going to be helping Hawk Moth with attacks. Gabriel's given this to me so I can contact Panthera."

Putting on the best scary judgemental face Duusu flies up to Mr Gabriel, "and why would she want to do that?"

He stares right back like Duusu's a bug he wants to squish, "because she has the power to heal Nathalie. And because she's agreed to heal Mayura."

"She has?" oh Duusu gets why his Miss Nathalie is so pleased, because she's so pleased too. This is so so great. Even though it's hardly the fault of the *Kwami* if their wielder breaks the Miraculous Duusu has never *liked* seeing the damage the Peacock Miraculous had left on Miss Nathalie. "Oh that's so much better. Miss Nathalie Is going to be ok."

It sort of feels like maybe if Duusu had been able to say something different to Emilie Agreste then she could have been convinced not to do any of this.

And even if that wasn't the case, if Duusu had never been able to stop what happened then it didn't change that there was still a faint link between the damage being done and where the energy that had done the damage had come from in the first place.

Duusu.

It's not how the magic is *supposed* to work, and seeing Miss Nathalie suffer had always felt wrong, and made Duusu feel sad even when she'd been cross at her for helping Mr Gabriel.

So this is so fantastic that Duusu can almost *almost* forgive Mr Gabriel. A little bit. Not totally.

"Yes," the man in question nods, and he's so fond Duusu thinks Miss Nathalie must feel it too, "she's going to be ok."

Maybe Miss Nathalie does because her smilie changes to a different one and she ducks her head shyly, "Gabriel…would you mind if I tried it now? Contacting Panthera?"

"Of course not," concern makes him frown, "should I stay while you transform? We could go together. I know she thinks you'll be fine but I'm not sure it's a risk we should take."

"Together," huh, Miss Nathalie very much does not like that idea and Duusu does not get it, "no that's alright. In fact," she reaches for her phone, "Adrien has a photoshoot coming up. And I know this totally isn't how anything is supposed to work but could *you* possibly take him."

He stares back at her confused, "Adrien has a fracture. I know he's much more mobile with the boot but how can he has a photoshoot?"

“It’s for touch-up shots of his face from the last one. You didn’t like the expressions remember?”

“Did I not?” and yep, Duusu is still enjoying it when he’s annoyed with himself, “well I suppose I can go but I still don’t like you going alone.”

“Maybe I’ll just contact her with the Miraculous then,” Miss Nathalie says.

“You, you know how to do that?”

“I know it *can* be done.” Miss Nathalie is amused, “I *am* aware of your conversations with her sir.”

“Oh.” And he’s embarrassed again, “I’d best be going then.”

“Good luck,” Miss Nathalie almost does a little wave as he leaves.

She stares dreamily at the door, and fingers her Miraculous.

“Oh yeah,” a very familiar voice that Duusu hasn’t heard in years, “he totally doesn’t have feelings for you. Urgh the two of you are worse than-“

“PLAGGGY!” Duusu flies at the Black Cat Kwami, “What are you doing here? This is so cool, oh my gosh you need to help me save Nooroo he’s stuck with Mr Gabriel and he’s terrible,”

Miss Nathalie snorts.

“Sorry Miss Nathalie, but to everyone except you he is, and anyway Plagg hasn’t answered me, how are you here? When did you find out where Nooroo and I were? Do you know Miss Nathalie? Did you know she’s going to be OK? Did you hear Shadow,” but oooh he doesn’t have Duusu anymore, “Hawk Moth is going to stop trying to steal your Miraculous?”

“I am suddenly wondering why I wanted to help you.” Plagg groans.

“Duusu,” Miss Nathalie is doing her responsible voice, “this is a secret and as the holder of your Miraculous I’m commanding you that you can’t tell anyone.”

The sensation of the command tightening around is no fun at all, “not even Nooroo?”

“Nooroo knows. But you can’t talk to him about it where Mr Gabriel might overhear.”

“Oh! Are you secretly working for Ladybug? I knew you were nice,” Duusu beams. It’s so cool, and so romantic. Her and Hawk Moth as star-crossed lovers with Miss Nathalie trying to bring him back out of being villainy without him discovering her allegiance and ruining the *mutual* bond between them.

“I’m working for the Agrestes.” Nathalie throws cold water on that idea, “I’m going to make sure they come out of this the absolute best way possible.”

But actually that's still kind of beautiful and could make the best story now they're not going after the Wish and Duusu can cheer Gabriel and Nathalie on wholeheartedly and…

"But what's Plagg doing here?"

Nathalie shrugs one shoulder, "Plagg, claws out."

And there's Panthera in her place. Dusuu's not seen her in the flesh before. Usually too busy creating Shadow Moth's transformation, but the heroine is easily recognisable from photos and the blurry recognition from Shadow Moth's interactions with her.

"You're Panthera! And he doesn't know!"

"I am. And he doesn't. And we don't have time for this because I need to go see Ladybug." She types something in her staff.

Duusu frowns. The woman in front of her is stressed, and seems ready for a fight but she's also oddly….hopeful seems the best word for it.

Probably another secret Duusu will discover soon.

"Aren't you going to unify me with him?"

"Not yet," Panthera holds her hand out for Duusu as she had as Miss Nathalie, "I need you to be very very quiet, and very serious and pay lots of attention to what Ladybug's feeling OK?"

Need isn't an exaggeration from her point of view at least.

"It's important?"

"Very important. If Ladybug seems ready to turn on us I have to know. Give me a nudge or something. And if it all goes well then…I need you to tell me if I can trust she's telling the truth."

"I can do that," it doesn't even sound that bad. "What are you going to ask Ladybug?"

"Something very very important."

…

Ladybug is annoyed when she arrives. "What's this all about?"

Panthera folds her arms, as If she wasn't the one to summon Ladybug to this rooftop. "Shadow Moth."

It's a simple clever answer but then Duusu had known Panthera was clever.

"Alright. Go on then."

"If someone dies from using a broken Miraculous can they be saved?"

Ladybug's eyes widen, "so you were right about him wanting to save someone."

"Yes."

"But," Ladybug's suspicious again now and her hand curls over her yo-yo but Duusu doesn't judge it time to alert her new-old holder yet, "The Butterfly and the Peacock are the only ones missing from the Miracle Box and he's used both of them. How can the problem be a broken Miraculous? Are you sure he's not lying to you to try to make it our problem?"

"He fixed the Peacock with the information he took from the previous Guardian."

"*Stole* from the previous Guardian," Ladybug corrects but despite her sharp tone, Duusu can feel the consideration turning over through Ladybug's mind. If she let herself be taken over by her every emotion then she'd have been akumatised long ago, or a sentimonster created from her so it makes sense that despite her distrust she'd listen.

"Stole then."

Disgust fills Ladybug, "so *that's* why he started wearing it after that. What a prick. That does actually make perfect sense but, *wait,"* now it's horror, "are you telling me Mayura's dead? And that still doesn't explain why he wanted our Miraculous before so-"

"Mayura isn't dead," Panthera doesn't lie, "The Miraculous made her very sick, but Plagg is able to heal her and I've agreed with Hawk Moth to do so."

"*What?!*" Oh she is very very cross, and Duusu debates making her move, on Ladybug's rather high pitched, "Without *asking* me? Why would you do that?"

"In exchange for the Peacock Miraculous," Panthera says evenly. "and there wasn't exactly time to ask you."

"You really believe he's going to give you that?" Ladybug scoffs but doesn't seem quite ready to attack.

"He already has," Panthera bends down her unzipped collar to show it pinned there.

Ladybug reaches up but Panthera shakes her head. "Not yet. Should things go wrong…." Which seems to be a true worry, "I might yet need it."

"So you *don't* totally trust him?"

"Mayura isn't the reason he started fighting."

"He wanted a Wish to raise the dead." Ladybug realises, "but then, he should never have let Mayura use it?"

"Give Mayura some credit, she *chose* to use that Miraculous."

"I feel like I should give her the opposite of credit for that."

Panthera tilts her head, but she doesn't feel offended to Duusu, "Maybe."

"So..." Ladybug frowns, "you want to know if there's another way to save this person Hawk Moth's fighting for?"

"Yes."

Ladybug's sadness must be as obvious to Miss Nathalie as Duusu as her whole face falls, "I can't raise the dead. No Miraculous can. Even combing mine and Chat Noir's would take an equal price."

Panthera seems oddly reluctant to ask. "You bring people back after akuma attacks, don't you?"

"What? Ladybug shakes her head, "no I…." for a moment Duusu is frightened because what Ladybug's feeling right now is *exactly* the sort of thing Hawk Moth would akumatise, "that's not the same."

"Why?"

"That's tied to the akuma, and it's only, it's taking away damage magic has made. Fixing something that never should have happened."

"Isn't a broken Miraculous that?"

"There wouldn't be any dark intention to cleanse, I can't. I can't work from nothing, I can't cure someone ill, or save someone in a car crash, or bring back my friend's mother. It's that's all part of life and my Miraculous doesn't work against that."

"Because it's part of it too," Panthera finishes for her and she, she's *relieved,* she wants to give up.

"What Shadow Moth's doing, it's fighting against the inevitable." Ladybug says.

"So, it wouldn't be selfish to give up?"

"Why would it be selfish, it would be selfish to— Oh."

"Yeah," Panthera admits.

"So um. You and Shadow Moth? It's um, serious then."

"I don't know." Panthera says, "but I'm starting to wonder if I'm wrong about it being impossible."

Chapter 16: Gabriel VI

The picnic blanket is in place, wine and cheese placed carefully central. He'd considered candles but decided against it in the end. Too much that could go accidentally wrong. This time there will be no embarrassing mistakes.

At least Hawk Moth's outfit will not betray him the way Shadow Moth's did.

And now he's given up the Peacock Miraculous he can finally admit that he *has* always thought it had a more flattering cut too.

Not that he's trying to seduce Panthera this time.

But still.

Appearances *are* important.

"Hi," her voice startles him from behind, he'd had thought he'd have heard her enter through a window.

He forces himself to turn slowly, into of twisting in shock. "Hello. Silent as a cat indeed."

"I try," there's amusement playing over her lips but her eyes are wide as she looks around, "you set all this up?"

Gabriel looks around the otherwise empty room, "well, I could hardly take you out to a restaurant. You'd be surprised at how many empty buildings there are in Paris when you care to look."

Even ones he himself owns but that goes seem like it might be a little too close to giving the game away. Still it had been easy enough for Nathalie to find a suitable meeting place even if he'd taken over the rest of the preparations himself.

It had seemed…wrong to expect her to help even if this is after all in many ways *because* of her.

Panthera elegantly settles down onto the rug, "my Kwami will be jealous you know. He's a maniac for cheese."

"Mine's rather fond of wine," he settles his legs down next to her.

"Hawk Moth," then she wrinkles her nose, "it's odd calling you that again."

"Not a downgrade I hope?"

"No, not a downgrade at all." Her shy smile reminds him of the new little ones that Nathalie's started sporting, and for once he's totally at ease as he reaches for the glasses.

But then she stops him, “before you pour anything. What is this about? I know you said you weren’t going to make the Wish but,”

“It’s not that.” He releases his hold on the stems and takes her hands in his instead, “this is me saying thank you.”

“Oh.”

“For helping me decide against the Wish,”

“I don’t know that that was me,”

“Without you I don’t know I could have made the decision with what it meant for Mayura and-,” *my son and my wife,* but he doesn’t want to go into that, still isn’t quite ready to admit why he’d been doing this while he was flirting with her and how close he’d come to being ready to sacrifice *his* son when she’s such a fierce protector of hers.

“And,”

“I can’t thank you enough for what you’ve done for Mayura. Seeing her now-“

It hadn’t been obvious while she’d been sat in her chair but then when she’d left to go fetch Adrien for lunch his ears had caught on the sound of her shoes against the Atelier floor. How it had sounded different to what he’d become used to.

And then when the door had let her back in the difference had been obvious.

“You’re not wearing your exoskeleton.” He’d realised.

“I’m not,” and then he’d seen the first of those smiles. Not the smirks of their planning, or the cool pleasure she sometimes shows as she, so politely they can’t complain, makes it clear he won’t be talking to someone, but pure joy and unlike its descendants this first smile hadn’t been small at all.

It had been beautiful on Nathalie’s face.

Nathalie had been beautiful.

She’d seemed to glow almost and he’d been about to ask if she’d tried a new foundation or something, when he’d realised what he was seeing was the healthy flush of *vitality.*

It had seemed like a travesty that he’d ever allowed her to become anything less than she was then; beautiful, happy, and well.

Panthera cocks her head, waiting.

“I don't know how to describe it.” He finishes weakly, “she’s... she’s so much better.”

“That it would heal her was the aim.”

“I know but,” and now he reaches for the wine and pours it, before passing her her glass, “cheers.”

“Cheers,” she echoes still seeming a little bemused.

He muses, swirling the glass around, “it’s more than just her health. She seems so much... lighter now. I suppose it’s how much easier things are for her now which makes me feel terrible but,”

“You chose her over fighting with her Miraculous. That's saving her too,” she lifts her glass to her mouth, burgundy wine against the deeper red of her lips, “and maybe it's not just her health making things easier for her these days.”

“What else could it be?”

Her eyes go all soft and comforting, and there’s nothing he wants more than to see that expression on her real eyes. Not these false green feline eyes. Human blue eyes creasing round their corners with affection despite a weary sadness shiny in them.

Not that he knows they *are* blue but it’s hard to imagine anything else now he’s got used to imagining them that way. Not a less saturated shade of it like his own grey-blue but something brighter, though not as true a blue as Ladybug’s since he *refuses* to ruin the image with that. No Something more like the aquamarine of Nathalie’s and if that feels a little too right he can probably blame it on Adrien’s confusing ideas.

“She was the one who told you about the Wish wasn’t she? It must be a relief that you’ve chosen not to chance it.”

“Yes, it must have been.”

He’s thankful for the mask hiding the flush he can feel on his face as he remembers Nathalie’s joyous reaction. The phantom warmth of her body feels heavy against his chest, and he can almost smell the scent of her hair, and the knowledge won’t leave him of how different it had felt to have her in his arms then to when he’d carried her during her illness.

“I’d have been. I mean I *was,* when you told me.”

“Because *you* are supposed to be keeping that ring safe from me.”

“Hmm, I can’t deny less akuma attacks would leave me for more time for the rest of my life. But honestly, it was on Chat Noir’s behalf I was most relieved.”

“That makes sense.” That kinship he feels with her raises it’s head again. “I’m relieved I didn’t do it for my son’s sake too.”

“You know. I was relieved for you too.”

Gabriel tries to resist the urge to frown. He doesn’t want to seem dismissive. “For me?”

“You’ve done so much to get these jewels for something deeply important to you, and despite my best attempts you’ve found your way into my affection. I’d have hated for you to think you’d won only to lose something else.”

It’s a good thing Gabriel’s not the one wielding the power of destruction right now or the shiver that went down his spine at the suggestion of Nathalie or Adrien crumpling to the floor dead at his hand as Emilie rose up out of his casket might have sparked a cataclysm.

Instead he tries to grasp for something else to destroy the image and finds it in Panthera’s words.

“I’ve managed to wriggle my way into your affections have I?”

“Oh hush you. You know that. Or do you think I spend hours on the phone to anyone?”

“Hmm,” he gives into the impulse to stroke just behind the ears of Panthera’s mask to see if it gains him a reaction, “but I don’t know *what* place I have in them.”

She eyes flutter, and she makes a noise as close to a purr as a human woman can, “Hawk Moth,”

“What? Do I give you butterflies in your stomach?”

Her eyes immediately open and she moves her head out of the curve of his hand, “you had to go and ruin it didn’t you?”

“I thought it was clever.”

“Please for the sake of my sanity never give Chat Noir lessons on dating.”

He almost smirks. “I always thought the boy’s major issue was being focused on the wrong girl.”

“You’re not exactly wrong there. Although I’m not sure that she *is* exactly the wrong girl.”

“Ah.” The heroes had never been at the forefront of his mind when he speaks to Panthera but he recalls, “You said she had a crush on his identity under the mask.”

“Another set of people you might be making happy. I assume their mutual unmasking will be saccharine enough to make our teeth hurt.”

“Probably. Though I don’t really think I’ll be the one making them happy. I’d hate to lose your goodwill by kidnapping and unmasking Chat Noir and his possible future girlfriend.”

“What?” She frowns, and looked away again, “I’m sorry. I guess I got ahead of myself.”

“How?”

She shrugs, “I guess I got so caught up in the excitement of you choosing not to make the Wish I forgot that you haven’t actually said you giving up completely.”

“Oh. That’s alright, you’re not the only one.”

Gabriel almost had himself the other day. He’d been watching Nathalie, his heart beating off a happy little beat at how clear it was death from the Miraculous had been avoided for her, when she’d placed a cup of coffee down next to him.

And he’d wanted nothing more in that moment than for this not just to be something that happened during work hours. He’d wanted her to make him coffee first thing in the morning, and to do the same for her. To have Nathalie and her support *all* the time truly, not just because he paid her and because circumstances made it practical to stay here.

He’d grabbed her hand to say, he doesn’t know what, and he thinks Nathalie had forgotten too with how her lips had parted and she’d made no move to separate herself from him.

But then then she’d gone from as seemingly unable to look away as he was to apparently catching sight of something behind him and she’d gone stiff.

He’d almost thought Adrien had stuck in behind him or something and had been ready to turn and confront his son when he'd remembered: Emilie’s portrait.

The visual representation of the woman lying below them waiting for him to bring them back.

It had been liked a rush of cold water and he’d let go of Nathalie.

“Have you thought sir, what you’re going to do?”

They'd both known exactly what she was referring to. There’s no reason to be circumspect in the Atelier; if they could be caught for incriminating themselves there then they’d already be in court under the unimpressed eyes of a judge. Yet she hadn’t needed to say anything more and it had felt wrong to do so.

As if doing do would bring the spectre of Emilie up from her resting place to judge them.

She’d be doing rather a lot of judging *him* recently.

And aware of that all he could offer was a cowardly, “Not yet.”

Panthera draws her glass to her lips and takes a long draw and then says, “do you... think you will try to find another way?”

“Why? Are you offering to negotiate with Ladybug for me.”

She sags a little, “she'll never agree a trade of any Miraculous.”

It's easy to shake his head, “none of the others have the power for what I need.”

There’s the Rabbit but what can be done with that can be just as easily *undone,* and there's so much tied up in his past he's reticent to chance changing, to risk losing with an over early

change to the timeline. Never mind the paradox it could cause. Nathalie might know if it could be done but he doesn't know if he wants to ask her.

"If," Panthera bits her lower lip, "there's anything else I could do to help..."

"There isn't."

"I'm sorry."

"No I'm sorry. I shouldn't have snapped. You, my darling Cat have been a light in all this darkness to me."

Her mask doesn't quite cover enough of her face to hide her blush. The strawberry stain of it creeping past the edge of her mask.

Embarrassment and desire and despite his turn away from villainy, guilt warring with hope tickle against his Miraculous making his mouth dry.

She gulps, as his eyes drawn to the motion of her throat, "I wish you wouldn't say things like that to me."

"There I thought that was your favourite thing about me."

"No, that would be how far you've go for the people you love."

"Sometimes now I think that's either too far or not far enough."

"I think I know that feeling."

Sympathy rings through him even if *her* mistakes are nothing compared to his. "Still feel you need to confiscate Chat Noir's Miraculous permanently for sneaking out and being a superhero?"

"Humph, something like that."

"I meant it you know. When I said I was thankful for all you've done. If it wasn't for you, and for Mayura then I don't know where I'd be now."

"Probably somewhere worse," she concedes with a tilt of her head, "though I'm not sure that was really me."

He can't help but disagree, "Mayura gave me the courage to continue after the worst part of my life. You gave me the courage to *change."*

"I think maybe you just see me as you want me to be."

"You're a very tough woman to compliment you know."

"Hawk Moth, do you..."

"Do I what?"

“Do you think you maybe have the issue you thought Chat Noir had? That maybe you’re…”

“Focused on the wrong woman?”

She means herself. He’s not blind to that. Not with how clear she’s always been that nothing can happen between them despite the want he always feels from her in his presence.

But it’s not Panthera that the words on his tongue conjures up in his mind.

No, it’s Emilie that he lets himself taste the possibility of letting go when he adds, “perhaps.”

Ever he decided to give up the wish-

No.

Ever since that moment Nathalie had come to him with what she’d found it’s all felt different.

It had all seemed so simple before.

Emilie was dead if not for his intervention. She was his wife and he loved her, of course he’d do anything for her. And their family, he hadn’t known how to be happy without her, and he certainly hadn’t known what to do with Adrien when he’d always let Emilie handle most things about their son, and he’d thought *saving* Emilie was the only way to put their family back together. That with her missing there *wasn’t* a family.

But Panthera and Chat Noir are clearly a family whatever their connection.

And Nathalie and Adrien only seem to get closer day by day even as he’s tried to put that fact out of his mind as much as possible.

And it seems like perhaps his heart isn’t the shrivelled dry thing incapable of love he’d thought it was without Emilie.

So that insidious whisper in his head keeps up its irritating buzz. Asking that if it took killing someone else he loved to bring Emilie back wasn’t she actually already dead after all whatever her casket might do to keep her suspended in time?

Funny how it seems different when *he’s* the one losing regardless.

He’d told himself before that what did mattered if he ruined someone else’s life like his had been ruined?

He was willing to fight against the physical laws of the universe, to terrorise an entire city, nay the whole world, to gain the primal forces of creation and destruction he needed to do so. If whoever he doomed had someone who truly loved them then they could do the same as Gabriel did.

But it wouldn’t someone else. Nathalie had told him it would be him again.

And Panthera has a way of making him feel guilt.

And he wasn't sure Emilie would like the man he'd become.

But others looked at him now and all his foibles and still believed in him. One of them even knowing *all* of him. How he'd only briefly attempted to reach out to Adrien telling himself it would all be fixed so there was no great need to. And now it won't be. And he's going to need help.

"Did Mayura say much about me? When you've been healing her?" He frowns, "how does that work actually? Do you just wave your arms over her?"

"Which of those questions did you actually want me to answer? Actually I'm stopping you right there, what happens between myself and Mayura *stays* between myself and Mayura."

"That's no fun," although now he's trying to work out what it would look like if Nathalie had to wear the Cat Miraculous to heal but all he keeps coming up with is Panthera with Nathalie's bun. Similarly imagining Panthera with the Peacock should they swap just gives him Mayura with Panthera's messy waves.

That probably says something about his psyche.

"Did you want me to tell Mayura the details of all our conversations?"

"She probably guesses much of them. She's a remarkably perceptive woman. But no. Still. What did you think of her?"

"What did I think of her?"

"Did you like her?"

Unfortunately he's caught her in the middle of a sip, and she chokes on it launching into a coughing fit that makes his own throat close up in horrified sympathy. Latent instincts from Nathalie's illness have him moving immediately.

Thankfully she shakes her head, as he's about to offer to help, but she doesn't shrug his hands off her shoulders this time once the coughing subsides.

"Sorry, went down the wrong way."

"You're alright?"

"Yeah OK."

"So dare I ask you that question again?"

Her face freezes in exactly the same way Nathalie's had when he'd trying pressing her on her opinion of Panthera before she'd told him she was very grateful for the healing offered her, and what the heroine had been able to offer him but she didn't think *her* opinion on Panthera was particularly relevant in the circumstances.

“She’d very devoted to you you know,” Panthera at least defers the question more gracefully but that only makes him *more* fascinated by what exactly had gone down between them because it doesn’t suggest any enmity between them the way Nathalie’s might.

“I do know,” he admits, “I’m not sure I deserve it.”

“I don’t know that it’s about deserving it. But you did justify her trust in you didn’t you?”

“I suppose I did.”

“Hawk Moth,” Panthera’s warm voice is uncertain again, “do you have feelings for Mayura?”

“Good thing this isn’t a date or I’d be failing desperately at it.” He still feels embarrassed. But maybe not as much as he shoud.

“You don’t have to answer.”

“You told me you loved Chat Noir’s father. So.” He exhales, “I am thinking of giving up. And if I do I think I might have to deal with the fact you remind me of her and all the implications of that.”

The corner of her lips starts to turn up, and he can’t help but go, “what?!”

“I like it when you’re brave.”

“Was that brave?”

“I think so.”

“You’re a strange one,” it’s easy enough to understand how Panthera can like him and be attracted to him but still stand certain on her walls of not letting anything happen between them, but how she can seem honestly *happy* with no hint of jealousy at all when he talks of his feelings for Nathalie he can’t understand at all.

But then if Nathalie has feelings for him, which he doesn’t know, and maybe it’s Adrien giving him unearned confidence here, but he certainly feels they could be nurtured in her from her reactions to him, she’s developed them while helping him try to get Emilie back so maybe it’s some feminine mystery Gabriel will never be able to understand.

“You wouldn’t like me otherwise.”

“Panthera,” he can’t help but lean in closer, “if this is our last time meeting,”

“I really shouldn’t let you kiss me,” but he can feel her breath against his lips and she closes her eyes.

If any man could resist that it’s definitely not him. It’s the work of seconds to close those last few millimetres, and then the softness of her lips are under his. They’re more textured than he’d expected and he wonders if she worries at them, before his mind loses the ability to think at all as her mouth opens, and she drags him down to the floor.

Distantly there's a clang, and part of him registers that that was either a glass or a bottle and Nathalie is not going to be impressed about getting the rug cleaned.

Then he remembers Nathalie and suddenly he's not all running on the impulse to try to close any slightest bit of air between himself and Panthera, to mould himself to her, to bury his reservations in the sensations of her.

Torn between desire that makes him as a dizzy as a teenage boy, and an awkward dissatisfaction that this isn't quite right; that the hair his hands are lost in is too short, that that leather should be soft crimson wool he manages to make himself roll off her.

It's not fair to Panthera to kiss her like this if he's not focused on her.

"I'm sorry,"

"No I get it I think."

"That wasn't actually what I meant to give you you know."

She turns her head to look at him, and once again he feels younger than his years, but back in his courtship of Emilie this time.

He reaches into the pocket he'd made clear to Nooroo needed to be included in his outfit and digs out a little jewellery box.

Panthera almost seems frightened but takes it from him and he can feel her relief as she opens it to discover a set of ruby earrings.

"It's hard when I don't know what you actually look like." He smiles, "I was going to go green. You know for your Miraculous, but then I remembered you saying you'd carry off red better. And well. It's my favourite colour too."

It had also been easier when Adrien had realised that on his screens wasn't designs, but a catalogue. His son had assumed he was picking something for Nathalie and pushed him away from the green he'd been looking at when Gabriel had remembered Panthera's words.

To cover his tracks, what with his son having noticed Nathalie's study of Shadow Moth, he'd pointed out to his son that Nathalie had taken to wearing what appeared to be a peridot ring, that she'd said she'd accidentally found after looking for it for ages when he'd asked if it was new, recently so she clearly *did* like green.

Adrien had countered that she wore all different colours of jewellery but they knew she liked red enough to put it in her hair so he still thought it was a better bet giving him an excuse to give in without suspicion. Nathalie *had* said he should try to listen to what his son said more.

From the look on Panthera's face he made the right choice.

"Aren't you afraid of giving away your identity?"

"Anyone could buy this."

“Anyone with the money to,” she corrected, turning them to catch the light, “but thank you.”

Chapter 17: Nathalie VI

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Nathalie is a sensible adult woman who's been successfully hiding her secret identity as Panthera from the man she lives with, works for, and is in love with. Never mind hiding *his,* and her own as Mayura from the entire world including his own son.

So there's absolutely no reason why she should keep teetering on the boundaries of giving it away by letting herself get distracted by the memory of that kiss. By the heat of his mouth, and he pressure of his weight against her.

Maybe it's just that it's been a long time since the last time someone kissed her and it definitely *hadn't* felt like that then.

Either time's just dulled her recollection or it's turns out that love, even unknown to him *requited* love, makes the difference.

"Nathalie?" Gabriel prompts again.

It takes all her power not to blush, "Sir?"

The kiss had been such a mistake, and she'd *known* it was a mistake but she'd got selfish and greedy and he'd sounded like he was choosing *her* and she's been running on restraint for so long while he actively flirted with her.

But it was definitely a mistake because now she knows exactly what it's like to kiss him, knows how his hands grip her like he never wants to let go, and *he doesn't know she knows* all while she still has to work with him.

She really needs Gabriel to say *half* to what he'd said about Nathalie to Panthera to *Nathalie* so she has an excuse to initiate another kiss and then at least she won't have to hide how affected she is by his presence as Gabriel anymore.

"When is Clara Nightingale supposed to come in for her consultation again?"

"11 o'clock but that's not until tomorrow."

"I know. But I was thinking of having it in the larger atelier."

"You were thinking of leaving the house?"

"Hmm. It seems silly to have the dress shipped here away from the team actually working on it, and making them come over."

"It's how you're been working for the last few years sir," Nathalie tries to just about fall on the side of polite reminder rather than reprimand."

“I know. But I think I’m going to be making some changes to my life. Of course if I was designing something for *you* that would be quite a different matter. It would be stupid to leave here for any sort of fittings.”

It almost feels like he’s *trying* to fluster her, and it’s almost a retaliation to say, “are you expecting to be making me anything?”

“If certain things play out there might be a need for it.”

“Would certain things include-“

A knock on the Atelier door breaks things up, the clock on the corner of her screen suggests it’s likely Adrien back home for lunch.

“Adrien,” she lets Gabriel know, given his ability to lose track of time, “I’ll let him in, or are you too busy?”

“He’s already distracted us. Might as well see what he needs now.”

“Yes sir,” she gets up at goes to the door, still not quite used to the fact that she *can* mostly do without the exoskeleton now and that she no longer has to worry about Gabriel noticing *that* much at least.

Adrien looks at her oddly as he comes in, and she surreptitiously checks her reflection in the her screen as he asks his father if he could go to cheer on his fencing team at their tournament even though he can’t compete.

She interjects then, reminding Gabriel that Adrien had been originally expected to attend as a competitor and thus there’s room in his schedule before going back to her inspection of herself.

Her hair is perfectly in place. Her red streak a little grown out but not in need of a touch up yet. There’s nothing on her face, or obvious smudge on her glasses. Her lipstick and eyeshadow seem perfect and not in need of reapplication. Her usual scarab stud earrings sit safely in her ears.

She’s wearing much the same outfit as she always does working. What Adrien thinks is so odd isn’t readily apparent to *her*.

Oh god.

She *hopes* that her excitement from the other day isn’t that obvious.

Gabriel, apparently aware there’s no good reason not to, gives Adrien permission though he asks Nathalie to accompany him which urgh, Adrien aside teenagers are not her favourites but she can deal even if it means deliberately ignoring when he and his friends talk about things she doesn’t want to and shouldn’t hear.

When Adrien turns to let her lead him out the door he’s still staring at her strangely, as if looking for something.

Unconsciously she brushes her fringe back, “is there something wrong with my appearance Adrien?”

“Oh. No,” he holds up as hands in surrender, “you look fine. I mean. Not fine, um good. I just thought maybe you’d be wearing the earrings Father gave you.”

Nathalie freezes.

But Adrien is looking *far* too innocent and frankly unbothered for this to be his announcement that he’s discovered Shadow Moth is his father, and by the way he and/or Ladybug were spying on her that night.

He might be Emilie’s son but he’s not *that* good.

So either Gabriel bought something *both* for Nathalie and Panthera and…somehow apparently involved Adrien in that decision which feels beyond implausible or, what for some reason asked his son’s opinions on jewellery for Panthera pretending it was for her while having no idea Adrien *knew* Panthera?

That makes no sense.

But now *Gabriel* is looking back up at them to after having returned to his screen immediately after granted Adrien permission and all Nathalie can do is offer a warning, “your father hasn’t given me any earrings Adrien.”

Only Nathalie has apparently made yet another horrific mistake in spending more time with and letting Adrien talk his mind to her as he frowns and looks away from her and *at his father.*

“Father!” Adrien hands fling out at his side in annoyance, “did you just put them in Nathalie’s room without telling her they were from you.”

Gabriel has turned positively *glacial,* but she can see the shake in his hands as he promptly hides them behind his back.

“I have no idea what you’re talking about Adrien.”

Adrien’s eyes dart between them, “I don’t understand why you’d both try and keep this a secret from me. You both know I’d be happy for you to get together, and Father *you* know I saw you chose them, and Nathalie *you* know they were in your room yesterday when we were playing chess.”

Apparently Adrien *has* the subtlety to say “playing chess” rather than “checking in with you and the Kwamis” but *not* enough to realise that even if this wasn’t the tangled mess it is it *still* wouldn’t be helpful of him to stick his oar in like this. School with other people was supposed to *help* his interpersonal skills but it clearly isn’t working in this arena damnit.

She had planned to hide the damned things, and then try to find a way to secretly get rid of them. She’s sure plenty of other people would value them, but Adrien had come in too

quickly and she'd never suspected *this* particular threat because she hadn't thought *he'd* have any reason to recognise them.

"My new ones?" Her voice isn't coming out anywhere near as calmly as she'd hoped. All she can do is pray Gabriel just blames it on her being embarrassed by the misunderstanding, "Adrien, they're not from your father." Then the stop his next question, she adds to her lie, "I bought those myself."

From his awkward reach to the back of his neck Adrien seems to accept us, "I guess I should apologise for ruining the surprise? But at least Father didn't accidentally give you something you already had."

She swallows with as much subtlety as she can, "that's a testament to how well he knows my taste I suppose."

"I'm not sure it implies that at all," and all Nathalie's muscles tense at the rage reined in behind the sharp bite of Gabriel's voice, "Nathalie could you see Adrien off to school."

Confusion fills Adrien's face, "but I've only just got home."

"Have the chef pack up your lunch for you, and go eat it with those friends of yours you're always claiming you want more time with."

"I don't-"

Gabriel looms over both of them. "I think it's time Nathalie and I had a discussion. In private."

The sudden excitement in Adrien's eyes cuts her to the quick.

"Come on," Nathalie places a hand on Adrien's shoulder and guides him out of the atelier.

The boy seems to glow, radiant in a way Nathalie didn't really think a person could be, like a beam of sunlight as he smiles once he's out of the door.

"I'm sorry for making things awkward but maybe,"

"Adrien." She takes up her wallet and pulls out all the cash in it and after a moments thought gives him her debit card too. It should take Gabriel a while to think of tracking *that* rather than the card Adrien has access to, or any of her *Gabriel* account ones. "Go back to school now and just buy lunch somewhere. Your bodyguard will take you. And….don't come home until I text you."

The light drains from his face with every word from her mouth, eyes widening in wounded confusion. "Nathalie?"

"And take this," she slips off the Black Cat Miraculous watching it change shape before eyes as she slips it back onto Adrien's finger instead.

"What's happening?"

Instead of meeting his eyes she finds Plagg's as the kwami appears behind Adrien. "It might be a good idea if you gave it back to Ladybug."

"What?!"

She pushes Adrien out of the door, "and remember. If your father asks, you know nothing about any Miraculous."

"I'd say that anyway but,"

"It's important Adrien."

"OK but what's going on, what has this got to do with the earrings? Is this something related to Shadow Moth? Is it my fault for telling Father you had a crush on him?"

"It's not your fault." It's *her's,* it might be Gabriel's, hell there's even an argument for it all being due to Emilie and her single-minded determination blinding her to what she was doing. "But that doesn't matter. Just *go."*

She'd shove him if she wasn't concerned about rebreaking his ankle. His hard boot gives him decent movement but he still moves down the stairs in front of the house too slowly for her liking until thankfully his bodyguard sees her distress and with a nod picks Adrien up and carries him to the car.

Nathalie knew she liked that man.

Then with a deep breath she turns and goes back to confront Gabriel.

It would be easier just to leave now but if Nathalie always did the easy thing in life then she wouldn't be in this situation to start with.

So she doesn't even pause by the door. There's no benefit to putting this off. Gabriel's mood will only get worse as he waits.

He's stood leaning against her desk but he lets go of it as she enters.

"Was it all a lie Panthera?"

"Sir,"

"I never did pay you enough attention did I? I took your loyalty for granted, I gave you your," he spits the word out, "*privacy.* But you can't hide now Nathalie. I know *exactly* how you feel about me now. Tell me, how long have you been conspiring against me? Trying to find a way to make me give up on my wife so you could have me for yourself."

"That's not what I was doing."

"Isn't it? It was clever of you you know. To approach me twice and make it seem like the choice was Nathalie or Panthera, instead of my *wife* or an wannabe homewrecker like you. So much for your apparent love for Chat Noir's father."

It should hurt. Should feel worse than any blow Shadow Moth had offered her. But instead she it's *anger* that rises in her, harsh and cruel, wanting to harm Gabriel the same way he wants to harm her for all his has a right to be cross, a right to feel betrayed.

Because afterall, "seduction was *your* idea not mine. If you remember I told you your plans with Panthera were a bad idea."

"And yet you didn't shut them down *as* Panthera."

"You didn't exactly give me a chance. And by the way, I wasn't lying about the Wish."

"Of course you'd say that," he yells slamming his fist on the table almost making her jump, "but how can I trust anything you say now? You were supposed to be my *ally* Nathalie. Panthera was supposed to be my friend. And instead you've been lying the whole time."

"I didn't have a choice."

"You could have told me who Chat Noir was when he gave you that ring, you could have not told me and just *given* me the ring if you were so set on protecting the boy, god knows why,"

"I couldn't give you the ring or-"

"You risked dying because you'd found your way into my affections under false pretences,"

She risks extending a hand, "Gabriel,"

But he slaps it aside, and it's more then shock than the pain that makes her flinch away but the air in here suddenly feels far too close and maybe she belatedly understands how it feels to be one of Shadow Moth's victims.

"It was always what was right for Nathalie Sancoeur wasn't it? Never mind what you said about wanting to help this family, wanting to help Adri-"

"Don't you *dare* question my love for Adrien. *That's* why I didn't give you the ring, *that's* why I told you about the Wish because that is the truth Gabriel, push me aside if you want to believe that. Don't risk it. Don't risk *him*."

His eyes narrow and then his hand is on her chin forcing her face up to look at him him, "you do believe that don't you?"

"Because it's the-"

"Shut up!" He snaps, but then his voice softens again, "how did they get to you Nathalie? How did they convince you? What did Chat Noir offer you to make you forget myself and Adrien? Or were *we* what he offered? Did he tell you that you could be enough for us? Did he tell you you were saving us? Well I guess I could just ask your Kwami couldn't I? Give me-"

Gabriel suddenly releases her. "Where's the ring?"

"Gone."

“Even now,” he looks mad, and she wants to draw him back to sanity but he’s out of her reach and she doesn’t know how, “even now you betray me. You used the fact I wanted to protect my son from all of this as a way to get rid of what I needed to save his mother.”

“No. No I took what could doom Adrien out of your reach. I can’t let you keep doing this?”

“Let me? My dear Nathalie. You gave Panthera’s Miraculous *away.* How exactly do you think you’ve going to stop me?”

“Don’t,”

“I’m sorry,” Gabriel says, “I really wish I didn’t have to do this. Wish you really were the woman I thought you were. Nooroo, Dark Wings Rise.”

Hawk Moth stands in front of her, and something at the back of her mind registers with surprise that she’s not any more frightened than a moment ago. Despite Hawk Moth’s increased height and presence what scares her is that this is *Gabriel,* and he’s never looked at her like this before.

“I’ve done all of this for *you.*” She begs him, tries to remind him, *“*You’ve felt my emotions, how can you think I was working against you?”

Something flickers in his eyes, “maybe you really did think you were doing the best thing for me. I’d like to believe that.”

“Do then, because it’s the truth.”

“I’m not sure that’s a concept you’ve familiar with.” His hand is surprisingly soft as it closes on her arm, “it would have been nice if it all had been true. I’d…had ideas for how I’d tell you about my feelings for you, introduce you to the press, and now instead I’m going to have to imprison you.”

“What? What the hell are you talking about?”

“I can’t have you running to the heroes. Or the police. Oh it won’t look good for a second woman in my life to disappear but it can be handled.”

“You can’t be serious.”

“You’ll be in complete comfort. I’ll have your bed installed on the lair. Have the chef make all your favourite foods to bring up.”

“Please stop and think about what you’re saying. If I wanted to betray you to the heroes I could have done that at any time already. I’m not going to-“

“*That* was back when you still thought the two of us could have a happily ever after together. My exposure would have hindered *that* rather, wouldn’t it?”

“Can’t we still *have* that? This doesn’t change anything.”

“It changes *everything.* It-“

And then the window next to them crumpled into nothing

And there Chat Noir stood like some avenging angel, a dark silhouette seeming out of place against the blue sky and the white walls separating the mansion from the road.

Her throat goes tight. He wasn’t supposed to be here, she should never have given him the ring back. She shouldn’t

“Get away from her.” Adrien commands his father like the hero he’s supposed to be and not the scared teenage boy he must be.

Though the question remains as to whether Adrien knows Hawk Moth is his father; just how long he’s been stood outside listening.

Worse still despite how obvious Nathalie feels like she’s managed to make it Gabriel very clearly has not realised that Chat Noir is Adrien, and as he turns towards Chat Noir there’s nothing but hatred in his eyes.

She prays in that moment that some small affection he had for Panthera remains and will remind him that they’d talked about Chat Noir, and how he’s just a boy.

“You.” His hand clenches on the hilt of his cane, “you’re the one who turned her against me. Or perhaps your father did. Either way I’ll enjoy this.”

“Don’t assume that old man,” Chat Noir quips back, repositioning his staff in his hands to attack but Nathalie’s eyes are drawn to the brace Plagg must constructed about Adrien’s leg.

“Hawk Moth don’t,” she tries to get between them, “you don’t need to do this. You’re better than this.”

“Am I?”

“He’s really not,” Adrien huffs.

Nathalie turns, “and *you.* I told you not to come back.”

“*Nathalie,* I’m here to save you.”

“Urgh,” she could tear her hair out, “why do you two have to be like this?!”

“Um,” Adrien and Gabriel’s response in concert would almost be funny if she wasn’t trying to ensure Gabriel doesn’t unknowingly fight his own son *again.*

“I’m asking both of you to stop this.”

“I can’t leave you” Adrien gasps.

“You now I can’t,” Gabriel sounds at least a little apologetic.

“Then I’ll have to make you,” she reaches for the brooch pinned to her turtle neck below her suit jacket, letting this secret free is the best of a bunch of only bad options, “*Duusu,* spread my feathers.”

“What?” Heartbreak echoes through Adrien’s voice, “no, no Nathalie you can’t be.”

“I’m sorry, but just trust me? I kept your Miraculous sa-“ she unable to finish her sentence as Gabriel yanks her back.

“Take off that brooch *now.”*

Trying to wriggle out of his grip, she bristles, “*no.”*

Gabriel tries to reach for her Miraculous, grabs her chest instead, and lets go like he’s burnt, “that’s *my wife’s brooch* you’re using to try to use to kill her,”

“She’s already dead! You admitted that yourself.”

Adrien reminds them of his presence, “What are you even *talking* about?”

“Don’t,” worry about it she means to finish but coughing swallows her next words.

“Oh I’m not falling for *that* again.” Gabriel says, “how long is it since you’ve actually been sick Nathalie?”

She tries to pull a feather for her fan, searching for something *anything* to keep Gabriel and Adrien apart while she can’t but her hand shakes as she does so and she can’t get a grip,

Then she’s falling to the floor, and Adrien’s screaming her name, and this isn’t *right,* Plagg was supposed to have stabilised her, but now her throat hurts worse than ever, and Gabriel’s just standing there staring at her.

Her throat convulses again as more air pushes itself out of her lungs, even as she tries to cover her mouth like it *matters* if she spits saliva everywhere now. As it pushes it’s way through her mouth it’s oddly warm and salty, and when her hand leaves her mouth there’s blood on it.

Black spots take over her vision and her chest hurts the way it usually does after a transformation not *during* when the raw power of the Miraculous keeps her body going until it doesn’t.

But all she can do is keep coughing, and even Gabriel seems to realise that. Kneeling down and putting a hand on her shoulder as if they hadn’t been fighting moments ago.

“Mayura, *Nathalie,* breathe. Please. We can sort this out afterwards. Nathalie just keep breathing for me alright? We’re going to get you help?”

But she can’t do anything but fall into a warm shroud of darkness.

Chapter End Notes

Needless to say this developed a little from it's initial conception in *Snippets*

Chapter 18: Adrien II

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

"We should call a doctor," Hawk Moth says to him, as he carefully lays Nathalie down on her bed. "Usually she recovers of her own accord but I'd prefer to have a second opinion. Especially since your *cure,"* his face twisted on the word. "didn't work."

The supervillain turns from the bed apparently looking for something, leaving his back open for attack if Adrien had the presence of mind to do so.

But Adrien was still distracted by how familiarly Hawk Moth had held Nathalie, how practised the action of laying her down had been, how he'd not questioned where Nathalie's room was.

Especially as Hawk Moth pulls various monitors out from her cupboard, and starts to plug them in and then attach them to Nathalie. Gently pulling off her blazer, and to Adrien's horror putting his hands under her top to attach electrodes to her skin.

Which did all make a sort of sense if Nathalie was Mayura and Hawk Moth had been by her side throughout her illness except no, that made no sense at all; because then why on earth would she have pretended to be on *Adrien's* side as Panthera instead of just giving Hawk Moth the ring?

His heart jumps as Nathalie takes a gasp of air in below then but she doesn't rouse from her unconscious state.

"She's stable at least," Hawk Moth says looking at the machines around her, "I'd thought… but we just need to wait now."

"Plagg said he was helping," even to himself his voice sounds lifeless, "what's wrong with her?"

"Her Miraculous." Hawk Moth said. Then as he picked up Nathalie's tablet he clarified, "the Peacock Miraculous. It was broken. It," he jabs harshly at the screen, "hurt her to wear it. Still hurts her apparently, which makes no sense- it's supposed to be fixed, and apparently she was able to wear the Black Cat Miraculous just fine."

Adrenaline has Adrien's muscles contracting, ready to leap forward into battle once more at the villain's admission that all this time it had been *him* hurting Nathalie.

The Miraculous might have done the damage but clearly Nathalie had worn it to help Hawk Moth. Or even if they somehow had some shared goal they both wanted he'd still *let her wear it.* Got himself cornered so she had to save him and unfortunately it hit a little too close to home with how Nathalie had worn *his* Miraculous despite her own illness, so he could easily see her choosing to continue. Claiming the damage was done.

“So this is your fault.”

“I thought I’d agreed with Panthera to give up that Miraculous once Nathalie no longer needed it to keep her identity secret in return for healing for Mayura. Only it seems that wasn’t the situation at *all.* So I’d suggest it’s *you* she risked her life for even though I can’t understand why.”

Hawk Moth looks down at him like Adrien’s a bug he’d like to squash. He supposes it’s nothing new. It’s pretty much how he imagines Hawk Moth *does* think of everyone except Mayura, who is apparently Nathalie, and it’s not dissimilar at all to what that copy of Hawk Moth had looked down at him as he was ready to drive his sword through Adrien’s shoulder.

It’s *not* how his father looks at him, even when he’s furious, or when he ignores him, and honestly Adrien had thought it *was.* Thought he was a useful asset at best, or a burden at worse and maybe his father, though he did love him, didn’t know how to see him as anything other than that. Only maybe that’s not true and he doesn’t know how to deal with that right now.

It feels like there was a rock in his throat blocking his airways, “shouldn’t we get on calling that doctor?”

Hawk Moth holds up the Ipad, “already done.”

“Right,” and he wasn’t going to cry, he couldn’t cry, not now. Ladybug needed him to be strong. *Nathalie* needed him to be strong, “I’m guessing you are Gabriel Agreste then.”

Hawk Moth stills, his attention tugged from Nathalie to Adrien, Adrien stays equally frozen caught in the stare of a predator, “tread carefully boy. Or you won’t be leaving this house.”

He looks the man who either *is* his father or has already done away with him. “Are you threatening to kill me?”

Hawk Moth seems startled into movement, “am I, am I threatening to *kill* you?! Good lord what is *wrong* with you?”

“I don’t know! What am I supposed to think of a supervillain who’s OK with his girlfriend hurting herself to help him?”

“Don’t you *dare.”* The man hisses, *“*Nathalie and the fact she apparently cares for you is the *exactly* what’s staying my hand.”

“Really? It didn’t look like you cared for Nathalie’s opinion down there.”

Hawk Moth reaches out, and strokes Nathalie’s forehead. “I’d had a shock. You wouldn’t know what it’s like to see such a betrayal from someone you trusted.”

“Don’t I?” Adrien can feel his lip curl, his voice goes harsh in an echo of the supervillain in front of him and he's carefully not thinking of the implications of that, “how do you think I felt when I saw her turn into Mayura?”

“Satisfied at how you’d turned my only ally against me I suppose.”

“How self-centred are you? Do you really think I was acting being shocked down there?”

“Nathalie is apparently able to a much higher level of deception than I thought,” Hawk Moth says, “how can I believe anything is true now?”

Adrien reaches out to touch Nathalie’s hand, his hopes falling as she doesn’t responds to it, “this isn’t a pretence.”

“No,” Hawk Moth’s eyes softens around the edges, “it isn’t. Was her recovery do you think?”

“I don’t know. I thought she was getting better.”

“So did I,” the supervillain suddenly looks a little less threatening, “she really lied to you to?”

“Yeah.”

Hawk Moth looks down at the woman in the bed, “Nathalie, Nathalie. What on earth were you up to?”

“I think she was trying to protect me,” Adrien swallows, “which is why I need to protect her,”

“Protect her?”

He stood out as straight as he could. “Give me you Miraculous.”

In other circumstances he’d laugh at the irony.

Hawk Moth’s hand goes to his cane. “And here I thought we were getting on so well.”

Adrien crosses his arms, and tries to stare down the supervillain and possibly his father, “We need to speak to my Kwami. He’ll know about Nathalie’s condition and I am *not* transforming in front of you.”

“And you think *I’m* going to let you discover my identity while letting your preserve your own?”

“It’s a little late for that isn’t it? So. Because either you’re Gabriel Agreste, or you’ve somehow done away with him but,” Adrien glanced down at Nathalie again, and how everything had started to go wrong played over in his head, “I’m pretty sure it’s the former.”

Much as he’d like to believe his father and Nathalie had sent him out of the room because they’d noticed something he hadn’t telling them Hawk Moth was coming he can’t convince himself of that. Because it had been *his father* who’d reacted about Nathalie’s earrings. And Adrien couldn’t see Nathalie appealing to Hawk Moth like she had if he *had* done something to him.

But Nathalie *helping* his father as Mayura. That, though he hated it, made a certain type of sense.

And it would, though he also hated, explain a *lot* about her reaction to Shadow Moth that was his father and she'd *known that.*

Hawk Moth's eyes moved to the Peacock Miraculous lying glinting on Nathalie's bedroom table.

"Don't even think of creating a sentimonster copy of him to confuse me."

"You're cleverer than I thought." Hawk Moth muses, "I always thought Ladybug was the brains of the operation."

"That's ironic," Adrien retorts, "I always thought Mayura was that for you. Not that either of you were exactly distinguishing yourselves getting beaten by teenagers all the time."

Hawk Moth's nostrils flare, then he says, "and yet Nathalie apparently deceived you too."

"Because I trusted her! You're *supposed* to be able to trust the people looking after you, supposed to be able to trust your-"

He covers his mouth with his hand but Hawk Moth is looking at him with wide eyes. Horror scrawled across them.

"Adrien?"

"Nice try. But no."

But Hawk Moth shakes his head, "god to think I thought I could use you to make money off my enemies image."

Dismay at his father being Hawk Moth should have already rendered him numb but, "*That's* your response?!"

It hurts. It hurts a lot actually. That his father doesn't care for the fact he's attacked him, that he could have killed him. That instead he's just annoyed his little joke at Chat Noir's expense actually had him as the butt of it. That both his identities are just money-making schemes for Gabriel Agreste.

"I considered it was you but I dismissed it. I thought I had proof it wasn't you."

"Did you listen to when I said it wasn't me?" Adrien forces himself to say even while hoping that maybe his's misjudged his father, that maybe-

"To think your Miraculous was under my roof all this time."

And no. Apparently Hawk Moth's only distressed he's missed his chance to steal his Miraculous.

"To think I could have got your mother back for us, that we could have all been a happy family again, but instead I've been fighting you for nothing. That when I've been-"

“Wait.” Adrien held out a hand to stop him, “what do you mean about getting m- Adrien’s mother back?”

“She’d hate me if she knew what I’d done, to think all this time I’ve been attacking our son to save her.”

“To save,” it felt like everything started to fall into place, “that’s what you wanted the Wish for? You were going to bring her back?”

“Yes.”

“But. That, that would have meant…” bile burns at the back of his throat, “who were you going to sacrifice? *Me?* Wait. Nathalie? Was *that* why you acted like that with Panthera?”

“No,” his father reaches for him but Adrien can’t help but flinch back, “son it was never meant to you. Never meant to Nathalie. I-, I didn’t know.” Then he repeated more quietly, “I didn’t know.”

“You kind of sound like you know what I’m talking about for someone who didn’t know.”

“Panthera,” he grimaced, “Nathalie told me about it. She told me that she’d found it in her research but now I assume that it was your Kwami at work there, so I don’t even know if I can trust her information.”

“Nathalie wouldn’t lie about that.”

“Nathalie would lie about a lot of things. But no, it’s your Kwami I don’t trust.”

Adrien snorts, “I guess it’s not like it makes a difference either way. You didn’t give up when she told you did you?”

“I was going to,” his father says, “after agreeing to give up the Peacock I’d realised. Well. I was going to give up because it didn’t seem worth it. Going to start a new life with you and Nathalie. Those earrings were supposed to be both a goodbye and a thank you to Panthera for helping me make that choice. Instead….”

“They became what made you turn back into a dick.”

“Adrien Alexander Anselm Augustin Athanase Agreste how *dare* you speak to me like that. If this is what public school does to you then I am pulling you out the *moment* we get confirmation Nathalie is going to alright.”

“How can you lecture me on good behaviour when *you* are a supervillain, and a-“ it suddenly hit Adrien, “a, a cheater!”

“Be careful boy,”

“No! You said that you were doing this for my mother but then you were flirting with Panthera *all the time.* And you were, you know, weird with Nathalie too. You’re a two-timer. Three-timer? I don’t even know. Father how could you!”

“It’s more complicated than that,” but his father still looks away from him in shame, “Panthera…was supposed to be just a ruse to get her Miraculous. But she made me realise that your mother is lost to us.”

“And yet, you’re not willing to give up your Miraculous to save her.”

“I can’t see why I need to. Keeping our identities secret is a moot point at this stage.”

“And you’ve just shown me I can’t trust you not to go after my Miraculous if I drop my transformation first.”

“You, *urgh,*” his father made it almost a growl, “dark wings fall. Happy now Adrien? Now can we *please* talk to your damned kwami.”

Adrien had known Hawk Moth was his father, they’d just had a whole conversation on that basis. And yet it’s still hard to actually see his purple be replaced by cream and red. A nervous looking butterfly kwami hovering over his father’s shoulder.

“Claws in.” Adrien sighs

“Cat Kwami.” His father snaps, “why did wearing the Peacock Miraculous do this to Nathalie?”

“My name. is. Plagg.” The harshness of Plagg’s tone is new to Adrien. All the laziness habitual to his Kwami is gone, “and I’m starting to think it’s worth chancing making France the new Atlantis if it meant I could cataclysm you.”

“Plagg don’t,” Adrien

Plagg’s teeth are bared, “you’re right. I wouldn’t want to catch you and Nathalie in the crossfire. He’s done enough to both of you.”

“I didn’t do *anything* to Nathalie.” His father scowls.

“Why’d she put on that Miraculous then?”

“That’s irrelevant,” his father splutters. “And not what we’re talking about. Can you heal her or not?”

Plagg goes and floats over Nathalie, “sheesh. You should have yanked that thing off her immediately.”

“Trust me I tried,” his father sneers.

Adrien interrupts, “Will she be alright?”

“I can’t heal her kid,” Plagg saggs.

His father’s scowl got deeper, “You lying bastard, telling her that-“

“I *was* helping her.” Plagg interrupts, “I collapsed all the damaged magical channels that were leaching off her life support. Only *someone* apparently made it so she needed to wear Duusu’s Miraculous,”

“Which was fixed.”

“Which opened them all back up again. Any other one she could have used safely. She could have used *mine* but instead-“

“She sent it away,” Adrien thought he was hallucinating at the wetness he saw in the corners of his father’s eyes, “because she worried I’d hurt Adrien. Or win and wipe him out of existence.”

“Exactly,” Plagg bristles. “And now she’s paying for it. Because it’s never you that needs to suffer. Is that what you did to Adrien’s mother too?”

“I never threatened Emilie. How do you-“

“Just judging from the behaviour I’ve seen. It’s not like you held back from attacking her son is it? Or spent any time with her? How much could you love her when you treat the last part of her you have like that?”

“None of it was supposed to matter. I was going to,”

“Remake the world blah blah blah. They all say that. And I’ve liked some of them more than I like you. To think I thought you could love her and give my kid a family.”

“But he does,” a timid voice surprises them all.

Adrien looks past his father and sees his Kwami.

Plagg winces, “Nooroo I know you like to see the best in people but. *Really?*”

The other kwami seemed to puff himself up, “but he *does*. I can feel it. And we can still save Nathalie.”

Plagg shook his head, “I can’t. If I try now I’d risk taking her organs out too.”

“Not you. Tikki. And her wielder. She’s a guardian isn’t she.”

“Eh,” Adrien did feel he hard to point out, “in terms of being responsible for the Miraculous yes, in terms of knowing everything a Guardian should know um. She’s figuring it out?”

“Fantastic,” his father pinches at the bridge of his nose.

“I believe she *could* do it.” Nooroo says.

Plagg looks considering. “He has a point. Sugercube, her powers could point us in the right direction at least.”

Adrien tries not to let the hope in his chest unfurl. His wishes seem to not come true. Or do so in the worst way with a sting in the tail. “Do you really think so?”

“Yeah.”

His father picked up Nathalie’s tablet, looked at something on the screen, and then sighed. “*Would* she though?”

“She’s Ladybug,” Adrien reminds him.

“And we’d be asking her to cure Mayura,” his father replies, “Panthera she might still feel some...responsibility to, goodness know they were hardly friends, but *Mayura? Me?*”

“Have you a better suggestion?”

His father looks him up and down. “We could try using you I suppose.”

“Me?”

“Ladybug has a crush on you.”

Adrien blinks. And then tries to remember if either he or Nathalie had hit his father on the head during the fight.

“She, *what?* No she doesn’t. If she did we’re be dating right now.” This he’s *not* falling for. He might have been oblivious to a lot of things, and he might still think that Ladybug could return his interest in the future because they were best friends, how she’d stayed in contact with him during his injury when he’d worried she might just move on showed that, so maybe she just needed more time but he wasn’t deluded.

Ladybug did not have a crush on him.

“Not on Chat Noir,” his father dismissed, “on Adrien Agreste.”

“How would you even know that?”

“Nathalie told me. Ladybug has a crush on Chat Noir’s alter ego and doesn’t know. So unless you and Félix have been taking turns with that Miraculous she has a thing for you.”

Adrien tries to imagine Ladybug telling Panthera that and draws a blank. “Why were Ladybug and Nathalie talking about that sort of thing?”

“How should I know? Some sort of female conversation I suppose.”

Still weird but, “you think that will be enough?”

His father seemed to think it over then sighed, “No. Perhaps if- no. It will be helpful for the rest of it but…I think we’re going to need something more.”

“Something more?”

His father shuts his eyes. “I left your mother kill herself on my watch.”

Wait *what?*

Adrien could have fallen over in shock. What did that *mean?* What had happened to her?

But his father continues talking, given him no time to assemble a whole picture from the clues he’s been given. “I won’t let it happen again. Nooroo I renounce you.”

“Father?”

He pulls the Miraculous out from under his cravat, and holds it out to Adrien.

“Here. Take this and the Peacock to your lady right now and bring her back to save Nathalie.”

Chapter End Notes

Show I have kept this chapter back a few days as I won't have time to write next weekend? Probably.

Chapter 19: Gabriel VII

Time seems to drag on and on and on. The sun doesn't seem to move across the sky, the shadows cast by Nathalie's windows doesn't seem to move inch by inch across the room.

But Nathalie's struggling breaths, audible now in the silence left by Adrien's absence, announce time's passage nonetheless.

Gabriel wonders how many times her chest will rise and fall before Adrien returns with Ladybug. Whether Adrien *will* return with Ladybug. Whether he'll return with Ladybug alone.

He believes his son *wants* to help Nathalie. He even believes he might feel some measure of guilt for having to be the one to finally pronounce his mother beyond saving. He wants to believe that his son still respects, *cares for*, him.

But this might not be Adrien's choice.

Ladybug's suspicious by nature from what he's seen and what he's heard from Panthera. She also has access to all the other Miraculous and people she apparently trusts to wield them.

Gabriel meanwhile has traded away the only method he has to fight back, has sent his son into the heroine's den while still injured, his only real ally lives dying in front of him and as for the only other person he'd consider trusting with a Miraculous, well, Tomoe's not one to join a losing side.

Something he'd always admired in her really. He'd thought himself cut of quite the same fabric except apparently he *isn't.* He'd been unable to see that once Emilie could only be frozen on the verge of death that she *was* effectively dead. Her heart doesn't beat in that casket. Her soul…Gabriel doesn't know where that is. Doesn't know whether had he won he would have traded back his son or Nathalie for some sort of zombie rather than the real Emilie. An automaton in reanimated flesh. An abomination.

The phantom splinters ache in the back of his thighs. Gabriel is the irreligious son of parents to whom church was more a cultural matter than one of faith but right now the crucifix he'd stared at on those high holy days they'd taken him with them to church seems to blur with the one that had stood above the altar at his and Emilie's ceremonial wedding. Both suffering for humanity where Gabriel has made humanity suffer for him. Both sacrificing where Gabriel has, he wants to say he'd never asked for it and he hadn't at first and maybe never would have done but once she'd made that first choice herself he *had,* asked for sacrifice from Nathalie.

Nathalie herself looks quite on her way to being able to haunt him for his failure and Gabriel hates that the only weapon he was able to arm his son with was the flimsy fact of Ladybug's crush on Adrien Agreste.

Nathalie had seemed to think it ammunition but then *she* had clearly had a well-conceived plan of her own built on the secrets she'd been keeping from them all where Gabriel's been desperately grasping for a solution since the truth of *her* secrets came out.

Funny really how even her betrayal had turned not on morality or anger at him but as it turns out, now he knows the truth of the Wish he would have made and of Chat Noir's identity, from a desperate attempt to save *him* and the family he'd had left.

A devotion he struggles to understand the root of when she'd clearly not trusted him enough to just tell him the truth. Whatever she might have pretended more recently when she'd declared her faith in him as she'd looked into his eyes with her arms around him.

Even now it's difficult to accept that was all false. Panthera and Nathalie were one and the same and that *makes sense* and it shouldn't and it doesn't and it does and Gabriel still can't reconcile his desire and his sense of betrayal and how his heart freezes in terror at the idea he can't save her.

And he can't help question if Plagg had misinformed both her and Adrien. But he has to ignore that question. Has to assume he's made the only choice possible to save the woman he-

The woman he can actually save.

That this is no renunciation of Emilie but merely a recognition of reality. That all he's done for Nathalie now is but returning the favour she'd done him in saving him from killing his own son unwittingly.

A hitch in Nathalie's rhythmic breathing has him startled upright with adrenaline but then she continues on steady as ever. He lets out the air caught in his own throat in response.

Hesitantly as if the atmosphere around them is suddenly viscous he reaches out and takes Nathalie's hand.

The tension in her face seems to ease a little as her fingers weakly close around his.

"It's alright my dear," he belatedly tries to reassure her, "Adrien's gone to get Ladybug and she's going to make you better. I know you and she, and I and her, have had disagreements but Shadow Moth's been defeated. That has to count for something doesn't it?"

It's too much a question in the still empty room.

"It *has* to count for something," he forces himself to declare to correct that. "Besides I don't," he hastily corrects, "*can't* think she'll want to alienate Adrien by *not* helping you. Do you?"

Nathalie remains unconscious, not uttering a word. Her countenance neither shifts nor relaxes any further.

His tongue feels stiff and awkward and *useless* in his mouth.

So he returns to his long silent vigil, hand in Nathalie's, until Adrien returns.

Time must move on because at long last he hears footsteps on the landing. Mutterings that could almost be Adrien and a schoolfriend attempting to sneak past the atelier. Only this is instead is Ladybug and Chat Noir bringing hopefully at least one salvation and perhaps another doom.

The door slowly eases open admitting two teenagers; his son and his arch-enemy.

The girl following Chat Noir into the room looks tense. The white over her torso breaking up her familiar red and streaked through her hair coupled with the dark glasses over her eyes declares her intention to flee should any sign of a threat emerge.

Rather a worrying indictment of her trust in Chat Noir. *Especially* when he's just brought her victory in the form of the two Miraculous that had empowered her opponents.

"Ladybug," he greets, as if manners have any place here, "or should I call you something else dressed like….that."

Her chin juts out in defiance, "Pegabug right now. You'll pardon me if I wanted to be sure of a quick way out in the circumstances M.Agreste. Or should I call you Shadow Moth? I'm a little unsure you see, about whether you're the man I've been fighting, or whether you're just the man Shadow Moth reminded Panthera of. I can see Shadow Moth fleeing when he knows I'm going to be here after all."

Gabriel hates that she's caught his interest, "Shadow Moth reminded Panthera of someone else?" But that's *him,* and why on earth would Nathalie have told Ladybug *that* unless it was someone different entirely but in that case, *"who?"*

"Chat Noir's father," Ladybug is no less bold, "which then," suddenly she seems to take in Nathalie on the bed, "would mean that maybe Panthera isn't Chat Noir's mother, and then *that* means that," her voice goes extraordinarily high-pitched, "Chat Noir is *your* son."

She spins back to Adrien who looks exceedingly sheepish and Gabriel wishes wishes *wishes* he knew what his son had said to get her here.

But still maybe there is a way around this, maybe they can suggest that Shadow Moth destroyed by his guilt in leaving Panthera like this had stepped aside. Had yielded the battle for Panthera's heart to Gabriel and that *he* has of course never been the villain that Ladybug probably wants to throw in prison.

But then Adrien gives an awkward wave, "um hi."

"*Adrien?!* No." Gabriel is rather discomforted to see his some of his own internal reactions to Panthera's and Chat Noir's identities voiced aloud by her, "that's not possible. You. I *know* Adrien. Or I thought I knew Adrien maybe I don't know Adrien? But you're so different. But Chat Noir wanted me to heal Panthera, uh, Miss Nathalie, which if she's Panthera then uh, you *are* Adrien and I just want to disappear right now. And oh my gosh I had that conversation with-" she puts her hands over her mouth.

“Yes Nathalie told us about your feelings for Adrien,” it’s not a helpful interjection, he knows it the moment the words leave his mouth but then if Gabriel’s impulsiveness wasn’t baked into him then they wouldn’t be here right now.

The girl makes a noise disconcertingly like a kettle, while simultaneously going almost as red as her uniform.

But then she tears her hands from her mouth, balls them into fists by her sides, takes a determined breath and says, “Panthera,” then she corrects, “*Nathalie* thought she actually had a chance of a serious relationship with Shadow Moth when he traded the Peacock Miraculous for Mayura’s health. And she *wanted* one. She hoped he might actually be able to give up trying for the Wish. Which he has now. So I guess I’ll be able to work out whether you *are* him or not by whether or not the two of you are together once she’s better.”

Well.

That.

That certainly answers some questions about exactly how much of Nathalie and Panthera’s behaviours and emotions had been false. Not that all of them could be. Nathalie couldn’t have lied to his Miraculous; as Nathalie she was spared because he didn’t look and as Panthera he didn’t understand the implications.

Other questions lie unanswered, and cannot be answered by anyone other than Nathalie. Ladybug and Adrien will of course back her up about the Wish. It’s Nathalie he needs to pin down and know if all of that had been for *him* or for her.

About if the idea of them had only come to her prompted by his own behaviour to Panthera, who he had apparently succeeded rather well in seducing, and then fanned into an idea by his choice to renounce the Wish.

Which he’s now definitively done while she can’t see it and he doesn’t quite know what to make of his feelings.

What to make of this new Nathalie he’s discovered will act independently of his goals, in *defiance* of him, which yes isn’t exactly unprecedented not with Mayura but he’d never expected her to keep secrets from him like this.

“Um, talking about that,” Adrien interrupts, “can you save Nathalie?”

Pegabug doesn’t quite let her eyes leaves him as she looks down at Nathalie putting her hands out to hover above her.

“What happened to her?”

Adrien’s hand goes to the back of his neck, “So you know Nathalie apparently which I am very carefully not thinking about right now.”

“That’s probably a good idea. Right now.” Pegabug nods.

Gabriel is overcome by the very strong desire to pinch at the bridge of his nose. His own mistake perhaps in bringing up the whole entanglement between Ladybug and Adrien and letting her let slip she *knows* Adrien which just makes the fact he never got their Miraculous even more infuriating even if he knows it is technically a good thing.

“And you know now that she’s Panthera.”

“I do. Given you asked me to heal Panthera and brought me to Nathalie.”

“Yeah. Well. So. This is also Mayura?”

“What.” Her answer is flat, and she looks likes she just wants to teleport out of this whole thing and for once Gabriel might have found something in his enemy he can’t even fault her for.

“But then…” She frowns trying to make sense of it.

“It’s why she’s like this,” Gabriel decides to explain, “she told you about how the Peacock Miraculous was broken?”

“Yes. And about how she’d agreed with,” the bug’s eyes narrow, “*you* because it has to be you doesn’t it? Adrien says she lives with you so you’d have noticed if she kept disappearing to be Mayura or Panthera. Except you *didn’t.* Because you were disappearing too. Which is why you never noticed *Adrien* disappearing either.”

“Clever.” Gabriel concedes, “but how do you explain *your* parents never noticing your disappearance? Don’t tell me you were honest with them. Would you have it they were secretly fighting you too?”

“*My* parents don’t try to monitor every second of my life and actually let me leave the house. But for *you* or her not to notice Adrien’s absence that’s inexplicable. Unless you were absent in a more literal sense than your normal too.”

“And what do you mean by that?”

“You’re a terrible father!” Bump her up a few years and she’d pass for a student political leader with all her righteousness, “you might control where Adrien is all the time, and what he can do, which by the way is terrible parenting. He’s 14 not 10 he deserves some freedom. But either way you’re never there when he needs you. Have you ever thought about how Adrien feels at all? About how he might not want to spend all his time being a model for you company? About how he might actually just want a father not an employer?”

Oh he’d be a good target for his own akuma right now. “Do you expect me to let my son, whose mother I have very recently lost, and who is extremely well-known wander around Paris freely like a target for abduction? Do you have any idea what might happen to him? How tempting a ransom might be for some people?”

“And who *made* him famous?” the brat crosses her arms, “Oh yes. *You.* Because you care more about what he can do for you than for him himself.”

“My lady,” Adrien tries to interrupt but she just holds up her hand.

“Chaton, he needs to hear it.”

“But,”

“Adrien,” Gabriel stops him, “it’s fine. I’m quite capable of defending myself. And,” he focuses back on the heroine, “how *dare* you say I don’t love my son. Don’t love my family. Why do you think I’ve been doing all this? Did Panthera tell you *that?* Do you think I don’t know I’m distant? That I don’t know I’m busy? That I don’t know I don’t know that I don’t understand my son and he’s too unlike me for me ever to do so? Did it not cross your tiny little brain that maybe it was for *both* of us that I wanted to save his mother? Or are your family so,” his lip curls, “hands-off that it’s easy for you to imagine a life without yours?”

She gasps, “his mother.”

“What did you think?”

“That’s why…”

He snaps, “why *what?”*

“Why Panthera asked me if I could save someone who’d died from using the Peacock Miraculous. Why she asked if it would be selfish of you to give up, but she didn’t mean you really did she she meant,”

“Herself,” Gabriel says quietly, and he’s still not sure what to do with that, “but perhaps she meant me too.”

He’d wanted her after all. Wanted Panthera and then wanted Nathalie when letting go of Emilie had become a possibility.

“It wouldn’t be selfish. You know. To give up.” Ladybug says with a horrible kindness in her voice, “I can’t imagine what it was like to lose your wife, or what it was like for Adrien to lose his mother but no one would expect you to do what you’d done to try to save her. No one *could* expect you to do that.”

“Emilie would have.”

Adrien looked startled at the mention of his mother, and oh god that’s another conversation that Gabriel really doesn’t want to have that now seems inevitable.

“But that’s. *That’s* sort of selfish I mean,” a sudden wince heralds the realisation this is her partner’s mother she’s talking about, and then she’s blushing again, “I’m not calling her selfish, I guess she didn’t know about the cost and-“

“Enough,” Gabriel puts a long-overdue halt to this embarrassment. “You don’t need to convince me to give up. I’ve already done so. Now can you actually do something for Nathalie, or have I just summoned you here to embarrass yourself and my son?”

Pegabug looks down at Nathalie again, “she said she had to way to help Mayura. But if she was Mayura then….”

“Apparently Plagg *did* have a way of helping her. The Peacock Miraculous had left broken magical pathways was how he explained it and he was destroying those. So she would have been fine even if he couldn’t make her like she used to be. Only then she wore the Peacock again and. Now she’s like this.” Adrien finishes in a hurry.

“Right,” she frowns again but it does seem to be in thought rather than in anger. “Why’d she put it on then?”

“I’m not sure her Kwami had mentioned the danger,” Gabriel answers before Adrien can.

But his son glares up at him, “because father frightened her. She thought she had to. To protect me.”

Gabriel takes a deep breath, and corrects his son. “To protect *us.* She didn’t want me to do something I’d later regret.”

“Huh.” Pegabug says.

Irritated he looks away from Adrien and at her. “What?”

“I couldn’t reconcile her being Mayura and her not telling you when she got the ring. Even if she discovered the cost of the Wish. To me and Chat Noir the two of you always seemed so, you know, close. And that seemed even stranger once I worked out who you really were. I mean why would she do all *this* for you when you’re not even a couple and then lie about Chat Noir. Because she’d have to believe in you to support you right? But I guess you’ve just given me my answer.”

“Talk clearly for once.”

“She might have loved you but she clearly didn’t trust you.”

Rage held in abeyance by Nathalie’s collapse earlier makes a sudden resurgence up his gullet, burning behind his heart, “Get-“

In the absence of his cane his hands find each other behind his back, nails digging into his palm while he forces himself to calm down, to remember he *needs* this blasted bug for Nathalie’s sake. Because maybe it’s all a mess and maybe he despises Ladybug and is furious with Adrien and even moreso with Nathalie but he needs her *alive* to have that conversation with her.

Even if he’s not sure what it is.

“Get to healing her,” he finishes gruffly and from the looks the teenagers are sending him he hasn’t fooled anyone.

“Then you get out.” The girl says.

Adrien looks between them uncertainly, “my lady?”

“I need to talk to Plagg and Tikki and I’m not doing that with you here.”

“Couldn’t you,” Adrien makes a strange movement with his hands, apparently some sort of code between the heroes.

Or perhaps not with the furrow between her eyes it gets in answer, “couldn’t I?”

“How did you two always defeat me.” He wonders aloud.

“Maybe you should think about what that says about you,” Pegabug says, “and yes Adrien I could just ask Tikki to stop transforming me and leave Kaalki protecting my identity. Which I’m going to have to do given,”

“You don’t trust me either. Even if you like me.” Adrien echoes her words back to her and making Gabriel prouder of him than he was the last time he aced his piano exam.

“It’s not that. It’s your father. And your,” she paused looking unsure, “Nathalie. It’s not fair of me to expect you to lie to them.”

“Sure.” Adrien mutters.

It’s somewhat annoying to have confirmation of the fractures between the heroes now when he can’t use it, and when it actually would be in his favour to have everything as smooth as possible.

Gabriel sighs internally. He *needs* this all over with. “Adrien?”

“Yes father.”

“Make sure she helps Nathalie.” He takes a step forward, “I do know what it is to need privacy while pulling off a masterpiece after all.

Chapter 20: Nathalie VII

Red surrounds her, a deep featureless crimson in all directions. Though the longer she looks the more that isn't quite true. Darker lines criss-cross her horizon, black spots hover in front of her, and even hints of blue rim flash off.

Sunlight shining through closed eyelids her mind belatedly provides.

She's not dying then.

She thinks anyway.

With awareness comes a bone-deep weary ache. Shouldn't she lose that if she was slipping away from life?

Perhaps not. People *do* sometimes die in pain don't they?

Gabriel surely wouldn't deprive her of painkillers to ease her passing though. She'd haunt him to distraction if he did. But no, despite how she can feel her heart beat hard against her ribs at the memory of Gabriel's anger he'd been frightened too at the end.

That she can remember.

Him begging her to come back.

It almost feels like she's hearing him right now.

Maybe she *is* hearing him right now?

The words seem slightly different from before. There's no Miraculous on her breast to broadcast his emotions to her but still this doesn't sound like the panic before though her ears are being sluggish and she can't make sense of the words.

But hmm, that's different, he sounds *different,* like he's asking her maybe, instead of commanding her. Different.

Maybe Nathalie could like different?

If she wakes up that is.

There's a rough warmness brushing across her, across her, her hands? She thinks that's her hands being touched. She tries to make out where that sensation move lies but she doesn't think she succeeds. If she does then she can't feel *that* but neither can she feel any response so she'll guess not.

Instead Nathalie tries to attempt opening her eyes but the damned things feel welded shut.

It would be so much easier to let go. To just sleep.

But there's Gabriel. And Adrien. And she *doesn't know what's happening.*

She can't stop everything going wrong won't have a chance to clear everything up unless she can just wake up.

Only even as more sensations begin to return, that ache getting worse, and actual shots of sharp *pain* in her chest she still can't more.

The voices change sometimes. Once she even thinks she recognises *Ladybug* and if Ladybug is in the house then things have all gone so wrong and she's stuck here unable to fix things.

She feels a little more relaxed when after that she feels that weight on her hands, and those flutters against her forehead, that she's tentatively named Gabriel even though he speaks little these days.

But then it's at *Adrien's* voice that her sticky crusted eyelids finally manage to open.

"Nathalie?" her boy beams like sunlight, "Nathalie stay awake," his head turns towards the door shielding her from the force of her yell, "FATHER," then he's back looking at her, "stay with me. It's going to be alright."

But she eyes are just so heavy and with all the willpower in the world she can't.

Gabriel's there the next time she wakes. Her mouth is dry when she tries to speak, and nothing comes out but she manages to squeeze her hand around his, and he looks at her like she's a miracle.

And then it becomes more and more often; her body responds to her, she's awake for longer, she manages to sit up, to ask *what happened* and listen while Adrien gives her a clearly edited take.

She holds him against her chest when one day he breaks down in tears and babbles about losing her too, and why did she do it, and she should have told him.

Her state is a convenient excuse for why she just holds him and doesn't explain anything more than just the necessary reassurances. Her throat is sandpaper, and she just doesn't have the energy but really it's cowardice.

Nurses come, paid for their discretion, and help her get out of bed and clean herself.

One day a physio even comes but Nathalie can feel the power thrumming through her veins, however she's been healed it's no feat of modern medicine or natural recovery of the body. Her limbs are sluggish from lack of use but she can feel the strength recovering in them.

Nathalie hasn't seen Gabriel since she's been able enough to follow, if not hold, a conversation.

She sits in front of her unlit fire, hair damp and dressed an oversized hoodie and leggings she hasn't worn for years. It's fitting really. She feels younger like all her defences have been taken away from her; she's too weak to use her martial training, underdressed without the

formality of her work suits, and her veneer of unbothered competence has been stripped away entirely when her body failed her.

The chess board sits on the table by her. Pieces still lying in place from a game she and Gabriel had started and never finished.

Maybe it's a sign.

"Nathalie," Adrien calls as she opens the door, and that's one of the downsides to being an invalid. People forget you might want privacy, or make up reasons it's unimportant.

Perhaps Adrien is his father's son after all. Gabriel had certainly never had any issues ignoring boundaries and taking what he wanted.

She reproaches herself the moment she has the thought. Out of the two Agrestes she's betrayed only Adrien has come to her each day to help her through her recovery. The difference between father and son is stark.

"Good morning Adrien," she forces the irritation out of her voice only to end up with a monotone more suited to an executive assistant ready to put up with a bunch of aggravation on her boss' behalf.

"Afternoon actually," she hates that she can see the pretence in the lightness of his answer; that's she hurt him again, "I brought lunch up. I thought we could eat together."

"Oh," she shifts her chair a little to make room, "that was nice of you."

An uneasy silence reigns as he lifts the lids to reveal their plates and sets things out on the trolley.

"How's school going?" Nathalie asks eventually in an awkward attempt to break the silence.

"Oh you know," it's a sharp turnaround from the boy who'd been so delighted to go to school, "it's going."

She leans forward, she's not quite sure what her place is in relation to Adrien now, what he's willing to grant her, never mind that it's probably definitely not her job anymore but she can't help but worry.

"Is something wrong? Do I need to talk to your teacher? Or the administration?"

He holds up his hands to stop her, "no, no, no, it's nothing like that. I like school," but his flat voice doesn't support his words, "so please don't tell Father any of this."

"That's not a problem," for her to tell Gabriel she'd have to *see* Gabriel.

A shadow crosses Adrien's face, "Nathalie. Father, he,"

"No." She stops him firmly, "we're talking about whatever your problem with school is."

“But,”

“We can talk about him after.”

“I have to go back to school after.”

“So we’ll talk about it after school.”

His lips set mulishly but he huffs, “fine.”

Nathalie waits patiently. It’s easier when there’s something to wait for.

“I hate lying to my friends.”

She tilts her head.

“I know I had to keep Chat Noir a secret too but…that was different. That felt like a nice secret, like I had this other life where I could be me and,”

“You don’t think Chat Noir is you surely.”

His mouth opens with an apologetic tilt forward of his head and Nathalie expects some mixed spiel of justification and apology to come, but then he suddenly squares his shoulders and looks for a second remarkably like a younger version of his father.

Give him glasses and the illusion would be surprisingly perfect.

But then a viridian flame in his eyes makes it quite clear this is Emilie’s son.

“Chat Noir is when I get to be free. To not have to be Father’s perfect son, or the obedient brand ambassador, or Paris’ favourite poor little rich boy.”

“Adrien,”

“They, Ladybug, everyone, they look at Chat Noir without preconceptions and he can do whatever he wants.”

“I’d hardly say that,” she means it to come out more sympathetic than it comes out. “Chat Noir is expected by Paris to be the hero, to be Ladybug’s support. Do you think you’d be allowed to break out of that structure? That you’d be allowed to do anything with that ring? Ladybug even objected to you giving it to me.”

“But…but you two kept on working as a team. And I mean, I did give it to Mayura so,”

“So you managed to stop Hawk Moth.” Nathalie says firmly. If Ladybug wants to blame Chat Noir for giving his Miraculous to a villain she’d better remember that too.

Adrien goes still.

“Your father gave up the Miraculous didn’t he?”

“I’m not supposed to be stressing you out?”

“There’s no other way I’m sitting here healed by magic and he’s not in prison. And besides he’d pretty much agreed to do so anyway.”

“He…had?”

Nathalie can’t help her frown. “Do you and Ladybug not talk? But yes, he had. Do you really think I’d let him go and make that Wish knowing what the cost was?”

“You helped him before.”

Oh this conversation has gone driving off in a direction Nathalie neither wants nor is ready for, “I didn’t what the price of winning would be, I didn’t know I was fighting *you*. Adrien the moment I found out that changed everything. I know that I’ve often been the tool your father has used to control your life, and I recognise that you haven’t always been happy about that and that I’ve done things I regret. But I have never *ever* wanted to hurt you. I promise you that.”

“I know, you always looked like you felt bad about it.”

Somehow that doesn’t feel like enough, she reaches up over the table to take his hands, “I know I only work for your father, and that I’ve deceived you so many times, but to me you’ve become more than that. You’re the closest thing to family I have.”

“Nathalie,” his voice breaks, “you have to know you’re family to me right?”

“I hoped so,” she smiles but she can feel a treacherous trickle at the corner of her eyes.

Adrien knocks the air out of her as he traps her into her hug at a run.

“It’s alright,” she tries to sooth him as she rubs his back, “I’m alright and we…we have time to work this out. It’s all going to be fine Adrien and we’re all here, and even when I’m not you’ll know that I love you OK? If something’s wrong you just ring me.”

She’s telling herself this as much as she’s telling Adrien.

“Why would you not be here?”

Nathalie blames the time unconscious for how she’s lost hold of everything, “well, who knows what the future might bring,” she says airily, and then adds hopefully more convincingly, “but anyway I won’t be there at school. Or when you’re Chat Noir.”

“I don’t have a reason to be Chat Noir anymore.”

“Hmm. Don’t you and Ladybug have things to talk about? I doubt she wants to be photographed with Adrien Agreste much as that might delight your father.”

“I’m not sure Father would like that.”

“Oh he’d be horrified. But also unable to resist the PR opportunity. And then horrified again that his brand would owe something to his enemy. It would be great fun to watch.”

Adrien’s nose wrinkles as he looks up at her, “is that something Panthera would say?”

“Probably not. Panthera was trying to get your father to listen to her because Panthera was *me.*”

“But don’t you see Panthera and Shadow Moth they could do things you and Father couldn’t let yourselves. Even if you *were* constrained as an apparent hero and villain. That’s what being Chat Noir is like for me!”

“Panthera could say things I couldn’t but that was…that was very much in reference to your Father and what I could get away with. I never had any real different personality- that would have felt like far more effort than I had the energy to do.”

Adrien lets go of her and mounts a very unimpressed face, “right so you want me to believe all that, he starts to flutter his eyelashes and his voice goes to a higher pitch ‘oh Shadow Moth I should stay away from you but I’m just so drawn to you’ was *you?*”

“Firstly I didn’t sound like that. And secondly given that we’ve just established you’re the closest thing I have to son I am not going to discuss my romantic life with you.”

“Don’t you have to if it’s with my Father? Given that would kind of involve me.”

She looks at his Cheshire ca-

Huh.

“Now that face is Chat Noir behaviour,” she sighs, “you and your father. You’re not like me. I was…pragmatic as Panthera. My goals were to get what I needed done. The two of you are different you *do* take your alter egos as a chance to do things you can’t as Gabriel and Adrien Agreste. Maybe even things you didn’t even realise you *wanted* as yourselves. But though your way of doing things might have been healthier than your father’s and maybe it’s something you needed I don’t think Chat Noir is any more your true self than Shadow Moth is your father’s.”

Downcast he does an uncharacteristic pout, “I don’t want to believe Shadow Moth is what my father truly is but…”

“Tell me, does Chat Noir have time to be sad?”

“He’s there to fight help Ladybug fight, there’s not really, we can’t talk about personal stuff.”

“Hmm. And you’d go up to, I don’t know, Kagami and flirt the way Chat Noir does?”

Adrien’s nose wrinkles, “I don’t think Kagami would like that.”

“Alright,” Nathalie casts her mind around Adrien’s various other friends and classmates looking for one hopefully Ladybug-esque and receptive, “what about Marinette?”

“Marinette’s just a friend.” His answer is a little too hurried.

Which. Interesting but not what Nathalie is actually going for right now.

“So?” She says instead of prodding. “Chat Noir turned his joking-so-it’s-not-threatening flirting on some of the temporary heroines.”

“That was just being charming,”

Oh Adrien *definitely* is Gabriel’s son. How did she never see this before. “Right.”

“It wasn’t flirting.”

“Mmmhmm.”

“It didn’t mean anything,” Adrien throws his hands in the air, “it was just a kiss on the hand. Father does that to Chloé’s mother and that doesn’t mean he likes her.”

“No he doesn’t. But I wouldn’t describe it as not flirting. Your father does that to appease Audrey because she likes to feel men are interested in her, and it’s a sop to her pride when he decides to remind her of favours she owes him rather than vice versa. It’s complicated.”

“Ew.” Adrien’s gone somewhat pale, “Why would you tell me that?”

Because at least it’s not about *her.* Which. Very much not dealing with that right now. “You brought it up.”

“Not like that.”

“We’re getting off topic. My point is, *yes,* you have more freedom as Chat Noir but he’s a persona you’ve created as much as the one you present to the media.”

“Father created that one.”

She shrugs, she won’t argue that.

“And maman.” He admits of his own accord, looking away.

She reaches out and ruffles his hair. “And you can remake it once you’re 18.”

“I don’t think Father would like that.” Adrien says as he tries to force his hair back into submission.

“I’d like to think I’d tutored you well enough you could get into a good university, and then a good job. Plus with your inheritance from your mother and your earnings as a model you’d hardly be without resources.”

He frowns, and part of Nathalie melts at his confusion. Oh way can’t she just hold him safe here forever instead of dealing with all this difficulty?

“Are you trying to tell me I should break away from my father the moment I’m 18?”

“No. I hope very much that you and your father can work things out. He does love you you know, you’re why he gave up.”

“Uh,” now his forehead wrinkles even more, “he gave up for *you.*”

“He only did that because he’d already given up on the Wish. Because he couldn’t risk it taking you. If he’d still been planning to fight for it then he might have given you one, he’d already done that for me once. But he wouldn’t have given up both, given up his chance.”

“Nathale he loves you.”

She pushes her hair back into an non-existent ponytail, “your father did,” god she can’t say it, “care for me. But that was before he discovered I betrayed him.”

“You betrayed *me* too and I don’t suddenly hate you.”

Nathalie studies Adrien but she can’t make him out, “are you angry with me?”

“Not really. I think it all sort of drained out while we were waiting for you to wake up,” he shrugs, “and you know I am angry at Father and that’s…easier. Plus I’ve been talking to Plagg a lot and I mean, you did try and protect me the whole time and pretty much from when I gave you the ring you did do the *right* thing. Just not the honest one.”

“I’m sorry.” She offers. “I was trying to protect you but I should have been honest with you. And,” she sighs, but it has to be said, “I know we spoke a bit about this before you knew the whole of it but, I’m sorry that I thought your father was right. Not entirely. I always wished I could get him to spend more time with you, let you have some more freedom but I honestly did think that saving your mother was the best thing for both of you.”

“You should be sorry.” Adrien retorts but then he softens, “but it’s easier to believe that you honestly believed it than Father.”

“Adrien,” Nathalie tries.

He ignores her intervention. “When you think it it’s not selfish. Father…it was what he wanted so of *course* he thought it was the best thing.”

“It was hard for him, watching your mother die.” It had been hard for Nathalie and she hadn’t even been particularly close to Emilie. If she hadn’t seen the fading of such a vibrant woman in front of her eyes, and the effect it had had on Gabriel and Adrien then Nathalie would never have let guilt coax her into continuing to try to help the Agrestes find the solution after it was, as she knows now, too late.

“I was hard for me too.” Adrien mumbles, and she winces as she sees him picking at his fingers.

Then he looks up. “Nathalie?”

“Hmm?”

“How did you justify it? I know you wanted to help my family but how could you think what you did to the rest of Paris was OK?”

She shuts her eyes and lies back, “oh I had lots of justifications. They just all seemed to fall away when I discovered I was fighting you. It wasn’t supposed to go on this long; we never meant for a reign of terror just to swipe those Miraculous, so you know really it was Ladybug and Chat Noir’s fault-“

Adrien’s looks unconvinced, “Uh,”

She holds up her hand, telling him to let her continue, “and Ladybug fixed anything so there was no damage done, and it’s not like either of us met people to be forced with the truth there of what we were doing. And I mean there was nothing stopping anyone from fighting back if they wanted to protect their families the way we did ours. And the big one of course: we could make it so none of this ever happened with the Wish.”

Adrien’s eyes narrow. “Mayura really is part of you isn’t she?”

“Just as Chat Noir is part of you. Adrien there’s nothing stopping you being a little bit more like him with your friends. If he truly *was* you why don’t you revert to being like him with them in private?”

“Because…because I don’t know if they’d like him.” He’s fiddling with his hands again.

She forces herself not to stop him. It probably won’t help. “I don’t think that’s it. But maybe you could try?”

“Try to be a little more Chat Noir with my friends? Is that even possible?”

Nathalie wants nothing more than to bring up how different Emilie had been able to be in different environments, with different people but she’s not sure Emilie’s son is ready for that yet.

“Only you can say that. But. I know your parents have put you in the public eye and that makes it harder but everyone has to bend themselves in little ways to not annoy people and be someone they like to be around. Unless of course you become the personal assistant of a reclusive billionaire who pays you to be a dick to people on his behalf.” Sometimes Nathalie loves her job.

“Yeah I am getting how you were a supervillain more now. But I don’t want to offend people.”

“See, that’s you. That’s not just what I’ve taught you or what your father demanded from you or what your mother modelled for you. You’re a good boy Adrien. And maybe you’re just a good boy who happens to have a terrible sense of humour.”

Adrien’s jaw drops and *now* he looks betrayed.

“I’ve had to deal with your Father’s. Trust me. I can say that.”

“Father has, *wait,* do you think Ladybug doesn’t really mind either?”

“I think maybe that’s something you need to talk to Ladybug about that. And maybe you should talk to her,” and she does not want to say this but urgh the girl has healed her and she has a decent head on her shoulders and Adrien needs someone more than her, “about other things too? We’ve given you a lot to deal with. You don’t have to bear it alone.”

“Father would said I need to. For this family’s sake.”

“Your father hasn’t gone through anything alone since at least when he married your mother,” she catches the clock by her bed out of the corner of her eye, “and you need to get back to school.”

Adrien moves slowly, “Can we talk more? Later?”

“Yeah, sure.” Nathalie promises tiredly as if that could be enough to fix it all.

She watches Adrien leave the room only for Plagg to fly back moments later.

“You’re going to need to tell our kid what you’re doing now."

Nathalie stiffens, “I’ll tell him when it’s time.”

Chapter 21: Adrien III

Chapter Summary

> I'm not happy with this chapter but in the interests of you guys not waiting another week have it :)

"You're *leaving?!*"

Whatever composure his parents have built into him, whatever deference his father has demanded from him, whatever obedience Nathalie has asked for with a mixture of command and apology all crumble in the face of her awkward explanation.

"Adrien," she sags back down onto the bed like someone who very much *should not be leaving the people who can help her when she's ill.*

"No, don't try that Nathalie. This is stupid! You can't *leave.* Why would you even think that's a good idea?"

"Because it's necessary."

He can't help but cross his arms, "and *how* exactly is it necessary? Explain that to me."

She stiffens, "don't try to channel your father to me Adrien, it's not going to work."

"I'm not trying to," he stumbles over his words, he doesn't want to be his father, doesn't want to force what he wants on the world, "be like him I just…do I have to lose you after,"

Oh and that choking hard rock in his throat is a surprise.

He'd thought that he'd accepted that his mother was gone a long time ago, but that was before he'd discovered his father had been fighting to bring her all back and Adrien had been the one stopping him.

And the stupid thing is that it hasn't even made him want her back more. He loves his mother but he doesn't want to die for her. Doesn't want *Nathalie* to die for her. Doesn't even want his father to die for her which doesn't really make sense when she was always with him, and he never was.

Adrien knows it's a good thing he stopped his father winning and he *wants* to have stopped his father winning, and he's glad he won but it still…hurts.

Hurts to imagine her trapped underground in glass when his maman had been so full of energy and had chafed at the cage his father's fame had created for them.

And yet, a horrible little part of him whispers, she'd strengthened those bars for him hadn't she? Had encouraged his modelling career. Had been happy to be his main tutor while Nathalie had relinquished power and risked her positon by lending her voice to the cause of him going to school.

But that didn't mean she didn't love him, that had never been in any doubt, and maybe he'd played a little at pretending what Paris believed was true, that Panthera *was* Chat Noir's mother and had wished Nathalie would show that love to him to but…

He'd never wanted to *replace* her.

Never wanted her dead.

Never wanted to lose her.

He'd accepted it, but that's quite a different matter and everything recently; discovering the truth, nearly losing Nathalie too, has scraped open what he'd thought was a healed wound.

And now that he apparently *is* losing Nathalie it feels like something's digging into it.

"You are *not* losing me," Nathalie reaches out and puts her hand on his shoulder, "I'll be right there at the other end of the phone. And…this isn't going to be something permanent Adrien. We'll work something out. Maybe I can go back to being your chaperone for shoots."

"You know that's not the same."

"I don't want to hurt you Adrien. But I can't stay here. You must understand that." Her voice is kind but that isn't enough.

He knows he sounds like a prick when he huffs, "I don't actually."

She exhales, "you know I did what I thought was best."

"I know." He admits. That much he doesn't doubt. Not at all really.

"And I don't regret it. I'd do it again in a heartbeat."

"I kind of know that too."

"But I lied to you and your father to do so."

"There seem to have been a *lot* of lies in this household."

"That's true but," she repeats that odd tic he'd never seen before which she'd seemed to have picked up recently of pulling her hair back. "Look. How would you feel if Ladybug had kept that sort of secret from you?"

"Angry," he admits honestly, "maybe…not surprised exactly but…angry."

Nathalie frowns, “what do you mean you wouldn’t be surprised? I know Ladybug takes on a leadership role between the two of you, and she.” She shuts her mouth deliberately, “I mean I’m very thankful to her for healing me. I know she didn’t have to.”

“She’s not the sort of person who could stand by knowing she could help,” Adrien explains, “and she does feel grateful to you you know, she knows Father wouldn’t have given up if not for you and that.” He doesn’t like thinking about it but, “you did have my Miraculous and you could have stolen hers after you got close to her. Ladybug knows she’s lucky you didn’t.”

Plagg looked up from the wheel of cheese he’d been taking slices from, which Nathalie had apparently left out in anticipation in an attempt to distract the Kwami, “and I might have talked to Tikki. Given what you did for Adrien and all.”

Nathalie’s smile is tight, “I appreciate it.”

Things had been off between her and Plagg since…since she’d almost woken up really. Adrien guesses it’s to do with these plans of hers to leave but he wonders too if Plagg resents how she’d chosen to deal with his father finding out.

He’d have approved of getting Adrien out of it, and getting his Miraculous away, but it must be hard to transform someone and then have them throw themselves into danger without you.

Adrien wonders how many Chat Noirs or Pantheras or whichever names they used had done that to Plagg.

Whatever the reason it’s automatic to try to dispel the tension saying, “anyway you know Ladybug’s’s sympathetic to you, both of you, about why you were doing it,” maybe more than *he* is upside down as that seems but, “she’s a good person you know.”

“Umhmm,” infuriatingly Nathalie doesn’t volunteer anything more.

He can tell she’s waiting for him to continue giving him the silence to fill and yet it still works.

Adrien blurts. “She *is.* She just. She doesn’t trust me. And she’s right isn’t she? I *have* missed attacks and *my father was Hawk Moth,* and so how *could* she tell me her identity?”

“He’s not lying when he says he decided not to make the Wish.” Nathalie says. “You father… he’s toyed with giving up before but those times were different. He’s different. You don’t have to worry about him trying to steal the earrings of any girlfriend you bring home.”

“How? How was it different.”

“He thought he couldn’t win. Or that he couldn’t do what he needed to *to* win, couldn’t take the necessary risks,” she’s not meeting his eyes as she says it.

“He seemed pretty okay with risking me.” Adrien couldn’t help but point out and *that* that had been one of the hardest things to deal with. He’d known his father couldn’t, didn’t, seem to care about how he felt but he had thought he at least cared about his physical status. As a brand asset if nothing else.

“He’d vacillate.” Nathalie’s mouth pulls downwards at the corner.

“I don’t feel like fathers *should* vacillate about whether or not to endanger their sons.”

“No.” She sighs, “it was all supposed to be alright after but…”

Adrien let her trail off but he had to know, “Do you regret not doing something sooner?”

“All the time. Especially with how it turned out. You know he used to go back and forth about risking me too.”

That didn’t sound right, but then there was Mayura, but then, “he loves you though.”

“And he loves you.”

“I guess.” *Don’t leave me with him please.* They’d spoken more while Nathalie had been out of it and Adrien had been experiencing the weirdly dizzying effect of being treated like a peer by his father for once, having been his enemy apparently granting him a respect he didn’t get as his son, but since then his father had been going back to his old hiding trick.

He couldn’t live in this mansion alone.

“And he’s no interest in continuing,” Nathalie firmly declares, “he knows now that winning won’t get him what he wanted. So he won’t attempt that, you don’t have to worry about him trying to steal the earrings off any girlfriend you bring home.”

Adrien fought the urge to blush, “*Nathalie.*”

That was a totally unfair thing for her to say when he knew Ladybug wasn’t going to date him anytime soon.

“I can tell her that if you want.”

“Do that and I’ll tell Father that…that,” but he found himself rather short of equivalent ammunition. Telling his father about the conversations he and Nathalie had had before the reveal didn’t really feel equal.

“You father already knows everything I’d rather he didn’t,” Nathalie’s lips are pursed, “there’s nothing you can tell him to change anything.”

“I’m sorry for telling him you had a crush on Shadow Noir.”

“That’s alright Adrien. I’m the one who fastened the noose around my neck there.”

“You can’t really be leaving just because you’re embarrassed though?”

“It’s not that simple. I’m supposed to work with your father all day that’s, look it’s just not going to work anymore.”

“That doesn’t mean you have to leave. He wouldn’t want you to do that.”

“Oh he does. You know your father, he doesn’t like complicated. And I’m *very* complicated right now.” She reaches out and ruffles his hair, “I am sorry Adrien. If I thought I could bear it I would stay for you. But I can’t keep dealing with this, I’ll go mad.”

Adrien tries to get his hair to fall back into place. He appreciated the affection but his father hatted to see it in a mess.

“You get used to it. Him avoiding you.” The words sound weak even as he says them.

She shakes her head, “I really have failed you haven’t I?”

“He’ll get over it. I mean he traded with Ladybug for you.”

“That’s the problem.” Nathalie exhales, “I betrayed him, for his own good and he knows that but that probably makes things worse, and in doing so I forced him to give up his Miraculous to save my life.”

“You said he’d given up on the Wish. And that he’d given up the Peacock.” The little bit of suspsicion he couldn’t stifle raised it’s head.

“He had. But so long as he had the Butterfly he still had the chance that maybe he could find another way. Or maybe he wouldn’t and he’d put it aside when he was happy with the life he had. And I took both those choices from him. And your father isn’t a forgiving man.”

Adrien frowns, “that’s stupid.”

“I’ve been telling her that kid but she’s not listening.” Plagg interjects, “and neither has your idiot of a father.”

“I told you not to talk to Gabriel,” Nathalie said sharply.

“Oh you can’t imagine how much I’ve been waiting to say to that man.”

Suddenly she pinches at the bridge of her nose, “It doesn’t matter. I’m leaving and that’s it.”

“Where are you going to go? Have you even got another job?”

“I’ve savings enough to support me until I work that out.”

“You shouldn’t have to.”

“You know life isn’t fair Adrien. I could have put a stop to this much earlier. Should have stopped your father from,” her words come to a sudden halt, “let’s just say I’d do things differently.”

“Is this about what happened between Shadow Moth and Panthera? Is that actually why you’re leaving?”

Nathalie’s pallor gains something of a flush. “I’m not going to talk about that with you Adrien. Hell, I don’t even know why I’m telling you even half of this.”

“It’s nice getting the truth from one of you for once actually.”

“I guess it is.” She sounds chagrined, “I did tell him to tell you, you know.”

“Tell me, *wait,* you wanted Father to tell me he was Hawk Moth?”

“I didn’t realise you’d be so opposed to it.”

“*How?”* He yelps, sometimes for all the connection he feels with Nathalie he doesn’t get her at all.

“Your mother,” she says simply, “and I didn’t know you were Chat Noir. I thought it would help you to know what he wasn’t just ignoring you for work. That he was fighting to get your family back.”

“My family is right here. And it seems like ignoring people is his default when anything actually emotional is involved.”

Weirdly Nathalie’s face goes all fond, and the hint of a smile plays over her lips, “he needs time to work through things. He’s never been good with sudden shocks. But. He will get through it. Eventually. And Plagg will make sure he doesn’t forget you while he does.”

“I thought you didn’t want Plagg to talk to Father.”

Nathalie shrugs, “not where I don’t think it’ll be useful.”

Adrien looked up at her as if a silent plea would move her when his words couldn’t but whatever she saw in her eyes Nathalie remained stubborn and implacable.

“I’m going to miss you,” he gave it a last ditch attempt.

“I’m going to miss you too,” her hand reaches out for him, pauses, but then she pulls him into a hug.

Adrien lets her hold him a long time.

“I can’t believe you’re just letting her leave.” Adrien almost spits the words at his father, as they watch Nathalie get into a taxi, his bodyguard carrying her cases.

“You’re still my son Adrien,” his father doesn’t look away from the window, “be careful how you speak to me.”

“I’m the reason you’re not in prison right now. Or are you deluded enough to think Ladybug wouldn’t have exposed you if not for me and Nathalie.”

It's something he doesn't like to think about. Yet another reason for Ladybug to be uncomfortable around him. It's much easier to focus on the other reasons she has, the one he'd told Nathalie.

He wants Ladybug to like him and to care about his opinion but on this one particular thing?

Yeah he'd prefer it more to be about Nathalie and forgiveness than because of anything she does or doesn't think of him. He doesn't want this to be a reason for her to resent her down the line.

But when it comes to fighting Shadow Moth you have to fight dirty and do things you're not quite comfortable with, and this is as vital a fight as any Chat Noir's ever thought.

"I have lawyers. And contingency plans," his father scoffs.

"Sure." Adrien agrees, "I'm sure that even if you managed to avoid prison the brand would get through this just fine. That Nathalie wouldn't get harassed on the street every time you sent her out in your place. That my aunt would let you keep custody of me. Or my mother."

That gains a stiffening and a slow turn of his head towards Adrien.

"Adrien," there's an obvious warning in his growl.

"Are you going to bury her? Properly? Somewhere I can visit? Or are you planning to make me lose *every* woman who's helped raise me?"

He hadn't meant to bring this up now, but in the moment it feels like the most natural thing possible.

"No one is stopping you visiting your mother," his father snaps, "and despite whatever idea you have in your head I don't plan to stop you seeing Nathalie either."

"No. You're just pushing Nathalie away, and leaving my mother somewhere I can't go without being reminded that you were a supervillain who almost killed me multiple times, and that's after I have to walk through the Atelier while you glare at me for being there."

"Adrien," and the change from anger to, what, uncertainty maybe, is stark in his voice, "I never. I didn't know it bothered you so much. And I never meant to hurt you."

"Yeah Nathalie said. But you didn't exactly try and keep me safe did you. Adrien I mean, not Chat Noir."

His father shut his eyes, "I should never has let any of that happen to you. I let myself get blinded by the power of the Wish, by the promise of none of this having happened."

"Yeah, Nathalie said that too."

"You too seem to have been speaking a lot." There's annoyance there yes, but also consideration in his eyes, like he's assessing Adrien.

“Someone has to.”

His father looks away from him again, “I’ll have a more suitable resting place found for your mother.”

“Thank you.” He’s not sure he feels better. Not sure he will until he’s by her grave for real. But it’s *something.* “And Nathalie?”

“What about Nathalie?”

“Are you seriously going to let her think you want her to leave?”

The tightening in his father’s hands would have been imperceptible behind his back, but stood at his side as Adrien was he could see it all. “My and Nathalie’s relationship isn’t any of your business.”

“Are you *really* trying that with me? Even if your relationship was just, I don’t know, a work thing do you really think it’s fair to let her leave thinking you’re incapable of forgiving her for saving my life?

“I understand why Nathalie did what she did.” He says tightly, like the words hurt to utter.

“Well she doesn’t think you do. Seeing as you’re refusing to talk to her.”

“You have a very odd conception of giving someone space.”

Adrien’s whole brain froze at that, “*what?*”

“Nathalie’s condition was fragile. You know that. The last thing her recovery needed was the man who almost killed her in the first place bothering her.”

“You,” oh my god his father cannot be this stupid. On the other hand he did think it was a sensible idea to become Hawk Moth so, “you think you’re staying away for *Nathalie’s* sake?”

“You’ve said it yourself Adrien. I don’t know how to be there with someone. And I have been very angry with Nathalie even if her actions were justified. If I was to go to her…a confrontation would help no one.”

“Maybe it would actually get you *talking.* Father she thinks you don’t want to see her. That’s why she’s leaving.”

“She’s leaving because she wants to be away from me. Because it’s for the best if she’s away from me.”

“She *loves* you.”

“She loves you,” his father says it like it’s a correction, “that much of my conversations with Panthera were true enough. I failed to save your mother. I won’t keep you away from Nathalie. I know you’re important to each other.”

“That much?”

His father casts a considering gaze on him, “I have always wanted to protect you Adrien. But it seems I have failed there. So perhaps I should treat you as an adult here. Perhaps it will help you in your endeavours with Ladybug.”

“Me and Ladybug aren’t going to happen.”

“If you say so,” he says it so blithely as if it’s not true and he isn’t the reason it won’t happen, “but you must understand Adrien I’ve hurt Nathalie. A lot. Not least by not noticing her,”

“What?”

“I thought for a long time after what happened that she’d only given into my advances because of you, maybe even for your mother’s sake to spare her from what she’d come back to. I hated that. But I hated it more when I remembered what she said about your father once and realised that wasn’t the case at all. That she’d been holding back all this time.”

Adrien really *really* does not want to know any of this, and yes, he’d wanted his father and Nathalie together but not to know the details, and he definitely did not want to know what ‘given in’ meant but, “I don’t get it.”

“She loves your father you know. She told me that when there was no advantage to her saying it. She had other methods to keep me away.”

“You’re my father.”

“Yes.”

It feels like he’s fallen into some topsy-turvy universe. “How can Nathalie loving you be a bad thing?”

“You don’t approve of what we’d both done.” His father announces in an apparent non-sequitur.

“No. Of course not.” He says unthinkingly.

“I think perhaps that was why she did it.”

Not that on some level Adrien hadn’t known that, hadn’t known a simple employee wouldn’t have risked her life as Mayura but, “Oh.”

“Exactly. I am angry at Nathalie. I’m not sure I knew her at all after all. I don’t know if I can forgive her. But most importantly if I can then I think the best thing I can do for her is to let her go.”

“Are you going to let me go?”

“What on earth are you talking about?”

“Well, if you apparently ruin the lives of those around you, Maman, Nathalie, who knows who else, and you’re letting Nathalie go to avoid that then are you going to let *me* go? Or do you not love me as much as you love her?”

His father almost recoils, “That’s not the same. Adrien you’re a child. I’m not going to throw you out into the world.”

Adrien decided to ignore the fact that his father still seemed to think he was ten or something, “And Nathalie’s still sick.”

“She’ll have made arrangements.” His father tries to justify.

“You can’t be telling me this is what you wanted. That if I hadn’t blabbed about those earrings this is where you hoped things would go.”

“Of course it’s not.”

“So? Are you the man who was ready to remake the universe for Maman or not?”

“Adrien,”

Adrien ignores the warning. He’s not being grounded anytime soon. Not when he can jump out his window as Chat Noir and his father won’t dare to call the police. “Are you going to go out there and fight for Nathalie and that future you wanted or are you going to be a coward and make us both lose someone *again?*”

His father’s hands are now in front of him as he fiddles with adjusting his cuffs and it suddenly seems ridiculous that he’d thought him hard to read, “you think she won’t flee further?”

“I think you need to talk. What happens then is up to you.”

Chapter 22: Gabriel VIII

The door opens and all the air runs out of the room with it leaving Gabriel dizzy and dry-mouthed as he looks on the woman standing in the doorway.

Nathalie looks completely different to the image that haunts him of her lying pale and still on her bed halfway to a corpse in those black pyjamas that only made her skin look a more sickly shade of white.

Instead she stands there purely under her own power, in dark jeans and a scarlet jumper that echoes the warmth in her checks and her lips, with her hair falling free behind her neck. Longer and straighter than Panthera's, and he's surprised at how thrown he is at that difference, it has a healthy gleam to it.

Gabirel had known she'd been doing well. He'd read it from Adrien, read all the reports from her doctors, and then physiotherapists. Had she not been *safe* to leave the house he'd never have let her go in the first place.

But it's different. Seeing it look this.

The edges of her ears are the first thing to move upon seeing him, and then her shoulders slump, her handbag strap falling from her arm to the crook of her elbow.

"Really?"

The strange atmosphere in the room breaks on her word. She might not look like his Nathalie, the one he'd known, but she sounds just the same.

It's not exactly the reaction to seeing him he was hoping for, but it always could have been worse. He'd known that appearing unannounced in her hotel room was a gamble but this conversation is hardly one to have in public, and he'd not been sure she'd agree to meet from what Adrien had said.

"I've come to take you home," he offers.

She throws her handbag down on the chair beside her bed and crosses her arms, "I don't recall asking for a lift. Did Plagg and Adrien put you up to this?"

"They did both have rather a lot of words for me on the matter," the damned kwami especially, "you seem to have wrapped that kwami around your finger. However do you manage it?"

He means it. First Duusu, now Plagg. Even Nooroo to some extent. The Kwamis seem to *like* Nathalie despite her forcing them to go along with her own plots as much as he does with his.

"I wouldn't say that. Although he's open to bribery with cheese. The more expensive the better."

“I doubt that would work,” the blasted thing’s ongoing litany of the many many ways in Plagg’s estimation that Gabriel has apparently failed as a father, which is honestly quite rich coming from a fatherless and childless inhuman being whose slept most of his existence, suggests only a happy Adrien will appease him and that seems a long way off these days. “Apparently I’m a worse father than a villain and I’ve almost killed everyone I love.”

There’s faint wrinkles of disagreement on Nathalie’s forehead. “But. Adrien, you,”

“The episode when I akumatised his bodyguard I suppose. Though I suppose that’s only the most obvious, and there’s probably worse times if I consider when he was Chat Noir.”

It’s one of those things that Gabriel’s been trying not to think about. It’s so easy to do when Plagg provokes him and he can expel his anger out on someone he doesn’t care about hurting and think about nothing but that. It’s harder in the night when he dreams of all the various ways his son could have died at his hand.

Dreams of a soulless Emilie staring through him at their son’s portrait, of a woman who’s sometimes Emilie and sometimes Nathalie yelling invective at him for killing Adrien, of the smiling Emilie he might have created will the wish who looks at him in love and whose face creases in concern and confusion when he talks of a son and tells him they have no children.

“Oh,” there’s a pause then slowly he sees her indifferent mask dropping to showcase the softer Nathalie behind, “How are you doing with…all of that?”

His own shield of ice that sometimes feels like the only thing keeping him upright seems to fracture in response. That little bit of warmth from Nathalie enough to melt a crack wide enough for the whole thing to shatter.

For once he makes no attempt to hold anything back as he sighs, “How do you think?”

Nathalie brushes her hair back behind her ears. “I’m sitting down to have this conversation.”

Gabriel hovers awkwardly as she settles herself on the bed.

“Here,” she takes her handbag off the chair, “you should too.”

It’s not an offer to set next to her, definitely not an invite to her bed, but it’s *something* so Gabriel accepts the olive branch gratefully and sits down opposite her.

Nathalie curls her legs up beneath her in a move that doesn’t really fit with the Nathalie he’d known but *does* fit with Panthera, and then it hits him she’s not wearing her electronic supports.

She hadn’t before it all came out; he realises now that that was due to Plagg and not just because she’d been as fill of hope for the future as he was the way he’d egotistically thought. But even after Ladybug had intervened the Nathalie whose bed he’d sat by for so many hours had looked so close to death he’d feared she’d never leave that state.

“You’re doing alright?” He nods towards the absence of the prosthetics.

Her fingers tap against her legs, “whatever Ladybug did I seem to have *too* much energy these days. It’s unsettling. I keep waiting for the crash. But until then I don’t seem to be at risk of collapse. ”

He tries not to frown at the concern that stirs in him. He’s not here to reprimand Nathalie or scare her off but, “You should speak to her.”

“Have you?” She strikes back.

Gabriel looks down at his lap, “not since I gave up my Miraculous for you.”

He’s not sure why he feels so ashamed. Nathalie knows what type of man he is. That he’d stay in his lair and send out others to do his bidding and that’s the only reason he hasn’t struck his own son with his own hands much worse than anything his father did to him.

“I suppose I can’t blame you there.” Nathalie sighs, “I was tempted to run away after Adrien gave me his Miraculous and then Plagg told me about what would happen if we made the Wish in very quick succession.”

His eyes are drawn back to Nathalie, one of the few ineffective tools he has to try to gauge her emotions now that he no longer has the Butterfly Miraculous. Not that that helped him much.

Nathalie, he can’t help but think, must have felt a rush of relief when he’d confirmed that he didn’t use his Miraculous on her or Adrien. Gabriel now thinks it might have been easier if he *had.* Or maybe he hadn’t used it on Panthera. Things would be much simpler now then.

She sits there opposite him and waits patiently for his response. She’s always been patient with him.

“You didn’t though,” he points out slowly, the words delayed by the confused morass of emotion he’s drowning in, *has* been drowning in since he saw Nathalie again, perhaps since the moment she collapsed as Mayura.

“How could I? I had to somehow find a way out of this that didn’t leave someone I loved dead. Leaving you and Adrien to fight each other? That wasn’t an option.”

Loved. That last syllable dragging it into the past tense echoes around his skull.

“But it is now?”

Her movement is slight, someone else might not notice it at all but Nathalie is Gabriel’s entire focus right now and he’s known her for years. Felt her make the same preparations to attack when he’d held Panthera in his arms.

“I thought you didn’t have your Miraculous anymore,” Nathalie’s voice is tight.

“I don’t, I gave it to Ladybug to-“

“To save me.” She finishes for him. “Yes I know. So I can’t see there’s an issue anymore. Unless you were planning to try to take Adrien’s Miraculous *as Gabriel.*”

His nails dig into his palms. “Adrien and I am quite capable of fighting without it being a physical battle between magical superheroes and supervillains you know. Especially now he knows I was said supervillain, and that I almost got you killed trying to save his mother who’d died from the same thing which I’d help her acquire.”

“Oh my god,” Nathalie presses at her temples, “Gabriel Agreste did you *seriously* come here to try and get me come back just so I can referee things between you and your son?”

“Well he does like you more than me,” he tries to joke, despite the tightness in his chest her misunderstanding creates.

But Nathalie scowls instead of giving in and fear shoots down his spine.

Her chest heaves, as she takes a breath in. “Have I not done *enough* for you? I risked my life for you, I risked my freedom, even our friendship by lying to you. And after you made it quite clear that you didn’t want to see me, which fair enough I can understand that after how I deceived you, that *fine*. But when I try to make a clean cut of things and leave your house *like you seem to want me to* you turn up somehow in my hotel room, which I don’t know how you even got in and-“

“I told the receptionist I was your boyfriend.” He interrupts.

It seems to work to break her flow. “What?”

“I told the receptionist I’d just flown in last night and wanted to surprise my girlfriend, Nathalie Sancoeur, and asked for a key to your room.”

“That’s why the flowers?” Her eyes fly to the bouquet sitting on the table. “How the hell did that work? What if you’d been a stalker? Or just randomly targeting me? I should complain, or sue them or something.”

“That seems a little harsh. I did show her photos of the two of us together,”

“You have those?”

Gabriel decides to ignore that, “and admittedly I did bribe her. Quite a bit for someone like that I’d have thought actually.”

Her head falls into her hands, “I don’t even want to know.”

“And I hoped you’d be happy to see me.”

Her face reveals itself from behind her hands with a distinctly unimpressed expression, fire burning in her eyes as clear as in any akuma Gabriel’s ever created.

“You. Never. Came. To. See. Me. I was literally in your house, just down the corridor. But you didn’t, and you didn’t stop me leaving. And now you’re daring to come here because

you're hoping to push Adrien's parenting off on me. While we, what? Just do our best to avoid each other in that house of yours?"

"I didn't come here for Adrien." He stands up. He's let this misapprehension go on too long.

Nathalie shakes her head. "What?"

He kneels down in front of her and reaches for her hands to unload himself to you, "I was scared to talk to you Nathalie. You know I need you with me to give me courage and without you, without even Nooroo, I couldn't work out what to say. I didn't know what I felt except that I didn't want to risk your health with another argument."

Nathalie's lips part, "So you stayed away."

"So I stayed away," she hasn't shoved his hands off hers so he dares to close his fingers around her a little tighter, "Nathalie it would make my son very happy if you came home. And he would be slightly less angry with me, because he's very cross at me for how I've treated you. But that's not why I'm here. I'm here because *I* want you to come home with me."

"You…do?" There's a wobble to her voice.

"Don't be so surprised. According to Plagg I'm very selfish you know." He half-smiles up at her, trying to make his honesty clear in every way he can.

"I don't know about that. You gave up Emilie for my and Adrien's sake."

"I gave up one woman I loved because I couldn't bear to bring her back at the cost of one of the other two people I love. Or both had I kept on fighting my son and let you die that day."

"You," Nathalie swallows, "you love me?"

He's never seen Nathalie look quite so flummoxed. Even that time he'd told her about his plan to seduce Panthera, to seduce *her.* It's cute. And it's an indictment of him.

Leaving just one hand on hers, Gabriel strokes her thankfully no longer hollow looking cheek, "I thought I'd told Panthera that."

"You told me you had feelings for Nathalie. Me." Her face screws up, and he's glad he's not the only one still struggling with how to describe those interactions now, "but those. I thought they were fairly new, that you wanted to try things, I wasn't sure how strong they were."

"Even after I risked my identity by asking Ladybug's help to save you?"

"I thought you might have resented me for that whatever you used to feel. You did,"

"Pull a disappearing act." He sighs, "I know."

"It's one of my least favourite of your traits you know."

“That’s your reaction to me laying my heart out to you?”

“Well it’s not like you need me to reciprocate. You *know* how I feel.”

“No I don’t.”

“I told you. And you felt my emotions when I was Panthera.”

“Not the depth of them. I had no idea you’d risk me hating you all for my own sake. And I knew how you *used* to feel. Not how you feel now.”

Tears threaten in the corners of her eyes, but the line of her mouth is soft as she looks down at him. “Do you really think something like that can just change? I know you avoid things you don’t know how to handle. That wasn’t going to make me hate you.”

He wants to accept that, to luxuriate in the forgiveness she’s offering but he has to push, has to know there’s no caveats, not sting in the tail, “What about attacking you and refusing to listen when I discovered you were Panthera? Threatening to lock you up? And then almost fighting the son you’d been trying to protect from me? Would any of that be enough?”

“It wasn’t. Though…had you not *stopped* fighting Adrien knowing he *was* Adrien I think we’d be having a different conversation.”

Gabriel inhales. “If I’d do that then I don’t think you’d be here to *have* that conversation.”

“You’re a better man than that.”

“Only because you make you one.” He half-disagrees.

“I also helped you be Hawk Moth, I’m hardly some paragon of morality.”

This time he does have to argue with her. “You wanted to save someone completely unselfishly.”

“You did pay me to try and find a magical cure for Emilie and I failed. It didn’t feel right to leave you after that, not after how I saw you all suffer. And then well,”

The tightness in his chest relaxes at the reminder. “You fell in love with me?”

“Yes. And Adrien wriggled his way into my heart too. I might not have been doing it for me, but I was still willing to terrorise thousands to just make two people I loved happy. It never bothered me until I knew it was Adrien we were fighting.”

“Do you know I used to judge Ladybug and Chat Noir’s parents?” Gabriel muses, “I couldn’t believe anyone could let their teenager do that.”

“Once you figured they *were* teenagers.”

“Lots of people are very short. But yes, discovering who else they gave out a Miraculous did give the game away there.”

“Admittedly I do doubt Ladybug is going to grow that much more.” Nathalie presses her lips together, “should *we* have cared? That we fighting kids Adrien’s age?”

He considers it a little. “Even if the heroes were adults we’d still have endangered people of all ages. We put a lot of weight in that Wish to fix things.”

“We did.” She nods, but it looks heavy, like she’s weighed down by their mistakes.

That he understands. “God I wish I’d known earlier.”

“Would you have been ready to know?”

“Perhaps not.”

“I suppose. If you haven’t been speaking to her, and you’re here so she’s clearly not revealed who you are, then…is Ladybug just letting us both get away with it?”

“She’d probably pardon you regardless.”

“Adrien said that too.”

“But you were right about her affection for my son. She knows him. It’s not just a celebrity crush. I could tell that much before I gave her the Butterfly. I think she doesn’t want to deprive Adrien of his father after she wasn’t able to save his mother. Though admittedly I’m somewhat worried she might be just waiting until she works out who’ll get custody of Adrien if I go to jail.”

One manicured eyebrow raises, “And you still came after me? To bring me back to that?”

“Well I rather hoped that if I was going to spend the rest of my life behind bars that I’d get to kiss you first.”

“Oh,” and the slight part in her very pink lips is extremely tempting right now.

“May I?”

“Technically if it was only the one kiss you’ve already had it.” But there’s a hint of smirk in her expression, and she’s clearly ready to engage.

So he overs her the same buy-in she’s offering to him, offers a truth he’s yet to say out loud, “That was Panthera not Nathalie. And I wanted it to be Nathalie all along.”

“You did?”

She’s staring down at him as if worried he’s just an illusion despite his hands on her proving his existence.

“I told you.” He tries to remind her, “Panthera reminded me of Nathalie. Why do you think I liked her so much?”

“I thought it was the other way round. That because of your attraction to Panthera you were able to imagine a relationship. And there I was a real practical option that I’d accidentally seduced you in to seeing.”

It’s a risk, but “Were you trying to seduce me?”

“No! I had no idea you’d respond to me like that,” she pushes her lips together in that little pout again and her eyes flick down, “Plagg wanted me to though.”

“Ah,” a few more pieces fall in to place, “that change in your costume.”

“Quite.” Her tone is dry.

“So between me and your Kwami it sounds like you were actually putting in the effort not to seduce me.”

“It was harder than I expected, not giving in when you were trying to seduce me.”

“Oh god,” and yes he’d known it already, had been reminded of it by Plagg and damn had he missed Nooroo then in a way he’d never expected “I told you to your face that I planned to seduce you.”

“Now you know how I feel.”

“I don't know about that, you can't have felt quite as stupid as I do right now.”

“I felt a lot of things.” Her fingers catch his to entwine them, “have you really forgiven me?”

“I think my anger died while I was worried you were.”

“You were there weren't you?”

He frowns trying to grasp her meaning.

“By my bed,” she clarifies, “before I woke up. I wasn’t sure after. Thought maybe I’d hallucinated it. Or that maybe you only watched because you weren’t sure I wasn’t faking until you saw what improvement in me looked like.”

“Nathalie no. Adrien and I kept constant vigil until we were sure you’d survive. I just...”

“Didn’t know what to say once you knew I would.”

“It was only after that I realised,” or was reminded, “that I did know your feelings. That you’d acted out of love for both of us.”

“I’d be embarrassed I told you that if it wasn’t that, well, I don't think you'd be here otherwise.”

He smirks, “you’re glad I’m here.”

“Of course I am. I thought you despised me Gabriel.”

“I could never despise you. I’m a little hurt that you didn't tell me the truth but...”

“But,”

“But you wanted to tell me didn't you? When you admitted things you only could because I didn’t know who you were you always seemed,” he struggles to explain it, what he’d felt is hard to translate to words, “I don't know. A little less like you were balancing on some tightrope.”

“That's a good way of putting it. It was,” there’s a pause as if she too is unsure how to say it and yet he thinks he understands perfectly, “Freeing to be honest amongst all those lies. Even if I could only say them because of all the masks.”

He certainly does understand that. Shadow Moth had pursued Panthera when Gabriel had been unable to even accept he wanted to pursue Nathalie.

And there’s another thing he gets on an instinctual level.

“You know, it would be a little hypocritical of me to blame you for lying to someone you loved to protect them while you thought you were doing the right thing.”

The corners of her mouth turn up a little at that, and Gabriel wants to spark that glimmer of amusement in her eyes everyday.

“But I do think,” he continues, her love for him giving him confidence, “that if you’re going to come back to the house in your new role then we’re going to have to be promise to be honest with each other. No more going behind my back. And I’ll have to try to make it so you don’t need to.”

Nathalie’s eyes narrow. “A new role?”

“Well you can't very well come back as my assistant now.”

“I suppose not.” But her lips press together.

She has always hated being unable to do anything. Gabriel can only hope he can offer enough to make up for that. He likes to think he can. He’s almost caught her.

“The title would be up to you you know.”

“Hmm,” her consideration is clear, “really?”

“Girlfriend, lover, partner. Whatever you think is best.”

“*Oh.*” Nathalie tongue wets her lips, “I see. Can I think about that?”

“So long as you’re only thinking about the title. I can offer others you know. But if you’re thinking about whether to *accept,*” he does as much as a shrug he can without releasing Nathalie, “then I’m going to have to seduce you again. Without the masks this time.”

“I.” Nathalie starts, “Gabriel,” stops again, “we need to talk.”

His heart drops, “What? You said,”

“I love you,” she stops him, “and I think I can believe you love me. It. It fits with everything you’re done. But I am, for a number of reasons, the reason you ended up letting Emilie go. Are you able to promise me you don’t resent me for that. That you’re not *going* to resent me for that? That the first time we fight as a couple you’re not going to throw that in my face?”

Chapter 23: Nathalie VIII

Her surname has never felt quite as untrue as in this moment when Gabriel looks up at her with his certainty shattered by her words, and indecision clashing in his eyes like the beginning of lightning in a storm cloud.

Inside her chest her heart beats so hard it feels like it wants to break out of her and she's not sure if it's for herself or for Gabriel that she feels this pain.

If he can say *yes,* then she's exonerated. She has everything she's ever wanted. A future with a Gabriel that loves her where she can attempt to rebuild things with an Adrien who seems open to that. None of her fears of everything being beyond fixing will have been true, they can move on from this, bruised and aware of their mistakes but towards a better life.

If he can't then that mirage of happiness that's been dangled in front of her is going to be ripped away again.

Which has already happened once.

But it would be worse this time. Worse when Gabriel knows the truth and is *still proposing this* because she'd known, even in her happiest moments with him before she was unmasked, she'd known that it could fall apart on him discovering the truth.

But she fears for Gabriel too. For a man so many people think cold he's such an expressive face and it's clear she's hurt him. He's put himself out there, opened up his soft inside to her, only for her to rebuff him.

For his own sake as well as hers but that doesn't make what she's asked of him any easier. Not with how it presses on all those tender spots he'd rather avoid: Emilie's loss, losing *her,* admitting things his instincts are to hide.

His lower lip sticks out below his upper and he looks like nothing so much as a child whose teddy bear's been taking away and Nathalie can't help it. She frees her hand from his and pulls him closer to her.

Gabriel doesn't fight her, falling between her legs and letting his head rest against her chest.

Nathalie runs her hand over his back, "if you can't answer now that's ok you know. We could still try being friends."

"Friends?" He croaks against her, and something in her twists in sympathy with the brokenness in his voice, but his cheek moves up against her almost as if his mouth is turning up, "my dear Nathalie, do you think we're really capable of being friends?"

"I-" it's tricky to imagine yes, their working relationship had transmuted into something else, something where loyalty went both ways and wasn't motivated by money but no, that never

had been friendship. Not on *her* side anyway as she'd slowly realised how far she'd go for Gabriel Agreste, and then realised *why* she would; that she'd lost her heart to him.

And perhaps it hadn't been on his side either. Perhaps the Gabriel who had leapt to woo her behind a mask armed with an excuse, the man who would come to her bedside seeking consolation, who shied away from physical affection except for when he forced himself with those whose approval he needed but who sought it from her. Perhaps it had never been friendship when things had shifted for him either.

It should have been apparent earlier. What she and he had, it wasn't the measured wary respect she saw between him and Tomoe Tsurugi, the only person she *could* maybe call a friend of his. Neither Audrey nor André with his pretended obsequiousness in public and derision in private would qualify. The closest she could think of otherwise is that he had people he preferred to work with.

Unhealthy perhaps but then Nathalie isn't much better. Depressing as it is *Plagg* of all people might be the closest thing she has to a confidante. She deeply needs to fix that because now it's not going to accidentally lead to the end of the world he's quite capable of spilling something to Adrien if he thinks it funny.

She inhales and tries, "not living together, but if we're not and I'm working elsewhere and maybe we don't meet up too much and-"

"Nathalie," Gabriel interrupts, "that's not friends either. That's acquaintances."

"Maybe," she lets her head droop so it lies on top of his, "but if you can't answer…"

"I thought you said I had time to answer."

"I did,"

His arms squeeze tighter around her, "it'll be alright."

"Will it?" She hates the damned quiver in her voice.

"You question…oh it was well chosen Nathalie. I don't know that I can't say I'd have said that in a fit of anger. I'd like to say we won't fight but I deeply loved Emilie,"

"I know," it's an odd mix of guilt and jealously and guilt for being jealous that presses against the back of her tongue.

"And oh, the arguments we used to have. She used to disappear with Adrien for days afterwards."

The world turns upside down at her words, "I didn't know that."

"We didn't do it in public. And I suppose by the time you moved in she was too ill to have the energy. And even if I was angrier at her than ever, I couldn't take it out on her. Not in that state." Suddenly his chest hitches against her, "but I did that to you didn't I? No wonder you don't want to come home to me."

“It’s not the same. You thought you couldn’t trust me. I mean you *couldn’t* trust me but, you,”

“Could trust you to have my best interests in mind. I should have known, it’s what you’d do as Mayura isn’t it? Lie to take that Miraculous and go behind my back because you were trying to give me what I wanted.”

“It looked rather worse than that.”

“Don’t try to make excuses for me darling. But I meant it. No more lies for us alright?”

“That might be a little hard for *us* of all people.” Lies are probably the only thing saving the two of them from mob violence right at this moment. As to what Gabriel has told Adrien of the truth- she has her doubts about that including the entirety of everything.

“No lies between *us,*” Gabriel shifts her head off his so he can turn and look her in the eyes, taking her face in his hands.

It must be a remarkably uncomfortable position for him but it’s hard to think caught in the full force of his gaze like this.

“Us?”

“I meant it. Maybe I would say it to hurt you but I promise I will never ever mean that. You’re *not* why I can’t have Emilie back. I can’t have Emilie back because she’s *dead* and there’s no way to save her. The Miraculous I thought could give me everything could only give me some of it and that’s not a bargain I’m willing to take. You’re not why I don’t have Emilie. You’ve why I still have Adrien. And I want you to be why I still have someone to love. Be mine Nathalie.”

“You must be hurting your back like that,” her mouth says while her brain completely shuts down at what her ears have just heard and her eyes have seen.

Gabriel’s brow furrows, “what?”

She falls back onto the bed, and Gabriel wholly unprepared follows her down, though he must manage to brace himself because though he’s enjoyably solid and heavy against her she’s not crushed in the slightest.

“I’d be remiss if I didn’t take care of you.” She explains, resting her arm on his back.

His jaw drops open, and then the widest smile she’s even seen on his face splits across it, “that’s a yes then.”

“Yes,” she finally manages to say properly.

“Good.”

He’s so so close and yet it seems like it takes an eternity for their mouths to meet.

It's the same as when Monarch kissed Panthera and it's totally different. He's just as warm against her as he was then but there's no masks separating them, no gloves on their hands, it's skin against skin and her hands tangle in his hair inside of closing on his cowl.

Gabriel's breathing heavily when they let the smallest bit of space creep in between them, "you know there's room for change with that title I'm offering you know. Promotion even, if you think of it like that."

"I guessed that." She nuzzles back against him and kisses him again.

Untraditional as their courtship might have been Gabriel *is.* She's known where the relationship he was offering was going in his head the moment he was offering it.

That's why she had to be sure he was ready to offer it.

But right now, with the world condensed down to him and her, and his hands and his lips, it's very easy to believe he is.

Nathalie's woken by a tickling sensation to the back of her neck, as if butterfly wings are brushing against it. It takes her sleepy brain time to make sense of it and the weight on top of her before her looks down at the arm around her and the very familiar silver ring on it.

In the meantime Gabriel presses more kisses to her neck. She pushes up against his arm so she can roll over coming face to face with him.

"How are you awake before me?"

Nathalie *always* wakes first. Until her illness she'd been an early riser by nature and it was her job to make sure the Agrestes were ready for the day after all.

"I had the most horrifically vivid dream about Adrien coming as Chat Noir to come check I hadn't scared you off again and peering in the window."

"Sounds like a nightmare."

"It would certainly be embarrassing. It's bad enough he knows Panthera and Shadow Moth are *us.*"

"I don't think anything we got photographed doing was bad enough that Adrien wouldn't be alright with it now he knows it's *you* and not a supervillain who's stolen me away."

"You're very important to my son you know." He nuzzles against her.

"I know. He told me." She looks past Gabriel at the window, "you're sure Adrien wouldn't actually do that?"

“Unfortunately we both know he *is* given to sneaking out as a superhero. But no, I told him this was something I needed to do myself. I thought about what asking him to borrow his Miraculous to come visit you but,”

“You *what?!”*

She can only hope her shriek didn’t wake anyone in a surrounding room. It turns out the simultaneous fact of trying to imagine him daring to request that of his son, and the rather arresting image it creates should impossibly Adrien have agreed makes it hard to remember they’re not in the mansion but somewhere their neighbours can actually hear them.

“I did have to get in here somehow. Shadow Moth could have taken the window but as you know I don't have those Miraculous anymore.”

“Adrien would have thought you'd be going back on your word and next thing you’d be attacking Ladybug with his Miraculous.”

“I didn’t actually ask him,” Gabriel bristles but then he hugs her a little tighter, “I've lost all my son’s respect for me haven’t I?”

“Not forever. You can earn it back you know,”

“He’s my son, he’s supposed to,” Gabriel’s voice gives out in his frustration.

“And we’re disappointed him.”

“He’s forgiven you.”

“Hmm. He feels sorry for me, and he thought I might die. That’s not quite the same thing. If he *does* still respect me it’s only for not giving you his Miraculous or stealing Ladybug’s from hers.”

“So you *did* consider that?”

“Of course. Before I knew about the Wish. Adrien would have hated me for it but if I thought I could have got away with it. Then, yes I would have.”

“A good thing you didn’t then.”

Nathalie tries not to put too much weight in his words, she’s can’t assume he’s thankful she deceived him even if he’s logically, and apparently emotionally, willing to forgive her. His ongoing focus on honesty suggests otherwise.

Whether to distract him or just because it’s still such a novel sight she pushes back the strands of his hair falling onto his forehead.

“Knowing our luck paparazzi would have caught you climbing in the window or cataclysming it or whatever you were planning.”

He smirks, “Chat Noir’s father coming to steal his woman back from Shadow Moth?”

She almost giggles at that image, but then perhaps in the hard-to-believe euphoria she's in now it's expected she'd be so like herself, "I'd like to see that. You fighting yourself."

"Would you now?"

"Hmm," she can't quite meet his eyes, "hot as the image as you as, hmm, what would it have been M. Panther? Or M. Noir? Cat Father?"

"Those are all awful, though I'm glad you think it would carry it off."

Warmth floods her core as she imagines Gabriel in a more masculine version of her own outfit as Panthera, probably with a cowl given him, and it's hard to associate him with green but, "black's always been your colour."

"Do you think so?"

"I think most people would agree with me."

"Maybe I should make some updates to my day to day wardrobe then. After all-" he suddenly cut off and a shadow crossed his face.

It hit Nathalie a moment later; Gabriel could well be expecting to wear a lot of black in the near future as he officially said goodbye to Emilie.

Clearly attraction made her stupid. Maybe this is how Gabriel had felt when he'd been flirting with her as Panthera. She'd have to apologise for judging him for that if things kept up like this.

"Gabriel?"

"Shadow Noir," he declares confusing her.

"What?"

"That's what I've have called myself with Adrien's Miraculous."

"I see," Nathalie says slightly uneasily, "doesn't that suggest some continuity with you as Shadow Moth though? And you wouldn't the Butterfly or the Peacock. Unless you were *really* planning to scare the kids."

"The continuity is in me."

She tries not to raise an eyebrow. "If you say so sir."

A slight crease forms between his eyebrows. "You know you're going to have to stop calling me that."

"Force of habit."

“Hmm, you know I’m not blind to the fact you only use it instead of my name when you're annoyed with me, or making fun of me.”

“I hadn't noticed.”

“Sorry to steal a weapon from your arsenal love.”

Nathalie’s stomach does a stupid flippy thing at that finl word, “and yet you seem to be gaining them. That doesn't seem very fair.”

“Do you like me calling you my love?”

She kisses him. It’s easier than replying with words. Gabriel pulls her tight against him as she does turning what had been meant to be a quick peck into something far deeper.

As she gasps against his lips she manages, “Good answer?”

“Very good answer.”

Despite the fact that she was very very comfortable in her current position and honestly didn’t want to leave this bed anytime in the near future herself something, perhaps the lingering terrifying image of Chat Noir looking through the window, allowed her to force herself to be sensible and say, “We can’t do this all day you know.”

“Why not?”

His attempt to sound unbothered is undercut by the whining that creeps into her voice and at that she can't quite hold back her smile. It’s going to take her a while to adjust to being the one Gabriel wants as herself.

“For a start you *did* tell your son you were coming after me. I don't think it's a good idea for us to keep him waiting. He'll think he’s messed it up.”

Gabriel groans and rolls back onto his back. “He will, won’t he?”

“Hey. You didn’t. And we’ll be able to show him that, and we’ve time. We can fix things with him.”

“I hope we *do* have time.” He mutters.

Nathalie shuts her eyes in an attempt to stave off the headache building up. She’d almost thought she was out of all of this but if she’s going back with Gabriel then, “We probably should talk to Ladybug yes. I’ve been waiting for the axe to finally hit my neck for long enough now. It’d be nice to live without that.”

Gabriel’s face takes on that familiar mournful cast it has, “Was I the axe?”

“Anybody discovering it all could have been. I don’t think Ladybug would have taken too well to know that her new ally was Mayura. She was suspicious enough of me as it was.”

Despite the cautious acceptance she'd received from the heroine in the end, even for her actions with Shadow Moth, she can't help but feel like Ladybug would have leapt at the chance to expose her as the fraud she's initially thought her and to swoop in and save Chat Noir.

At least the latter impulse is helpful to them even if Nathalie has no plans to let Adrien need saving anytime soon.

"I saw some of that." Gabriel sounds amused again.

"I know." And she can't help it, "I did run into you after you know."

She forces herself to get out of the bed hoping it'll force Gabriel to do the same, but instead the infuriating man just watches her the whole way to the bathroom with a fondness that means she can't even be properly angry at him.

Gabriel scowls at his hair as he attempts to brush it back into place in front of the mirror. "I don't understand how you keep your bun in place with this hairspray."

She shakes her head at his silliness, "hairpins mostly. And I'm not exactly going for height like you are."

He rolls his eyes, "I'd have been able to skip this part until I got home with a Miraculous."

Nathalie delays putting on her lipstick to point out, "apart from the whole thing of making Adrien worry that you hadn't really given up, given what happened with your coat I'm not sure you should be trusted with any Miraculous if you don't want to embarrass yourself more."

Turning from the mirror to look, Gabriel raises his eyebrows, "Tempting as trapping you with any tail would have been I don't think that's particularly *cat*-like so I'm sure it would have been fine. Unless you think I was going to just pounce on you."

She pretends to think about it, the memories of him holding her feeling almost physical against her body, "you almost did that as Shadow Moth and you had no excuse then."

"And I seem to remember you liking it. Maybe that would have been a quicker way to resolve this than all of this talk."

Nathalie turns and leans up to press a quick kiss to his lips, to remove that pout of his.

"Sometimes talking about our feelings is necessary Gabriel however much you hate it."

"Is that hypocrisy I hear?"

It's a fair point. And yet, "I don't know. I like how yesterday's conversation turned out. Didn't you?"

"You've always been good at making convincing arguments."

It would be nice to the take the compliment but there's been a niggling pain behind her tooth since earlier in their conversation and softening the blow by resting her cheek against his shoulder and wrapping her arms around him she says, "you know you can talk to me about her you know?"

"What?"

"Earlier. When the subject of," *Emilie* but her tongue feels heavy and awkward in her mouth and she can't form those syllables when neither she nor Gabriel have spoken his wife's name yet, and she fumbles and manages "funeral attire came up. You deflected it, and I don't want that to be because of me. I don't want things to be awkward. I helped you terrorise this city for her, you don't have to pretend that she doesn't exist. You don't have to pretend you're not grieving."

She can feels the movement in his chest as he breathes in.

"What if I'm not?"

"What?"

"It feels like for so long I've been frozen in place, unable to move forward, lost in some pervasive darkness so deep I couldn't feel anything at all, except for anger on occasion. And now…now it's like the sun's broken through the clouds Nathalie. I feel happy here with you. And I *want* to feel happy. That must sound terrible."

"I don't think so. I get it, this is a new start isn't it? And we're been trying to save her so long,"

Nathalie gets it in an almost instinctual level. It hadn't been *her* reaction to discovering she couldn't save Emilie, but then she'd still had to find a way to get Gabriel and Adrien out of it all mostly in one piece and without them hating each other.

But after that, even thinking Gabriel had rejected her definitively, having it all out in the open had been, "It's almost a relief to know we can't?"

"Yeah."

"I will be. Later. Upset I mean. Adrien and I will have to say goodbye but for now I've sick of being unhappy."

"You don't have to be." Her words carry the weight of a promise, but for once it's a promise that doesn't feel like thorns growing round her throat when she makes it. It's not one she *can* make really, its Gabriel's choice not hers, but she thinks this is one aim of his that she won't regret helping him achieve.

Chapter 24: Plagg II

For how long he'd lived Plagg has known less humans than might be expected. Still he's known enough that he doesn't need Duusu or Nooroo's skills to recognise the body language between his back-up holder and her disaster of a man.

After all a cat can definitely tell when another one has the cream.

And from how she comfortably allows the arm around her waist as she leaves the car Nathalie is *quite* satisfied indeed. Never mind the glow to her complexion. Though admittedly that last bit might just finally be finally seeing her when she's healthy.

"Told ya kid."

Adrien rushes to the window, "Is Father back? Does he have Nathalie?"

The boy gets his own answer as he sees them down below him and at the bright sunshine that spreads across his face Plagg can't feel bad about anything he'd held back from anyone to get here.

Not, he muses, as he follows his holder down the stairs that he has any reason to do so. It's hardly as if he'd had much choice in it with everything that binds him as a kwami and besides he did manage to bring Shadow Moth's activities to an end. If maybe not in the way his boy and Tikki's girl had exactly dreamed about. Or the way Tikki might have either.

But as much as he'd take great glee in tearing Gabriel Agreste apart atom from atom it would upset Adrien and Nathalie so really this is a better ending than the one in which the heroes unmasked him in front of the entire city.

And now he's sorted all the adults all he has to do is get the kids sorted out too, and then he'll be able to lie back and enjoy fine cheeses, paid for by Gabriel's money, and no longer have to play emotional support like he's Nooroo or someone more suited to that sort of thing.

No Plagg can be quite happy in that he's made *his* people happy, and if that also happens to mean his favourite wielder in…well pretty much forever really, now has an increased chance of *not* finding his own destruction the way he's seen before?

Well then. Plagg, saviour of the city of Paris, is winning on every count really.

And as for the city's former villain?

Much as he doesn't want to admit it Adrien's father is not in fact the *worst* man Plagg's met. Not that he's ever telling him that. But if with a few hints about destroying computers and such Plagg can manage to nudge him to look after Adrien the way he should have instead of ruining his life and leading him to a possible early death then he thinks they can find a way to co-exist.

Especially as Adrien runs up to Nathalie to throw his arms around her, and the tension in his grip makes it clear just how afraid his boy had been of losing her.

“I’m so glad you’re back,” Adrien’s little whimper is barely audible even with Plagg’s better than human hearing.

“I couldn’t leave my kitten behind,” she murmurs as she hugs him back, “who knows what sort of trouble you might get into without me?”

The softness in face of the man Plagg’s two wielders both inexplicably love as he watches his son hug his woman is further evidence. Pity Nooroo and Duusu *aren’t* here to see that. They’d have liked it probably. Maybe Adrien can send them a photo or something.

He doesn’t really look like Shadow Moth at all as he nods at Plagg in wary recognition and, he likes to think, thanks.

Adrien finally seems to remember Nathalie needs to breathe and lets go of her, “So are you staying? This isn’t just you coming back to say goodbye properly?”

“No I’m staying,” she looks to her side, “so long as I’m wanted.”

“You know you’re wanted,” Gabriel says gruffly though Plagg could *almost* forgive me the awkwardness given the little smile tugging at Nathalie’s lips as he said it.

Even when plotting this happy ending, even when he’d started to care about it being happy *for her* and not just Adrien he hadn’t realised she care look like that. Look so unburdened.

A smirks pulls at the corner of Adrien’s lips, and he’s a little proud of his boy as he says, “so is Nathalie back as your assistant then?”

“Ah no.” Nathalie gives an apologetic shrug to her apparently former boss, “I’m not sure that would be a good idea.”

“It probably wouldn’t be, although I’m hardly known for my good ideas,” he agrees, turning his attention to his son, “no Adrien Nathalie’s going to be living with us as my partner.” Then he amends, “My romantic partner.”

The last amendment seems pretty unnecessary to Plagg. Humans are always coming up with new titles for things but he thinks it’s pretty clear exactly what’s going on between the two adults.

“Which is only happening because your father and I have known each other a long time and I’ve already been living with you two and is not something you should emulate on starting a realtionship.”

Adrien rubs at the back of his neck. “OK?”

“I’d hope Adrien’s a bit young for that to be necessary to say.” Adrien’s father says with a grimace.

Plagg personally thinks moving in with Ladybug would send his holder over the moon but as far as he can tell from all his boy's friends it does seem like it's not the done thing for a boy of his age so Plagg will just have to focus on giving Adrien the easiest home life he can with the least about of effort.

Namely generally bugging Nathalie about it when he gives her his cheese order for the week.

Oh it's *good* to have a woman like that to sort things out for him.

Thank goodness he'd chosen someone whose family was capable of providing for his needs. More proof that Adrien was the *perfect* wielder for him that he should point out to Tikki's girl.

"Hmm." Nathalie's doing that little smile again, "We've not exactly been great role models to Adrien when it comes to love. That's probably something we should fix."

Plagg waits for the Adrien to point out that they haven't exactly been good role models in *anything* but apparently despite how his father's been knocked off his pedestal he's not quite ready to talk back like that.

Though admittedly he might have used a good bunch of that confidence up when he'd tried to tell his father about Nathalie's feelings for Shadow Moth.

Oh the things a kwami has to do himself, "or in anything really."

Nathalie's 'romantic partner' exhales harshly through his nostrils and Plagg once again questions her taste.

"We gave up didn't we?" He bites up, "perhaps at least Adrien can learn from us when to recognise futility. And perhaps that it's better to just admit your feelings for someone."

OK Plagg will admit that last bit wasn't bad.

"You know I like Ladybug." Adrien looks between everyone confusedly, "that's not really the problem there."

Nathalie at least looks a little abashed at that, which yeah, she probably should do even if she's not the one of Adrien's parents baring the most guilt here really.

"I don't know," she has that thoughtful frown on her face, "*Ladybug* might be hesitant to have anything too much to do with you given she'd not want your father and I to know who she is. But whoever Ladybug is beneath that mask might not have that issue."

"Because you think she wouldn't still worry about that?"

Nathalie concedes, "she probably would. But it's not like we'd know if you were dating her or moving on with another girl. You have liked other girls you know."

"I guess," Adrien looks unsure.

Plagg tries not to roll his eyes at Mr Fail Father's "He has?"

"I told you. Tomoe's daughter."

"Ah. Anyway I very much plan to remain in denial about the possibility of having Ladybug as a daughter-in-law. Preferably forever. You can tell her that by the way."

Red takes over Adrien's cheeks, "*Father."*

"Like that's not your plan," Plagg reminds Adrien only slightly in revenge for the number of times he's heard it. It's a lot.

"*Plagg,"* his Adrien chimes in an almost identical tone.

"Anyway." Nathalie straightens up and her shoulders move back in what he's recognised is her getting back to business face, "we do need to talk to Ladybug."

"Yes," a shadow crossing his face makes it much easier to see as the man who'd terrorised this town, "We do. Adrien it's important you get this set up quickly. Nathalie's been feeling odd since Ladybug healed her, and,"

The cheese he'd eaten earlier seems to curdle further inside him. It had been bad enough when his *own* magic had failed Nathalie when she was holding his Miraculous, but it's somehow impossibly worse to hear that *Tikki's* might have.

No it's not his fault this time but Plagg's used to things going wrong when he uses his power. There's a reason he doesn't do it anymore. Tikki's power is supposed to be different, to full all the holes in his lack, to create rather than destroy.

If Nathalie's still ill after *that* then maybe healing is impossible for her.

Maybe this is just a ceasefire in the battle for a better life Adrien seems to have been born into, a *temporary* oasis in this desert, and not a real happy-ending.

Adrien's gone pale as milk, and frankly looks as bad as Plagg feels.

"Nathalie's not ok*?*"

"I'm *fine."* Nathalie scowls at Gabriel.

"Are you though?" Plagg asks.

"What?"

"Just saying Lady, you don't exactly have a good history being honest about this sort of thing."

"I was honest enough with you wasn't I? And you know why I had to keep what I did from Adrien and Gabriel."

The latter takes her hand and Plagg watches his thumb rub over hers “you always did have a tendency to claim you were fine when you weren’t even before Adrien gave you that ring my dear Nathalie.”

She purses her lips, but her eyes aren’t angry at all, and then says, “that’s because I didn’t want to leave you dealing with all this alone Gabriel. I wasn’t being sentenced to my bed until I had to be. *And,*” she looked away from her lover and at Plagg and Adrien, “I’ll have you both know that I’m absolutely fine. This is nothing like before. I’m just a little restless that’s all. And as it happens I do plan to bring it up with Ladybug.”

Plagg’s about to ask her if she’s sure about that when Adrien deploys better pleading kitten eyes than he could ever manage, and with a pout says, “do you promise?”

“Yes.” Nathalie agrees. “I do. But that’s not why we need to talk to Ladybug.”

Once again Plagg and his holder react in sync, this time with a frown.

“Why do you need to talk to Ladybug?”

“Well I suppose maybe we could just talk to you if she’s told you, but Adrien, what does Ladybug want from us?”

“Want from you?”

“She healed Nathalie.” Gabriel says, “I exchanged both Miraculous for that. But given the circumstances of that being necessary,”

That, Plagg thought, was certainly one of saying that he’d scared her to almost death by threatening to lock her away forever, and then being ready to attack his own son such that she’d had to intervene before he’d do something permanent that he’d regret once his bloodlust went down.

“I believe the previous agreement Nathalie brokered on my behalf is probably null and void. Especially now that she’s aware Nathalie also misled her.”

“I…don’t think she blames Nathalie?” Adrien looks fidgety, “I mean we spoke a bit. More when Nathalie was still ill and Ladybug was checking on her but I uh, I think she gets why Nathalie did what she did and she understands it. I mean she gets why *you* did what you did but uh,”

“She understands it less.” Ladybug’s former nemesis’ answer is stiff.

“Yeah?” Adrien offers.

“Tikki’s chosen isn’t the type of hurt others. Now she’s plenty capable of doing it by accident,” how she’d treated Adrien on occasion still stung, “and she’s not without her own violent streak,” he did think it was a pity she’d never really got her chance to beat Shadow Moth up, “but she what stops her from being like you is that she couldn’t deal with the collateral damage to innocents you don’t care about.”

Nathalie gets something of a pass from the girl for not stealing both Miraculous Shadow Moth had held and putting a stop to it all firstly because Marinette understands being in love, and secondly because, quite apart from causing it all to stop in the end, she hadn't actually been the one directly causing it in the first place. Shadow Moth would still have sent out his akumas if Adrien had given the ring to someone else.

"Temporary collateral damage," Shadow Moth appears below the veneer of Gabriel Agreste in his shrug.

"Father," Adrien hisses.

"Maybe don't say that to Ladybug," Nathalie says dryly.

"What? It's not like…" he seems to belatedly register Adrien's glare.

"We didn't leave physical damage but we both know the worst scars aren't always physical," Nathalie says. Then she looks at Plagg, "you're been speaking to Tikki then?"

"Someone had to. Kids a mess talking to his Lady,"

"*Plagg,*"

"And you were dying and then recovering and then you ran away. And that one hid in his office feeling sorry for himself."

Said man glares at that. "Sometimes I think you only want cheap cheese."

Plagg flies up to his face, "don't you dare. Do you *want* me to set Tikki against her. Because her holder listens to her the way you didn't to Nooroo."

Gabirel's jaw sets, "Fine. But just imagine a world without Tikki and then tell me if *you'd* be up to all this stuff you apparently think I should have been doing instead."

A glower tags over his face and he can feel the power thrumming below his skin at the idea of having Tikki taken away from him, at the idea of being so out of balance, at the loss of his other half, at the idea of *someone taking him from her.*

He forgets for a moment where he is as darkness around him and-

Nathalie's clear calm voice cuts through it, "he's not threatening you Plagg."

"Just asking for understanding," the man who he has to remind himself that both Nathalie and Adrien love and that they would be very unhappy were something to happen to him.

"Never do that to me *again,*" he snarls at Gabriel Agreste.

"It's ok Plagg," Adrien calls him back and Plagg flies over to snuggle in his hair and settle himself down against the main reason apart from cheese that he knows it's a good thing he doesn't destroy this world.

“Just reminding you that things haven’t been easy for me.” Gabriel says.

“Doesn’t mean you did right by Adrien.”

“No,” the word is dragged out of him by force, but it nonetheless comes, “I’m aware of that.”

Adrien looks up, and *that* that look of hope on his face is exactly why Plagg dislikes his father, “you *do?*”

“My god Adrien do you think that if I’d known I couldn’t fix everything with magic I’d have become Hawk Moth for fun?”

“Well no but…”

Nathalie grimaces, “I’m not sure it’s entirely Hawk Moth he’s asking about Gabriel.”

It seems the perfect time to interject, “I disliked you even before I knew you were the Moth Man you know.”

“Please don’t call me that.”

“Bite me.”

“Plagg,” Adrien’s voice has the slightest shade of reprimand in it.

Adrien’s father looks down, “I do realise I’ve been distant since your mother died Adrien. I… would have made an attempt to be less so had I not thought I was going to be able to bring her back.”

Plagg wonders if he’s noticed how his language has changed over time as he’s been prodding at him in the Atelier. From “lost” and “sleeping” to “died” and from “save” to “bring her back” and “resurrect”

He’ll give him enough understanding given that he *did* eventually turn it around and given Plagg *has* managed to bring Gabriel to a breakdown once, rather to his satisfaction, he do him a favour and won’t bring it up now.

Especially in front of Adrien as he hardly wants to upset the boy further.

And now he thinks about it discussing her predecessor might upset Nathalie too.

So he’ll hold off for now.

Especially as Adrien seems to finally be showing claws of his own with a surprisingly sceptical, “You would?”

“I wouldn’t have turned into your mother, I know she was always the one of us who looked after you, but yes I’d have made an effort.”

“Are you going to make an effort now?”

“I plan to.”

“Assuming he can.” Nathalie cuts in.

The two Agrestes look at her, having apparently forgotten they’re not alone. Plagg isn’t offended. He’s used to that with his cats.

Adrien’s forehead creases, “what do you mean?”

“We got a little off topic,” her attempted lightness is a little strained, “but we do need to talk to Ladybug. Neither of us want to live with an axe above our necks.”

“My lady isn’t like that!”

The two adults and Plagg all wince a little at Adrien’s fervent defence of Ladybug.

He assumes not all their reasons are the same.

Much as he’d love the kids to get over their issues and get together personally he can’t help but wish Ladybug valued his chosen the way Adrien values Tikki’s.

She’ll get there. Probably.

He just wishes it didn’t hurt Adrien while she was doing so.

Eventually Nathalie speaks, “we’re not saying she is. But she doesn’t seem the type to be happy with just letting us go either. So since she *knows* our identities, and we could probably start to piece together more of hers,”

Adrien’s eyes go wide at that.

“I think it’s probably a good plan we talk to her and sort things out.” She finishes.

Chapter 25: Gabriel IX

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Gabriel finds himself staring up at Ladybug. It's an unusual position for him. He probably hasn't sat below someone like this for what, a decade? Almost two?

Whichever, having this chit of a girl stand over him ready to define his destiny while he sits down awkwardly on his son's couch makes his skin ready to break out in hives. Or it would if Nathalie wasn't sat next to him curled into her side with her head rested on his shoulder.

She's very…grounding is the best word he can offer for how Nathalie makes him feel. It's easier to do what has to be done with her by his side. It always hard been. In his life as Hawk Moth and as Gabriel Agreste. And now when it comes to trying to create the relationship with his son he's never had, and being ready to face the superheroine who holds all their fates in their lives.

Ladybug crosses her arms in front of her. "Adrien said you wanted to talk to me."

"Yes," it comes out stiffly but he doubts Adrien and Nathalie at least expect better from him, "about the future and about Nathalie's future health?"

The girl gasps.

Internally Gabriel groans *how did he lose to a child who wears her emotions on her face?*

How did he never akumatise her?

Yes, he's glad he didn't win but it's still offensive to his soul.

Ladybug's eyes are wide,"Nathalie's still ill?"

Nathalie sighs and sits up a little straighter, "I don't know."

Ladybug frowns and he sees her looking for signs of sickness in his lover. Gabriel himself has struggled to catch anything that would be obvious to see but he can't deny that Ladybug is clever, and that she has access to knowledge about the Miraculous they don't.

And he almost hopes she *can* see something because he *has* noticed other things. The restlessness Nathalie had alluded to. Which could just be a reaction to the strange purgatory they're been in while they try to find a way out of this stalemate, and how she's without a purpose to devote herself to without their quest and her job as his assistant.

But he doesn't think that's it. Not with how she's sleeping less hours than she ever has, to the extent even a night owl like him struggles to match her, yet shows no sign of it either in her appearance or in her energy levels during the day. Nor with the fidgetiness she's suddenly developed.

“What do you mean?” Ladybug sounds more interested than anything else now, that creative mind of hers gearing up to solve a puzzle. Gabriel can only hope she’s as good as solving this as she was at intuited the meanings of her Lucky Charms, “does it vary by day? Or is at that sort of level where it’s annoying but you put it off because you have other things to do?”

“You sound like you might be familiar with that,” Nathalie sounds amused, and faintly chiding as *she* looks over the heroine again as if wondering what secret she might be hiding.

Gabriel himself finds himself amused at how despite their circumstances, and despite how she’s lectured *him* on not taking back to Ladybug, Nathalie still finds herself taking this somewhat disapproving stance on the girl. Or rather that Ladybug *is* a girl and not a woman.

Not that…

Well let’s just said he’s rather glad he surrendered and won’t have to deal with the fact he has permanently beaten by the teenage fangirl of his son. Yes, Ladybug and Chat Noir *had* always won but they’d also never become any closer to unmasking him either.

Until his son had accidentally stumbled onto his identity all because he’d jumped to thinking the worse of Nathalie.

He’s lucky she took him back he knows. Lucky Adrien *had* intervened. If he’d kept her up in the lair he doubts very much things would have turned out like this.

No.

Since then he’s been making the right choices. He has to believe that. And it’s not so difficult when he’s with Adrien and Nathalie and everything seems to be going *right.*

It’s just that it doesn’t *always* go right.

His and Adrien’s relationship is like a set of puzzle pieces they’re trying to assemble and frankly Gabriel’s not sure they *ever* had some of those pieces. Emilie and then Nathalie had always handled the bulk of the childcare.

And Nathalie. Even Nathalie has those frowns on her face at times that she tries to hide from him.

But that’s why he has to work to make sure things *do* go right.

And that includes listening to Ladybug.

For whom it sounds like surprisingly enough not everything goes right for either.

“It’s pretty busy being Ladybug and handling my real life.”

“I can understand that,” Nathalie agrees though privately Gabriel doubts it could be harder for Ladybug than them running a full-on business at the same time. But then again maybe he’s being unfair. Ladybug wouldn’t have had a Nathalie. And if she worked less hours she’d have theoretically been watched for more of them.

Though if her school is like his son's and with the amount of immature angst he tries to tune out until it's strong enough to call to an akuma then frankly he doesn't know what the teachers are doing.

Adrien looks like he wants to move to the girl, "but you're ok?"

Her smile turns soft for his son, and Gabriel can't help but reassured by the sign her affection for Adrien is still in face. It's the main reason she bears them any goodwill after all whatever Plagg the annoyance might claim.

"I'm fine Chaton. Just. Having one less thing to juggle is going to be a relief."

"Right," Adrien doesn't sound as relieved as he'd expect, "of course."

He forces himself to try to take on some of that concern, it's not worse than kissing up to Audrey after all, "I didn't mean to lay another burden on you when I brought up Nathalie's symptoms."

"No," a familiar determination gleams in Ladybug's eyes, "if what I did to heal Nathalie didn't work I want to know. I'd feel so much worse if I only found out when it got bad and I could have done something. And you know I don't leave things unfinished either."

Nathalie stiffens slightly next to him.

The *other* reason they'd wanted to talk to Ladybug of course.

"I don't think it didn't work," Nathalie says, "I mean I'm not in coma right now. I just..could it be possible you gave me too *much* life energy or something. I know that sounds stupid but…"

"No," Ladybug's chewing her lip, "my powers *do* come from creation. It's possible there could be some remnants of that. Maybe, may I?"

She comes a step closer.

"Sure," Nathalie sits forward in her chair.

Ladybug frowns, as she bends slightly to better inspect Nathalie, too short to need to kneel the same way Gabriel would in that position.

She puts a hand to Nathalie's forehead and her frown deepens.

Gabriel's heart drops.

But then she says, "I don't think it's going to be problem."

"It's not?"

"Keep an eye on it and let me know *immediately* if anything changes, but I think it should sort itself out."

Gabriel isn't sure how she can see that with her bare eyes. Even transformed as she is. It's not like she'd seen the Peacock's strain on Panthera's soul. Though he supposes it's different when it's you own magic.

"Anything I can do to speed that up?"

"Create," Ladybug suggests with a shrug, "knit, or crochet, or paint, or draw, or I don't know do pottery or something."

Nathalie does something too elegant to report, "a pity it wasn't Gabriel you healed. I've never been creative."

Ladybug's nose scrunches, "it doesn't have to be something professional level. Don't you doodle or anything? Or uh, I don't know maybe even something like computer coding would bleed off the energy later."

"I guess I'd better look for a new hobby then." Nathalie says, and he can almost hear her mind churning, hearing it consider and then dispose of various different ideas.

Ladybug looks confused, "what do you do when you're not working then?"

Gabriel reminds himself his son is here and bites his tongue.

"I read. Look after these two. Play boardgames. Mostly chess."

"Oh." The poor heroine is doing her best not to look appalled and not when pulling it off.

He knows without looking Nathalie's smirking next to him. "Oh and I like to polish my self-defence skills. I've got back into going to the dojo I went to before I fell ill. Sports in general really."

"Ah." Now she doesn't look sure how to respond.

"And languages of course. I'm thinking of picking up another. Though my Sanskrit has got dusty. Maybe I should focus on that first."

"Stop teasing the girl Nathalie," Gabriel decides to magnanimously save Ladybug since Adrien doesn't seem to have picked up that he should be playing the dashing knight saving his lady right now.

"Wait, she doesn't do all that then?"

"No she does," Gabriel smiles.

"Yeah," Adrien interjects, "did you know she's dad's bodyguard? How cool is that?"

"I did not know that." Ladybug looks a little shell-shocked still.

"But we'll find her a creative outlet too I'm sure." Gabriel reassures her.

“Who knows, maybe it’ll make me more creative,” Nathalie says.

Gabriel’s throat goes tight. He looks at the teenage girl who’s the only one who might be able to answer him, and then at his *son* standing by watching. The son Nathalie’s become a parent to.

But then he’s not sure he can dare *not* ask. “Will it? This magic of yours, does it, that is to say, will it suddenly allow Nathalie to create things she wouldn’t have been able to without it?”

They’re been taking precautions of course but neither of them had considered the matter of *literal creation magic* potentially nullifying them.

Ladybug looks frankly concerned for his sanity but says, “that’s not how this works. It’s like my Lucky Charms. They can show me a way but *I* have to be the one to understand them. This isn’t just going to make Nathalie an artist.”

Nathalie seems to get his meaning, “well we’re all thankful for that.”

The relief in her voice is obvious. Neither of them want to make things even more complicated. Not when they don’t know what shape their future might take and when honestly Adrien is quick enough to be dealing with.

“Um.”

“Anyway,” his girlfriend says, “that not why we asked you here.”

“Right.” Ladybug says, “you said you wanted to talk about the future. I’m not going to give you back your Miraculous you know. Nooroo and Duusu are both happy with the other Kwami’s.”

“And we wouldn’t ask you to do that,” Gabriel finds it easy to say. Now he knows the Miraculous can’t give him anything he wants he sees little need for them.

“So what are you asking?”

Nathalie reaches for his hand, “you and I had a deal. But that was before you knew I was Mayura.”

“And before I attacked Nathalie and Adrien instead of stopping being Shadow Moth like I’d agreed,” Gabriel adds. Because little as he likes saying it that *is* what he’d done.

“And before Father actually did give both Miraculous back to you,” Adrien interjects, “he did give up. And Nathalie lied to protect me, and she’s *why* he gave up.”

Nathalie’s head immediately turns to Adrien, “he was giving up the Wish because of *you* Adrien. Not me.”

“And you’re the one who told him about it.”

Gabriel represses the urge to pinch at his nose. “I couldn’t risk you Adrien. And I couldn’t risk Nathalie dying when I could save her either. The two of you don’t need to argue about who is more important to me.”

“And I’m not going back on our deal.” Ladybug says, “I told you, what I wanted was just for everything to stop. And I’m certainly not going to complain about losing two villains for the price of one. I used to worry about what Mayura be plotting in the background.”

“Sorry.” Nathalie offers.

Ladybug shrugs, “I mean apparently it was to get Shadow Moth to give up, so?”

Gabriel does not point out that technically her aim had been to save this family and had the Wish *not* had a price Nathalie might well have gone ahead with a plot to take Ladybug’s earrings to combine with the ring she already had.

Though he supposes Nathalie did *listen* to Ladybug, and not try to fight her straight away which isn’t something he can say he would have managed to do in the circumstances. He know he can be- impulsive. And that he’d hated the girl in front of him until she’d saved the woman he loved.

“And,” Ladybug continues, “it wasn’t *me* you attacked after your initial surrender. I think it’s the two other people in the room you should be apologising to.”

Nathalie leans a little closer to him in a reminder that *she* at least has forgiven him. Though he supposes he’d *asked* for forgiveness from her in a way he hasn’t really from Adrien.

“I’m not happy about what you did,” Adrien says, “but it’s not worse than the rest of it. Someone you love who you thought was your best friend keeping secrets from you hurts. Even if they had a good reason.”

“Adrien,” Ladybug’s voice quavers on his name.

“I mean given my father turned out to be Hawk Moth I guess you were right to be so strict about our identities.”

“I really didn’t even consider that as one of my reasons. It’s just that,” she looks down and trails off.

“I don’t think this is a conversation you want to have in front of us Ladybug,” Nathalie says, “but I think it’s a conversation you two should have. Sitting here as someone who’s spoken to both of you, I know you’re very important to Adrien and he is to you however that ends up being. Don’t let things you haven’t said keep you apart.” The way it almost had the two of them he knows she means, “And don’t let us do that either.”

Stiffly Gabriel adds, “once we’ve removed certain secrets from the house I suppose it would be possible for Adrien to have a…limited amount of friends over provided they stay away from the Atelier and don’t do anything stupid. And as I said, I’m not going to try to take your

Miraculous. Trust me, I'm delighted to go back to the realms of ignorance when it comes to petty teenage drama."

Ladybug looks between them, "are you trying to invite the me behind the mask over to spend time with Adrien?"

"We're just informing you that Adrien's friends will be visiting on occasion." It seems safer than letting them frolic on the streets with who knows what Miraculous, "whoever that happens to include. Which we won't be attempting to check."

"If this is your apology to Adrien then it's a start."

"Is it?"

Ladybug's hands go to her hips, "I know you've been grieving Mr Agreste. And I know you'd scared of losing Adrien too. And maybe you think you're helping him by trying to make him perfect. But you're *not.* You're just forcing him to wear a mask all the time, because Chat Noir? He's all parts of Adrien you don't let out. And if you don't give your son more freedom and actually pay attention to him apart from when it comes to disciplining him and monetising him then you'd going to lose him after all."

Anger burns in his chest. He wants to yell at the impudent girl. To throw her out of this house.

But Nathalie's hand is on his knee holding him back. He has to play nice. For her. And for Adrien. And for himself.

And, a little voice whispers, he'd had no idea that Adrien was Chat Noir nor of how real the connection between Adrien and Nathalie rather than some parody of the bond with the mother Adrien missed. Because Adrien does miss Emilie, just the way Gabriel grieved her but that doesn't mean they can't love others.

Perhaps. And he hates this. Ladybug might have a point.

All he's achieved since Emilie died was losing his link with his son chasing a dream whose cost would likely have been the death of his son.

He hates it when the people dripping with condescending impractical morality turn out to be right.

"Is she right?" He asks his son.

Adrien doesn't meet his eyes. But he does mumble. "She is."

It makes him wonder what Chat Noir had told Ladybug or Adrien had told whichever friend of his is Ladybug.

"I'm giving you a chance Mr Agreste." Ladybug says, "what you do with it is up to you. But you've done a lot of damage ever since you chose to use that Miraculous. Maybe you should think about doing some good."

“Are you suggesting we should try to, what makes things up to Paris?” Nathalie asks.

“Don’t you think you should? And to Adrien of course?”

“Obviously we want to fix things with Adrien,” Nathalie says.

“And maybe therapy?”

“Therapy?” Gabriel can’t help but be perturbed. Needing therapy feels like an admission of being a failure. Or an American.

“Don’t you want to be a better father and, um, partner?”

“I suppose I do.”

“Then go and do that.” Ladybug says.

And with Nathalie there with him Gabriel thinks he might just do that.

Chapter End Notes

If you've been enjoying this fic and have been reading it as it goes along then I can only recommend despibcablebird's art for it on her instagram here and here.

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